



in too deep

KENNY WRIGHT *part one*

CONTENTS

[Foreword](#)

[Book 1](#)

[The Gold Club](#)

[Here](#)

[And then gone](#)

[Research](#)

[Schmoozing](#)

[Helping](#)

[Revelation](#)

[Perspective](#)

[The Video](#)

[Book 2](#)

[Setting Expectations](#)

[Our Roles](#)

[The Hotwife Husband](#)

[Moving Forward](#)

[Mr. and Mrs. Downing](#)

[Surveillance](#)

[Malibu](#)

[The Master Bedroom](#)

[Back to normal](#)

[About Kenny Wright](#)

[Also by Kenny Wright](#)

[*OceanofPDF.com*](#)

FOREWORD

I love thrillers. I love reading them. I love watching them. A good spy story is always fun, and I've always wanted to write a hotwife book with those themes, something along the lines of Gina Davis in *The Long Kiss Goodnight*.

This particular story has been in the works for a decade, and it's taken a lot of different forms. The beginning was always the same, but where it ended up is completely different than anything I'd originally conceived. At its core, though, was a story with a sexy wife was unlike anyone I've written before—strong, doesn't take shit, Tom Boy from the beginning, but with a very naughty side.

But unlike most of my books, the conflict didn't just boil out of the internal tension between husband and wife as they explore the journey of hotwifing. The real plot of this book was an external one, which required a lot more plotting, a lot of rewriting, and a lot more careful thought to make sure everyone's motivations made sense.

In a good thriller, these stories always seemed to go one direction and then end up somewhere else. My first "final" draft of *In Too Deep* told the story of Amanda and David, but the ending was just too clean. The plans in these types of stories never go off without a hitch, so I ditched the ending. This pushed it into a much longer book, and because of this, I'm splitting it

in two. You're holding Part 1. Part 2 is finished, so you won't have to wait very long, but I am going to space them out some.

I'd be remiss to thank my Patreon community for all of their feedback on this epic tale. This book is a product of their comments, critiques, questions, and curiosity as I posted it over many months back in 2024. If you are a member, thank you so much for your support in shaping this. Also, enjoy this version, as it's different in a few ways to what you've already read.

Special thanks to Ben Boswell, who sent me this idea so long ago. Shameless plug, but I posted his original, very short abstract on Patreon if you're curious where it all came from (it's VERY different).

I also need to thank my editor, Miles Evans, who has a lot more professional expertise in the world of mystery novels than I do. His insights were invaluable, and it's been a pleasure to work with him.

Finally, I must thank my wife as always for supporting me and my writing. Couldn't do it without her.

Enjoy the book!

OceanofPDF.com

BOOK 1

OCEANOFFPDF.COM

THE GOLD CLUB

I 'd never been inside a strip club before. I always told myself that I didn't need them. That I had a beautiful wife at home. That it was a waste of time and money. As soon as I stepped inside the Gold Club and was greeted with the wealth of tight, naked flesh, I saw the appeal. The blonde on the stage closest to us could have been in Playboy, and the dancer on the far stage was equally hot.

"David, what did I tell you? Totally worth it," Brandon Cruise said. "Top shelf pussy, right here."

The statement made me cringe, but I had to admit that he had a point. I looked across the open space of the strip club, scattered with armchairs, low tables, and couches. Booths lined the wall, but most of the patrons occupied the chairs right up against the stages.

"Looks like all the good spots are taken," Brandon said. "Come on, guys, follow me."

Brandon led our contingent into the room. I looked back at the group—a bunch of guys from Taiwan who looked about as wide-eyed as I felt. I took comfort in not being alone in my bewilderment.

We'd just closed a deal and it had been Brandon's idea to take all parties out for a celebration. I should have known that the celebration would have taken us to a place like this, but when everyone enthusiastically agreed, I wasn't going to be the wet blanket.

Besides, it had been two months since I'd seen my wife, Amanda, and I had to admit that part of me was ready to change things up beyond internet porn. I would just make sure not to mention this little trip to her.

These past couple months had been the worst I'd ever experienced in my life—definitely the worst of our three-year marriage. When the FBI had approached her about going undercover, neither of us were sure about it. I didn't like the idea, didn't want her to do it. Amanda was more thoughtful. Despite her impressive resume, she'd never worked undercover, but where I saw peril, Amanda saw a way to leave the world better off.

She promised that she'd only do it the one time—that she knew the details of the case—details she couldn't share with me due to clearance—and assured me that this was big. "If we can nail these guys, the world's going to be a much safer place," she'd said, her large blue eyes lighting up the way they always did when she talked about something she was passionate about. I could never talk her out of a thing when she got like that—and I never wanted to. It was that passion that I'd fallen in love with.

Amanda excelled at everything she put her mind to. I assured myself that UC work would be no different. Still, after two months without her and only a handful of quick phone calls, I missed the hell out of her.

"Check out the brunette over there," Brandon said to the group. He pointed to the far stage, where a dancer was starting a new set.

Brandon was right, she was the hottest yet, although I was biased since she reminded me of Amanda. They had the same near-black hair, same porcelain skin, same awesome body. She ascended the stage wearing a pair of black hot pants and a matching black halter top—neither of which did much to cover her creamy, unblemished skin. The small tribal tattoo on her tailbone was one of the few differences.

The MC announced her with the unlikely stage name of "Raven."

"Yeah, we should have sat over there," I said, getting into the spirit of the club.

A petite blonde with a tight little body came over to their table, wearing a see-through skirt and a bra that cradled her perky tits. "Evening, boys. I'm Valerie. Anyone want a dance?"

Brandon looked at the Taiwanese contingent. "What do you guys think? Want a spin?"

They nodded enthusiastically, drawing a wide grin from Brandon. To the dancer, he said, "How much?"

She took a seat in Brandon's lap, wrapping one arm around his shoulder. The other played with his collar. "Out here, it's \$20 a dance per person, but if you want to pay for a private dance, I can give y'all a group discount."

Brandon laughed. "I'm sure you could, Valerie. Let's stick to lap dances for now, for my Chinese friends." I cringed at the labeling, glancing at the Taiwanese. They didn't seem offended, or maybe they were just too enraptured by Valerie.

Brandon peeled off three twenties and passed them over to her.

Valerie just shrugged, took the money, and moved over to our first client.

"So what's your name, big boy?" she asked, straddling his lap

"Hao," he said, looking like he couldn't decide whether to ogle her or look away.

"How nice to meet you, Hao. I'm Valerie, and right now, I want you to stare at my tits."

Brandon laughed, nodding at me. *This is how you celebrate*, he seemed to say.

I looked past the strip tease, to the brunette dancer on the far side. I was just in time to watch her shimmy out of her hot pants, leaving her in a black g-string that looked great against her pale skin. Like Amanda, she had a perfect, heart-shaped ass—the kind of ass that defied her otherwise slender curves.

The tramp stamp just above her lower back dimples was sexy, I admitted to myself, even though it was a little trashy. Amanda wasn't into tattoos, and she didn't have a high opinion of women who got them in that particular spot.

The stripper knew how to move her body, that was for sure. She didn't do any acrobatics on the pole or anything, but instead danced with it like an intimate lover as the clothes hit the stage.

Her top went next, and I was surprised to see her full tits were real, hanging plump and round in a way that surgeons hadn't yet fully mastered. I'd been expecting implants, like most of the busty dancers here—but they appeared natural.

"Yeah, she's slammin'," Brandon said, following my eyes to the nearly naked brunette. "Bet she'd be fun to take into the back for a private dance."

I tore my gaze away from her, looking at Brandon. Coming to this strip club was bad enough. Going into the back for a private dance was out of the

question. Still, I was curious. "What happens during a private dance?"

"Depends on the girl, and how much you're willing to pay." He looked at the brunette as she sauntered up to the edge of stage, squatting next to a group of guys armed with singles. Pulling the g-string out so they could stuff it, I didn't doubt that she gave them a peek at her pussy in the process. "I bet that chick puts out, though."

As she gathered her clothing and climbed off stage, I couldn't help but think how uncanny the resemblance to Amanda was. If my wife wore a little more makeup and bought a pair of platform stilettos like that stripper, they could have been twins.

I closed my eyes and got my head right. Two months into this three-month undercover stint, I was seeing things. I swear, my neighbor's dog was starting to look like Amanda.

This woman's attitude was all wrong, anyway. The way she sauntered off the stage without bothering to cover herself, still wearing only the g-string and heels, was so brazenly sexual—so not my wife. Her tits were on full display as she crossed the room, hips swaying, everyone's eyes all over her body. Amanda would have been slapping everyone she could reach.

Instead, she met everyone's eyes with playful encouragement—*go ahead and look*, Raven seemed to suggest. *I don't mind*.

As she passed by the VIP section, roped off in velvet and filled with the wealthy, she seemed to meet one man's eyes in particular—a well-dressed man with great, salt-and-pepper hair and an equally amazing, groomed beard. A smile formed at the corners of her lips and was gone so fast I wondered if I'd imagined it. By the time she disappeared into the back room, I'd convinced myself that I had.

But the guy kept looking, his eyes lingering on the beaded curtain still swinging where Raven had passed. He rubbed his beard, lost in a calculating kind of thought. It didn't sit well with me.

Maybe it was the fact that Raven looked so much like Amanda that in my slightly inebriated state, I believed it *was* her, but I felt a wave of jealousy pass through me. That man clearly wanted to fuck the stripper, and as he took his seat and stared at nothing, I knew he was imagining doing just that.

It made me think of all the times that something like that had happened with Amanda. She'd always put them down with remorseless and reassuring

efficiency. Raven hadn't done that. Raven and that smile suggested that maybe, just maybe, this guy had a chance.

Jealousy stirred inside of me. It was a familiar sensation, one that usually arrived in those first few moments when a man hit on Amanda when he thought that we weren't together—before he was shut down. Envy, protectiveness, territorialism—things that I shouldn't feel because Amanda was the last person to tolerate it.

I watched for Raven for the rest of the night, but she never reemerged. Her shift must have been over. Or maybe she'd gone off with a client.

It tied my stomach up in knots.

I missed Amanda. That was the problem. Every other stripper I saw, I compared to Raven, which in turn made me compare them to Amanda.

Two months down. Only one more to go.

OceanofPDF.com

HERE

Raven haunted me. I dreamt about her at night, thought about her when wondering where my wife was. I just couldn't shake how much the stripper reminded me of my wife. I told myself over and over that it was only longing.

And yet I couldn't help but dwell on that smile she'd shared with the man in the VIP section. I thought about my Amanda sharing a smile like that with another man and felt vipers in my stomach every time.

I needed her back, but since I couldn't have that, I tried doing the next best thing. I pulled out our old photo albums, going through our history hoping it would help me forget that she wasn't there with me.

We'd been together for five years, and married for half of them. We met in law school, when we started dating. After, we both ended up doing a Department of Justice internship. She went into the FBI, I followed an even more bureaucratic career path. It worked. We got married and have been inseparable ever since. Until this undercover gig, anyway.

Amanda is a study in contrasts. Tall with long, dark brown hair, porcelain skin, and deep blue eyes, the first time that I met her, I remember thinking, *She's way out of my league*. At the time, I thought that she was a model.

She's also brilliant. Duke undergrad. Columbia law. As if she hadn't been intimidating enough with those hips and that deep cleavage, she was

smarter than me, and wittier than me, and far more driven than me. She was Army ROTC in college to give her a leg up. Took a tour as an MP in Afghanistan because she wanted to serve her country. After clerking for a Federal judge, she joined the FBI as a field agent. All of that by the time she turned 27, when we got married.

I picked up a photograph from the time we spent in Miami, when she was with the aforementioned Organized Crime/Drugs Division. She wore aviators, her dark hair loose and wind-swept across her face. She'd just busted a major drug shipment earlier in the day and we were out celebrating. This was before her supervisor had swooped in and taken all of the credit, when we thought this was the first big step to a major promotion. She was so happy. So proud. I missed her so much.

I threw myself into my own work, staying at the office well past normal hours. I started to hate going home to an empty house, to heating up leftovers and eating alone in front of the television while I worried about Amanda and where she was at that moment.

My mind filled in all kinds of horrible, dangerous details. The men she was going after were murderers. A gang. Or worse, a terrorist cell. I had no idea, and the truth was that she was more likely than not working some white collar connection—corrupt importers or money launderers. That got me thinking about her representing a sexy, competent lawyer, which was an equally troubling road to head down, if not for entirely different reasons.

But I didn't know any of the details, so I was left to wonder and worry.

One evening, I came home from work around ten at night and Amanda was there, sleeping in our bed. It was about a week after the Gold Club visit, and for a second, I wondered if the woman in my bed, wearing Amanda's satin pajamas, was a hallucination.

But she was warm when I snuggled up behind her, still wearing my socks, my suit, and the weariness of the day. She smelled like Amanda. And when she stirred at my touch, turning to look up at me, her dark hair spilling over her pillow, I saw my wife.

Before I could say a word, she turned and grabbed me, hugging me with an intensity that caught me off-kilter.

"Welcome home," I only just managed to choke out.. For the longest time she didn't say a thing. Didn't let go. We just stayed that way, her latched on to me like a shellfish to a rock, and me, still in my suit, half-sitting, half-leaning into her.

Eventually I said, "Can I at least change for bed?"

She shook her head. With her face pressed into my chest, I got a muffled, "Just give me *this*."

My heart soared. Amanda was *home*. And apparently I wasn't the only one missing our life together.

Without warning she moved her face from my chest to my ear, even as her hands began to tug my coat jacket off. "I'm not letting go of you, so let's compromise," she breathed huskily into my ear. "Let me help you. You're wearing way too many clothes..."

We were all over each other as she helped me strip, and I helped her, each article of clothing tossed carelessly somewhere in the dark room, one item after the other. All of it accompanied by Amanda's incessant giggling. It felt like nothing had changed between us. It felt like slipping back into a comfortable pair of jeans.

I forgot about these last months of absence, if only for a moment, getting lost in her touch, in her hands on my face, in the look of her eyes as they met mine in the dim light cast by the moon.

She had this grin, an expression where the left side of her mouth quirked up into a dimple that only showed itself when she smiled exactly this way. I called it her "I-know-what-you're-thinking" smirk.

She had that look on her face now.

Pushing me onto my back, she mounted me, possessively throwing her leg over my hip, reaching for my cock, eyes alight as she found me hard and ready. I groaned as she placed it against her pussy, so wet for me, so ready.

"Hey, David," she whispered against my ear. "It's good to be—" she paused and sighed as I bottomed out in her, "home."

"Are you sure?" I asked. "It's late and you were asleep, and—"

She cut me off with a scorching kiss. "Am I not *wet enough* for you to tell?" she said once we broke the kiss. We were still connected, joined. Not moving, aside from her flexing around me. "David, if there's one thing the last two months has taught me, it's that I'm always gonna want you." She flexed again, as if for emphasis. "And even if I have you, even just like this," she flexed again, "I'm always gonna want *more* of you."

My turn to kiss her. Deep, soft, putting all of my heart and the loneliness of the past eight weeks into it. Once we broke the kiss, she smirked in the

way her dimple showed again. I leaned in and kissed it. As I did so, she purred into my ear, “Now let’s make up for lost time.”

I slept well for the first time in over two months. Amanda had come home.

SHE WAS STILL ASLEEP when I got out of bed, barely stirring when I rose. I let her sleep.

Downstairs, I brewed us a pot of coffee, then went further and made us some bacon and waffles. I called in to work, took the day off. We had so much to catch up on.

Amanda finally came down close to 9:30. She’d always been an early riser. She never slept in. Never. But when she finally dragged herself downstairs, scratching her head and yawning, hair still mussed from sleep, she looked like she could go another 12 hours.

She further announced her presence by gathering me in a bear hug from behind, interrupting my getting the last of the waffles onto a plate. “Mmm, smells great, honey,” she said, her words muffled by the part of my upper back into which she had pressed her face.

“I was going to bring it up to you.” I turned into her hug, smiling down at her. “Breakfast in bed.”

Emotion moved through her. Her eyes shimmered. “This is...perfect.”

I poured her a mug of coffee, setting it gingerly before her as she settled in at the table. “Did you get enough rest?”

“No.” She laughed. “But it’s a start.”

“I’m sorry, I didn’t know you’d be back yesterday. I would have come home earlier.”

“I didn’t know either until the last minute. It was a sudden kind of thing. Besides, I wouldn’t want to take you away from your girlfriend,” she said with a smirk. “I wouldn’t dream of it.”

“Don’t worry about that. I’m sure the three of us can work something out.” It felt good to joke with Amanda again, although while she did laugh, the mirth didn’t quite reach her eyes. “So you’re home for—”

“Just a couple of days,” Amanda said. My heart sank even though I’d suspected as much. “Things are still in play.”

This was temporary. She'd have to go back. "But you're safe?"

Amanda nodded. "As safe as I can hope to be."

I worried for her, but she was putting on a brave face, so I would, too. "Can you talk about it at all?"

She shook her head. She started cutting her waffle, focusing on that more than on me. "Sorry, Babe." She waved her knife in the air. "Let's talk about something else. How are you?"

"Lonely." I laughed to try and clear the tension, but it fell flat. "I miss you so much."

She set her utensils down, reached for my hand and fixed me with a compassionate stare. "I know. I miss you, too."

I heard the *but*, loud and clear. She'd started this thing, she'd finish it, and we weren't even going to discuss it.

"Eat up. We can get caught up when you're done.."

Amanda picked a waffle slice in her fingers—her nails painted fire engine red, I noticed—and popped it into her mouth. Then she rose and walked around to my side of the table. "I think I've got my strength back enough to...catch up."

Her hands went to the buttons that ran down the front of her pajama top.

"Oh," I said. Amanda was usually never this forward. She unfastened the first button of her top and her deep cleavage spilled into view. Something about the black satin of her PJs against her creamy skin triggered something in me. I stood, trapping her against the table, and kissed her passionately in what felt like the first time in forever—last night notwithstanding. She was warm and soft, tasting like maple syrup and toothpaste. I wanted to laugh and cry all at once. I wanted to devour her whole.

She placed her hands on my head, pulling me back long enough to look me in the eyes. "I missed you so much. I missed *this* so fucking much."

My wife was no stranger to the F-bomb. She was surrounded by it during her time working in the field, not to mention Afghanistan, but the way it rolled off her tongue here felt different.

Her gaze burned into me as she opened her shirt and let me drink in her tits, drawing me away from my questions. They were so full, so soft, so large on her otherwise slender body. And in that moment, her nipples had swollen into high, hard pebbles that begged me to notice them as she pulled the shirt off and tossed it to the floor.

It was as if last night either hadn't happened, or it did, but only seemed to have lit her fuse, rather than satiate her. *I'm always gonna want you*, her words from last night rang again in my head. *I'm always gonna want more of you*.

I grabbed her tits, bending down to suck on those nipples before she reached down and dragged my own shirt over my head.

We fumbled with our pajama bottoms after that. She went for mine as I went for hers, getting tangled in our limbs. We laughed and she deferred to me, placing her hands on the lip of the table and lifting her ass up so I could pull her silken PJs off.

Her stomach was as flat as ever—if not a little more toned than before. Her thighs were taut, her hips round. But it was her pussy that I couldn't stop looking at. Her pussy that I barely recognized. Where she'd always kept a trimmed thatch of dark pubes, she was completely bare.

Seeing that sent fire through my gut. The implications set explosions off in my world. I looked up at her, seeking an explanation, but she was already quick at work on my own pajama bottoms. She was hungry for sex. Explanations would have to wait.

"You're so hard, baby." She took me out, and I was. I couldn't help it. Not with the long and lean naked body of this brunette babe right in front of me, legs spread, shaved pussy moist for cock.

I stepped up to her and together, I slid easily into her pussy. *Welcome home*, I thought as she molded around me. A perfect fit.

"Yes," she sighed. "Oh, yes..."

She held me close, a hand on my shoulder, the other behind her, bracing herself. I leaned over her, kissing her neck and nuzzling her ear as I fucked her. She breathed hotly, her moans encouraging me.

At first, I held back because it had been so long that I didn't want to hurt her. But when she moaned for me to take her harder, I happily obliged.

"Yes! Like that. That's what I need, baby," she said. This was new, too. She never talked much during sex. "Welcome...me...home...yes!"

My cock swelled at her words. I could feel it grow inside her, harder and harder with each plunge. I found purchase on the table behind her, dug my feet in, and pounded her into the surface of the table as my excitement spilled over.

"Yes! Come, David! Oh, fuck, come! I want to feel you inside me. *Please!*"

I couldn't have stopped myself even if I'd wanted to. I was already there, my balls slapping against her buttocks, feeling the unfamiliar grip of her smooth pussy lips. I rammed myself deep, then exploded with a long, drawn out groan.

Amanda held me close, pulling me back into a long, hard hug as she drew ragged, post-orgasmic breaths. I pulled back to rest my head on hers, looking at her. "You sure you can't just stay? Forget all this undercover nonsense?"

She smiled warily. "You'll make it worth my while?"

"Always."

"How about I make these next couple of days worth your while?" she said. "Then you'll have something to think about when I'm gone again."

"Let me text my girlfriend. Tell her to lay low for a couple of days, 'cause the Fuzz is in town and hasslin' me."

"Ha!" Eyes alight, she pushed me back, slipped off the table and directed me to take her place. I wasn't sure what her game was, but let myself be moved. My cock had already begun to soften, wet with our combined juices.

"Think you can go another round?" she asked. She didn't wait for my answer. Sinking to her knees, she took my cock into her mouth and sucked down on it. She'd never done that before—never blown me after sex. If the taste bothered her, she didn't seem to react now.

That alone would have gotten me hard again. But her blowjob was incredible. They say that absence makes the heart grow fonder, but they should also add that it makes the blowjobs even better. Holding me up with her right hand, she attacked me with her mouth, bobbing up and down with a ferocity I didn't recognize.

I was hard less than a minute into her onslaught, but it felt so good that I didn't want to stop her. Amanda had other plans.

She dragged my cock through her soft cleavage as she rose. "Ready for round two?"

She pushed me onto my back on the kitchen table and climbed over me. Once again, I was enveloped by her familiar-yet-unfamiliar pussy.

"This for me?" I asked, touching her bare mound, now completely hairless.

"You like it?" she asked, rolling her hips along my length.

"Yeah, it's sexy."

She pushed her hand down between her legs, grabbing my fingers and directing them against her clit. “Feels sexy, too.” And then she giggled. “See? I’m not *really* the Fuzz...”

“No,” I said as I rubbed her clit, now completely exposed to me. “Definitely not.” As she bounced in my lap, I looked around and laughed. We were still in the kitchen. We hadn’t been like this since we were newlyweds.

She leaned forward, placing her hands on my shoulders—which crushed her tits together into a mouthwatering sight. Her eyes were closed. Her head tilted to one side, causing her dark hair to spill over a smooth shoulder that I swore was more tanned than the last time I’d seen her. This is the image that I wanted to remember on the lonely nights to come, when Amanda was out there risking her life and I was alone in our home in the suburbs.

But instead, the perfection of the moment was robbed from me as Amanda slipped off the table and pulled me up. “Do it from behind, so you go deeper and harder.” It was another new development. Amanda always thought that doggystyle was demeaning and would never go for that. But there she was, both hands reaching for the counter, her long legs spread, her luscious ass ripe and inviting. And just above it, I saw the thing that would change everything: there, on her lower back, was a swirling, tribal tattoo inked in black.

I touched the tattoo, tracing the sharp swirls, like black flames. This close, I realized that they formed a perching raven, tail feathers down, head looking back. I felt numb.

Was I dreaming this whole thing? It wasn’t the craziest of theories. My wife shows up, unannounced, in bed last night, then comes down raring to go like an oversexed newlywed. My subconscious connects the stripper from the Gold Club to my wife, and voila, here we were.

And yet, it didn’t feel like a dream. It felt fantastic, the way Amanda fucked me, rolling her hips back into me as I held her hips, using her hips like a...stripper...

“You like it?”

“I...I...” I stuttered. “I don’t understand.”

“It’s fake,” she said. “But pretty realistic, huh?”

In a sense, that comforted me. Amanda hadn’t gone out and marked her body like a stripper—she was just pretending to be one. My insides shriveled. I couldn’t pretend that I hadn’t seen this design. The evidence

had been piling up against me since I'd walked into that club a week ago, and I could no longer deny it.

"What's your cover, Amanda? When you go back out there, who do you become?"

She sighed, pressing back, hips still. "You need to drop this. You know I can't—"

"I saw you. I know."

I felt her stiffen.

"I was in the Gold Club last week. I saw you."

Amanda was silent a long time, unmoving until she abruptly straightened up and turned around. She didn't look my way, didn't even bother grabbing her clothing as she went to the sink and with what felt like practiced deliberation, poured herself a glass of water. I caught a glimpse of Raven once again, so comfortable with her nudity.

I had expected her to deny it.

She didn't bother.

"I wish you hadn't seen that." She took a draw of her water, her back to me. I just stared at her naked back, at the tattoo, at the teasing glimpse of sideboob.

My stomach sank at the confirmation. Incredibly, my cock didn't sink quite so fast. Embarrassed, I lowered myself into a kitchen chair and chided myself for even getting slightly excited by the thought of my wife as a *stripper*. Even that thought sent a jolt through me. I masked it by pinching the bridge of my nose between my fingers.

"So...that was you," I said lamely.

She didn't respond, but something seemed to give way inside her. In an instant "Raven" was wiped away. Amanda's head went down, her shoulder blades rose, and she reached out a hand to either side, bracing herself on the counter top.

I squeezed my eyes shut. *No tears.*

When I opened them, Amanda was finally pulling on her pajama top, slowly buttoning it up to conceal her nudity. "We can't have this conversation."

"Of course we can't," I said, my voice flat and unrecognizable in my own ears. "I know the score." And I really did. But none of what had plagued me since the night I saw Amanda at the club had anything to do with the dangers of undercover work. Instead, all kinds of crazy shit was

going through my head. Amanda grinding in some guy's lap, naked except for a g-string, her body shimmering in the low light of the strip club's backroom—

"Please, honey. Don't go there." Her words drifted to me, as if they'd traveled from far, far away.

I squeezed my eyes shut again. I *heard* Amanda, but I saw *Raven*, going down on her knees, taking a customer's throbbing cock in her mouth—

"I can take care of myself. You need to know that."

"That doesn't make this any easier." I risked a look up at her, but instead saw Raven on her stomach, legs splayed as another man rammed his enormous cock into her—

"Hey."

I shook my head and blinked to clear the image, and suddenly she was there, *really* there before me, Amanda, beside me, sitting in a chair. She took my hands in hers, her touch warm and familiar and *real*.

And that confusing mixture of crippling jealousy and heart-pounding adrenaline slowly faded.

But not fully.

"Look, I know that this is hard."

I shook my head silently as she said it. *The speech*.

"And I really do wish you didn't know." I looked at her again. Her eye contact, usually so startlingly direct, wavered. My wife didn't usually do timid or apologetic, especially when it came to the demands of her job, and she was neither now. I watched as she visibly steeled herself, and when she repeated herself, "I *really do* wish you didn't know," there was the steely Amanda who was so good at her job. Her tone made it clear: this was hard *for me*. If there was regret, it was that I knew. Not at what she was doing. "But this is important, David. This is Big."

I heard the capitalization of "Big". I saw the fire in her eyes, the one that burned with a sense of purpose. This is what made Amanda such a good agent. This is what drove her.

It helped—a little, anyway. This was a job. A means to an end. Amanda was still Amanda.

I let my heart do the talking. "I don't want to lose you to this."

She squeezed my hands. "You're not getting rid of me that easily. It's just my job. I can separate my real life from my cover. You have to trust me."

“Oh come on. You’ve got to admit it’s a lot.”

“I do. But if you trust me, you understand that I need to do this.”

“Trust is a two-way street.”

She cocked her head. “Meaning?”

“You ask for trust. Maybe try giving it.”

Her eyes narrowed. When she spoke, her voice was cold. “Don’t be a child, David. You knew what you were signing up for.”

“And then there’s you conveniently showing up not long after I was likely spotted by your surveillance team at the Gold Club.”

She continued to gaze at me. Not saying anything. I knew Amanda. She was thinking before she spoke. Something I wasn’t always the best at. She had probably already mapped out the different ways this conversation could go.

“Two days to confirm whether or not I’d seen you,” I continued. “And if I had, to make sure I’d keep my yap shut about it. That right?”

She didn’t flinch, but I knew that one had landed. We rarely fought. I’m hardly the confrontational type. But I’m a lawyer, too. Plus, when we fight, I’m usually the wild card. I’m the same way in court. Which is one reason why I almost never wind up in court. It’s also the main reason my brilliant, analytical wife doesn’t win *all* of our fights. I said I wasn’t confrontational, but nobody likes a doormat.

She pursed her lips and looked at me for what felt like a long time. I let my words hang between us. When she eventually spoke, instead of blowing up at me, instead of staying icily above my “antics,” she took a new tack.

“Alright. Look. These are *very* bad men. I’m in a position to stop them. We’re *close* on this, I *swear* to you, and even telling you that much is too much, but I *do* trust you, honey, I *do*.” Her look turned pleading. Which was something to see, because Amanda didn’t *plead*. “I cannot let this go. Not now. I *have* to see this thing through.”

And right there was the Amanda I knew. Suddenly, I understood why she’d do God alone only knew how many things so utterly counter to what she always stood for to bust the bad guys.

“Okay,” I made a face. The words coming hard. “I think I can understand that. But this conversation isn’t over. And I won’t be put off forever.”

Amanda nodded. It looked like it came hard for her, too.

I helped her out, saying, “For the time being let’s just say I’m giving you the same sort of immunity deal UCs routinely cut with the DOJ.”

She suppressed a grin. “Would that be ‘transactional,’ or ‘use,’ Counselor?”

“It’s a new type.”

She closed the distance between us, wrapping her arms around me. “A new type, huh?”

“Yep.”

“Does this ‘new type of immunity’ have a name?”

“Yeah. It’s called, ‘Your Husband Is Patient and Loving, But Not a Fool’ Immunity.”

Amanda smiled, but it was strained. “That’s quite a mouthful.”

I stood there, her arms around my neck, recalling the way she’d smiled at the men at the Gold Club, and all the scintillating promise that came with it. I buried it deep before I ended up blurting something that I shouldn’t have. Amanda saw my face cloud. She was too observant to miss it.

She stroked my forehead. Then one cheek. Then the other. As if she could caress away the frown lines, the concern, the fear writ large across my face.

“You know, there will always be things I have to do undercover that I would never do otherwise,” she said as she continued to stroke my face. “But I know they have to be done. And I have to be okay with that. When I finish, I take all those things and I lock them in a box with my cover, and I don’t look back. But to do that—to do my job—” she paused, lips pressed together, chin trembling. “I need to know that you’ll be there when I do return to my life. You *are* my life. I love you, David.”

“I know. I love you, too.”

Pulling me in for a kiss, she said, “I’m home for two whole days. Let’s not waste one more second of them.”

AND THEN GONE

I sometimes have these mundane dreams where I go through my regular routine—get up, go to work, read reports, sit in meetings—but it's all a dream. There's nothing particularly fantastic about them other than their utter banality; it was just like real life, only in a dream.

The next two days felt like one of those dreams. Amanda and I did all the things we always did together before her assignment. We cooked dinner. We cleaned up. We made love. We watched old episodes of *Castaway* on our streaming service.

I took those two days off, so not everything was normal, but it still felt more like a long weekend than anything else.

But it wasn't a long weekend. We didn't bring up the undercover assignment, yet it was still ever present, the giant, white fucking elephant in an otherwise empty room. Every time I thought about it, I felt this unsettling loss of control.

We nibbled around the edges of it. Certain things were still kosher to talk about. "How are things with you and Julia? She still holding a grudge?"

Julia was another agent on Amanda's team, and as Amanda told it, had wanted the undercover assignment before the higher-ups decided that Amanda was a better fit.

"Well, she's still a raging bitch," Amanda said with a laugh. "But she's my acting handler, so you know, we're playing nice."

Armed with what I knew about Amanda's assignment, it occurred to me why Amanda had been chosen over Julia. "It's not easy being told you're not hot enough."

In my head, the statement had been borderline. As I watched my wife process it with a grimace, though, I winced.

"Sorry," I said.

Her face was a mask. "Uh huh."

I should have left it there. Thing was, that got me thinking. Julia was actually very attractive in an LA kind of way. She had dirty, but clearly dyed, blonde hair, fake tits, collagen enhanced lips, and a tan that was rich and ever-present. In short, she was the perfect stripper. In light of what I now knew about the nature of the assignment, I wondered why she hadn't been picked after all.

"Actually, seems like Julia would have been ideal playing a... ideal for this cover."

Amanda just looked at me, like she could will me to shut up about this with a stare. She knew me well enough to know that I wouldn't. "Maybe five years ago," Amanda said.

The snarky response wasn't like Amanda, but maybe I was imagining it. After all, she was right. Julia was attractive, but in her late-thirties, she was on the older end of the girls I'd seen dancing at the Gold Club.

Seeming to realize how out-of-character she sounded, Amanda added, "Bradley made the decision based on some of the intel we have from our man inside."

Bradley Hirsch was the agent in charge of this investigation and Amanda's immediate boss. She didn't elaborate on what the intel was, and I was too unsettled to ask. "Honestly, though, I don't think Bradley likes Julia all that much."

"Why do you think that?"

Amanda shrugged. "Body language, mostly. I can't really put my finger on it, but there's tension between those two." She cracked a smile. "Either they hate each other, or they're fucking."

There was the casual use of that word again, forcing me to consider the type of company she was probably keeping.

I didn't call her on it, though. I let it go.

AS TROUBLED AS JUST THINKING about the sexual aspects of her assignment made me, the sex was out of this world. I tried to tell myself that this was entirely because of the long months of abstinence. I'm sure that was a large part of it. But there were times when Amanda was gyrating in my lap, her hands on my shoulders, her long, dark hair spilling around her bare shoulders, that I couldn't help thinking about her Raven persona.

And that got me thinking about what else she had to do as Raven. She did lapdances, for sure, which would have put her topless and alone in a room with a stranger. Did she shimmy out of her panties? She'd shaved her pussy bald for the first time in her life; had she done that because guys would expect a stripper to look that way?

There were darker thoughts, too. Like how did she get the job in the first place. Amanda had no experience stripping. The FBI had someone inside, but did he or she have enough pull to get her the job? Or did she have to do something wilder to land it? These ideas made me queasy. Mentally, I squirmed away from them, yet there was something else there. Something I didn't care to even admit.

So I didn't.

Instead, I focused on the sex. The reconnection. I was determined to give her something to look forward to returning to that was more than just a familiar home and open arms.

"Yes! Oh, yes, David!" Amanda panted as I rutted away. She was on her back, long legs wrapped around me as I took her. We'd been at it all morning and were covered in sweat. I'd already come once, but her cries were forecasting a second.

"You feel so good, baby," I said, groaning as she pressed her heels into my lower back. Had she always done that? Or was that a new trick of hers?

"I missed this," she said, her voice tight. She clutched the bedsheets on either side of her, anchoring her to the mattress as I fucked her harder. "Give it to me. Give. It. To. Me!"

In that hazy moment before orgasm, I imagined her in this same position with another man—a man who knew her as Raven the Stripper, not Amanda my wife. For an instant, I saw her as Raven, too, with a body built for fucking and a carefree attitude that welcomed it all.

I can take care of myself, she'd told me.

But what did that mean? How far would she go to make everyone believe that she was nothing more than a stripper?

It should have disgusted me. It should have sucked all the eroticism out of the moment. I should have gone soft inside her. Instead, I came. Hard. With her heels guiding me, I slammed into her and released whatever fucked up energy I'd been storing over the past couple days—for the past couple months.

Amanda moaned with me, feeling me fill her. She arched against me, pressing her tits against my chest. Jaw clenched, eyes closed, she came with me.

Even in my euphoric state, part of me wondered whether she was really *with me*? I buried that insecurity, even as my cock flagged and my body finally gave in to the fatigue. I rolled off her, both of us breathing hard.

"That was amazing," Amanda said. Her fingers touched mine between our heaving, sweat-slick bodies.

"Something worth coming home to?"

"Just one more reason, yeah." Amanda laughed. "When this thing is done, I'm going to have to come up with excuses to be away more if my homecomings will be like this."

"Please no," I said. The tone was light, but we both heard the heaviness in it.

Amanda rolled onto me, kissing me softly. Her body felt so good. Had she always felt this soft? This smooth? Or had she picked up a trick or two from the other strippers?

For a moment, I thought she'd say something about her assignment—some form of reassurance to me that the job was just a job. But we'd already had that conversation, and she seemed determined not to have it again. "So today, I was thinking we do dinner and a movie. I heard that theater finally opened up. The one that serves wine and beer."

"Oh, you mean the one that'll cost \$100 for the two of us?"

"So are you saying that I'm not worth it?"

I brushed her hair back. "Dinner and a movie sounds awesome." A date, like old times, was exactly the thing that we needed.

But when she hopped out of bed and headed for the shower, I couldn't take my eyes off the tattoo on her lower back. The raven. The reminder of where she'd go tomorrow. The queasiness was back, and I realized that

nothing could hold it at bay forever—not sex, not dinner and a movie, not anything.

AND AS FAST and surprising as Amanda's return had been, so did it come to an end. We were at the front door. She had a single roller bag with everything she needed. She wore a pair of cropped yoga pants and a long and loose tank top with a built in sports bra. She could have been headed to the gym or the yoga studio.

But she wasn't. She was going back undercover, part of which involved taking her clothes off in a room filled with leering men. And that's just the part of the cover that I knew about. It made me jittery.

"I love you, David." She hugged me tightly, then pulled back to look me in the eyes. We'd said that to one another thousands of times—such a simple, throw-away phrase. This time, I felt the weight of its meaning.

She needed reassurance. She needed to know that after she did whatever she needed to do, I'd be here for her when she came home. The last thing she needed was to worry about me and my state of mind. That helped me put on a brave face.

"I love you, too, sweetheart," I said. The term of endearment felt so incongruous with where she was going. "Be safe."

Her face began to set into the hard-edged, stubborn expression I was so familiar with. This was the Amanda that I knew so well. "I will. Don't worry."

I pressed my forehead to hers, holding her close. "I'll be here. Go do your thing. Get those bad guys."

"Thanks, baby." We shared one final kiss and I watched her climb into the cab that was waiting.

I recognized the driver, a guy from her team. I didn't know his name. He saw me looking and nodded. Surely he knew where he was taking Amanda, so what must he have thought about me, the husband who supports his wife—

No, I can't go there, I thought, although I didn't even know what I meant by 'there'.

I waved at her one last time as the cab pulled away and suddenly I was alone again.

OceanofPDF.com

RESEARCH

They say ignorance is bliss, and they're fucking right. I wish that I'd never walked into the Gold Club with Brandon. I wish I could have kept on thinking that Amanda's assignment had been some kind of white collar thing, tracking bad guys in boardrooms, not back rooms.

But I couldn't. The truth was out there like a stain that I couldn't stop looking at, and wouldn't go away. I struggled through the days alone, trying to focus on work, trying to put my head down and make it through one day at a time, but I couldn't. Not when my mind kept drifting to thoughts of what Amanda was doing *right now*.

Nights were the hardest because they held the worst possibilities. She could be at the strip club—she inevitably *would* be at the strip club on many of those nights—taking her clothes off on a stage. Or dancing for someone privately. Or going back to someone's house to squeeze them for information.

That was the thing I needed to keep reminding myself. These were all means to an end. She was a tool for justice, for good, so that made everything just and good. Right?

Besides, she was still a federal agent. There was a line by the very nature of her job description. Or so I told myself. In truth, I had no fucking clue if there was or not, and the more it gnawed at me, the more I realized

how little I knew about undercover operations. So I called my buddy, Ty Lawrence, to improve that understanding.

Amanda and I had gone to law school with Ty before he decided to drop out and join the police academy. He was a brilliant guy and had quickly excelled through the ranks of LAPD. By the time life took me and Amanda to Los Angeles, Ty was already a Sergeant. He'd worked more than a few undercover jobs during his time with a special crimes division, so I figured he'd be able to give me some context around what Amanda was doing.

But first, we just shot the shit. It had been too long since we'd had a beer.

"How you doing, man?" Ty said. He was an East Coaster like me and Amanda, but the years had converted him into a true LA detective. He wore his tan well, his thick, sandy hair looked like he'd just stepped off the beach, and unlike the stereotypical television cop, he was still in peak physical condition.

"I'm alright, I'm alright," I said, when I was anything but alright. "You?"

"I can't complain. We've been busting our balls cracking down on this new designer drug that's been floating around—'jazz'," he said in air quotes. "But this is LA. Anyone really surprised? And if I can make a good impression, well, Lieutenant Murty's retiring next month." He grinned. "It's a long shot, I may have an outside chance."

"Lieutenant before you turn thirty. Impressive."

"Not bad for a Columbia dropout from the Bronx, eh?"

I laughed. "Modesty doesn't suit you. Feels weird."

"And what about you?" Ty asked. "Married life treating you alright?"

"You know Amanda. I think you can probably answer that one as well as I can."

Ty nodded. "That chick's one-of-a-kind. *Especially* out here in LA. I date around, you know, but all these chicks are so superficial. It's all about appearances for them."

"That never was a problem for you before. You looking to settle down now?" Ty had always been something of a man-whore back in college. When Amanda and I were busy falling in love, Ty had a steady rotation of girls passing through the bedroom.

"You know, gets old after a while." He grinned. "Or maybe you have no fucking clue. You've been hitched for forever."

I thought of the wild sex I'd just had with Amanda during her two-day hiatus and couldn't help smiling, no matter the uncomfortable circumstances surrounding that. "Like I said, you know Amanda. I really can't complain."

"Go ahead and rub that shit in." Ty laughed, signaling for another beer. "So what's up? You wanted to know about UC work?"

My heart pulsed. Now that we were here, I questioned whether I wanted to know after all. Let sleeping dogs lie and all that.

But I found myself saying, "Yeah. You've done it before, right?"

"Sure. Did a stint with vice. Then a longer one with narco. Great for the resume, hard as fuck on the head."

"Yeah? How so?"

Ty took a swig of his beer. If he was bothered by the past, he didn't show it. He might as well have been discussing what he had for dinner last night. "Well, to do it right, you have to get into the head of whoever you're trying to infiltrate, you know? So, like, if I'm busting some drug pushers, I need to act like a user. I need to understand their needs; their desperation. So by the time I go up and make the buy, I believe I need the next hit bad."

"But it's all fake," I said. I didn't like the implications that this had on Amanda at all.

"Yeah, 'course it is. But it's still exhausting to do. Slipping into those personas doesn't come without a toll. I don't know how guys who do that all the time manage to stay sane, honestly."

"Do they?"

"What do you mean?"

I asked, "Do they ever, you know, slip too deep into the role?"

"Yeah, it's happened. I've heard a story or two about a NARC who developed a problem with substances. But that's only the case with deep cover shit, and mostly that's handled by the Feds."

My body went cold.

He said, "Why the sudden interest, anyway?"

Ty could have sucker punched me in the face and I wouldn't have been more stunned. His question yanked me out of it, but I still had no strategy for answering it. "Um..."

"Amanda working UC?" His smile suggested that it was a joke, but I guess my expression gave the truth away.

“No shit! So now, you’re all worried about her.” He nodded. “Things are starting to make sense.”

“I can’t talk about it, Ty. You know that. This is, like, really, *really* off the record.”

“So tell me more. What do you know?” he said, leaning in.

“I can’t.”

“Then I can’t help you out, friend. I need context to give you some.”

I thumbed the condensation on my pint glass, tracing an A before wiping it away. I really shouldn’t do this. This was so out-of-bounds it was crazy. Looking up at Ty and his open, you-can-tell-me-anything expression, I knew that I was going to. It wasn’t so much that I trusted him—although I did trust him—more like I needed to share this with *someone*, and Ty was as good a someone as any.

“I don’t know much about the case, but...” My face started to heat up. “...she’s working as a dancer.” I regretted telling him almost immediately. He went all wide-eyed, like I’d just told him that Christmas had been rescheduled and was now tomorrow.

Ty blinked, processed, and said, “A dancer? Like, she’s undercover as a stripper?”

I nodded. I didn’t trust myself to speak.

“Get the fuck out of here. Amanda is stripping? As in, *summa cum laude* from Columbia Amanda? The girl who once punched a guy out for touching her ass Amanda?”

“Wasn’t that you?” I pointed out.

“Yeah, the one and only.”

We shared a laugh.

He leaned in. “Where is she ‘dancing’?”

“Oh no, I’m not telling you that. You just want to go and stare at her tits.”

Ty laughed. “Oh come on, can you blame me?”

“This was a total mistake. This shit is serious, man. Her life could be on the line here.”

Ty nodded, getting more serious. “You’re right, you’re right. I’m still, you know, in total disbelief. These guys must be some bad people for her to do that.”

“You’re not really helping me deal with this,” I said tightly.

“Sorry.” His sigh was deep and came out like a whistle. “Okay, so seriously, where is she, erm, dancing? Maybe I know something about it.”

“You just happen to be an expert on strip clubs in LA?”

“Hey, I’m LAPD. Maybe not an expert, but let’s just say I’ve got working knowledge.”

I thought about telling him, but decided against it. “No, I don’t think so. I’ve already said way too much. What I really want to know was...” I tried off, not sure how to ask this next part? My heart was beating so fast I thought I might have a heart attack.

Ty saved me. “You want to know if she’s fucking guys as part of her cover.”

My gut clenched. Yup, that was it exactly. “Not exactly that. Just, you know, whether that was something that happened undercover.”

“Ah, hypotheticals. Safe.” Ty nodded. “I think this will require a couple of shots of Jameson.” He flagged our server down and ordered us a round.

“I’m not going to like this answer, am I?”

Ty shrugged. “You asked. Still want to know?”

My stomach churned. “Might as well. I’ll think the worst now if you don’t.”

Ty nodded. “Well, it all depends. They frown on...sexual liaisons—especially the FBI—because it could potentially be used against them in court. Typically, UC agents are protected from testifying, and their actions are mostly cleaned up. But it happens. Especially when going deep.”

I nodded. I felt like I’d just chugged battery acid.

“But hey, that doesn’t mean that’s what’s going on,” Ty said reassuringly. “Just because it *can* happen doesn’t mean jack. Amanda’s a badass. I’m sure she’s figured out a way to keep things above board.”

“Yeah,” I said robotically. “Thanks.”

Our shots arrived. I didn’t think I’d be able to stomach the Irish whiskey, but I was sure as fuck willing to risk it. It went down like fire, but fire was better than the queasy sensation I’d been feeling a moment earlier.

“How long’s her assignment?”

“It’s been a couple months.” Things started to fuzz around the edges. “About one more left.”

“That’s rough, man. But try not to dwell too on it much. The Feds do that shit better than anyone, and you know Amanda—she’d only do this if it was important.”

It wasn't really comforting at all, but I nodded like it was. "Thanks, Ty."

"Hey, no problem. Give me a call if you ever need to talk."

I rose, feeling shaky on my legs. "I will."

"Seriously, man," he said, standing with me. "Don't keep all this shit bottled up. I'm your guy. Whenever."

I made eye contact with him for the first time, seeing a true friend. I had no intention of ever having this conversation again with another living being, but if I did, Ty was at the top of my list—maybe the only person on that list.

"Thanks, Ty. I'll keep that in mind." We even shared a man-hug on the matter.

"Oh, and David. I'm sure you know this, but you need to stay away from that club. You need to let her do her thing without meddling. Trust in her ability to take care of herself."

"Of course," I said. Thing was, until that moment, it hadn't even occurred to me to visit. "I'm not an idiot."

"Good."

As I picked my way out into the warm LA night and hailed a cab, all I could think about was Amanda dancing at the Gold Club. Was she there tonight? It was a Friday. It would be crowded. I could blend right in.

I'm not an idiot.

"Where to, mister?" the cab driver asked as I slid in. It smelled like vinyl and Pine-Sol.

For one weak moment, I really considered telling him to take me to the Gold Club. Instead, I gave him my home address and off we were into the warm night. I was drunk, but not *that* drunk.

SCHMOOZING

I'll be honest, I was proud of myself for not going to the strip club. In the unsympathetic light of Saturday morning, I realized what a huge mistake that would have been.

Ty said that I needed to trust Amanda to do her thing. On paper, sure. She was a warrior. I believed that she was capable of doing anything that she put her mind to.

But there was one issue that this approach overlooked—our marriage. Amanda had always been fiercely independent, but she wasn't single anymore.

I played my conversation with Ty over and over again in my head. Could she be spreading her legs undercover? *It depends.* And, *it happens.* And, *especially when going deep.* None of that helped calm my fear or allay the slowly spreading sense of betrayal. Then again, what did I expect when I sought out those answers? For him to tell me that infiltrating the criminal underworld was as easy as picking flowers in a spring meadow?

When Amanda and I had fucked the last time she'd visited, she was hungry for it, more passionate than she'd been in ages. Had she learned some new tricks on the job? Had she developed a taste for a harder, rougher sort? She'd shaved her pussy. Was that just to accommodate her small, stripper g-strings? Or because that's what her clients expected?

Fuck, there seemed to be no way to escape this downward spiral. Around and around I went in my head, going insane. I needed something to distract me. I tried the movies, but I don't think I could have told you the plot. I tried video games, hoping the run and gun mechanics of *Call of Duty* could take my mind off things. Instead, I ended up getting rolled over and over because I couldn't focus. So I shut that off, too.

I discovered the Gold Club's website, which wasn't exactly the pinnacle of modern web design. Flash animations, animated gifs, an insipid techno beat, browsing the site was like being transported back to the early 2000s.

After rifling through PDF cocktail menus and a poorly executed virtual tour of the club itself, I found what I was looking for. Sort of. A schedule of dancers for the next week, with a note at the bottom to check back weekly. No photos of the dancers were shown, but reading the name *Raven* was enough to tighten my chest every time. She worked four nights a week with a couple of day time shifts. Busy girl.

Seeing that schedule made it real—as if it somehow wasn't before. Amanda had a schedule. She had shifts at a strip club. Shifts that I could track. For instance, Sunday night, as I tried to watch an older episode of the *Global Odyssey*, I knew that she was working the night shift.

In a weird way, knowing where she was brought me comfort. It didn't stop that gut-wrenching foreboding that was ever-present, but at least I knew *something* about what was happening. On the flip side, the times when I knew she wasn't working became even harder. What did she do during those times? Presumably she had an apartment somewhere—what was that like? How did the stripper version of my wife decorate her place?

Before this gig, Amanda was a creature of routine. She'd get up early and go for a run every morning. On Mondays, she went to yoga. On Wednesdays, we watched *Castaway* together. Every first Friday of the month, she went out with her girlfriends. Every second Friday, we went out to dinner somewhere. Did she have something similar now? Based on her schedule, I couldn't see much regularity. That must have killed her.

Or maybe she just spent all her free time hanging out in some guy's bed. It was the wrong thing to think, but I couldn't *stop* thinking it. She'd been sent undercover as a stripper to get close to some bad men—men who had certain expectations of what strippers did in their free time.

Could she really do that? Could she really just ignore our vows, our love, our history for what was essentially a job?

I thought about how angry she'd been after her big bust back in Miami. It wasn't just that her superior officer had taken credit for the work she'd put in—although that certainly didn't help. It was that she thought that the raid had been premature, that she wasn't being heard. It had worked out, but Amanda was a perfectionist, and even as she was celebrating, she saw all the flaws.

Could she not see her own flaws now?

By Monday, I was fried. I don't think I got much sleep and apparently it showed as I dragged myself into the office. "What the fuck happened to you?" Brandon Cruise said. He threw himself into a chair opposite my desk, making himself right at home.

"Just a little under the weather, I think. Didn't get much sleep last night."

"Well, Jesus, go home, man. Don't go bringing that shit in here. That's why you've got sick days."

The thought of spending another day home alone was terrifying. "Thanks, but I don't think I'm contagious anymore."

Brandon shrugged, moving on. "What are you doing Wednesday night?"

I thought of *Castaway* and Amanda and the prospect of watching television by myself. It was pretty pathetic. "No plans."

"Great. We're taking a potential client out, you and me."

"We are?"

"Yeah. Guy's flying in from Spain. Says it's his birthday Wednesday, so I figured we could help him celebrate."

I had an inkling of what Brandon had in mind for "celebrating," and suddenly wished that I'd told him I was busy. "You really think it's his birthday?"

"Who the fuck cares? He says it is, so it is. You know how this works." Brandon picked up one of my business cards from its tray and folded it into quarters.

"So what's the plan?"

Brandon unfolded the card and put it back where he'd picked it up, now thoroughly creased. He grinned. "The Gold Club again. Figured that was pretty successful last time."

Part of me must have been expecting that, because I didn't feel totally stunned by the suggestion—just mostly. Now I really needed to get out of

this. I couldn't go back. It wasn't an option. I just needed to figure out a way to gracefully decline.

"Are you sure that's a good idea? I mean, do we even know the guy?" I knew how fruitless this argument was with Brandon, but I figured I'd try.

"He's a guy. That's all I need to know. I mean, fuck, you're about as straight as they come, and even you were like a kid in a candy store."

I felt a flush climb my neck and willed it back down.

He went on. "But it's good that you're concerned about the client. We wouldn't want to bring them anywhere that's anything less than top shelf."

I saw a glimmer of hope. "Good thought. Maybe there's somewhere higher...class or something to take him?"

Brandon nodded. I felt relief. I could suddenly breathe easier again. "My thought exactly. So I did some...research, shall we say?" The grin was back, along with that tightness in my chest. "Went to all the classiest joints in the area. The Gold Club is *definitely* top end. They have the hottest pussy around."

I swallowed. It was hard to do. "Yeah?"

"Oh, and remember that chick you couldn't take your eyes off of? The brunette with the big, natural tits?"

Oh, God. Things got tighter and tighter. I had to consciously take breaths. "I don't remember. That night was a blur."

"Her name's Raven. She's got this sexy ass tramp stamp of a raven—naturally."

"Okay, what about her?"

"Took her into the backroom for a private dance. Damn, dude. Fuckin' sweet."

"No." I uttered it before I could stop myself. Brandon could have punched me in the gut and it would have felt better than hearing what he was saying now.

Brandon smiled, nodding. "Oh, yes. She was expensive, but it was so worth it."

Did my coworker just have sex with my wife? I had no words. I didn't know how to react. "You slept with her?"

Brandon laughed. "I fuckin' wish. Nah. I offered, but she declined. Said it was *against policy*, which is total B.S."

I masked my relief like a fucking poker player. I sat back in my chair, silently releasing a breath. "So just a dance?"

“Dude, if you’d have been there, you wouldn’t have called it *just a dance*. That’s like saying the *Mona Lisa*’s just a selfie. Not only does she have a *killer* bod, but she knows how to use it, man. She was so soft. I don’t know how these chicks do that. I got her to strip all the way and *damn*, man. I swear, she was wet.”

“But you didn’t get to check yourself?”

Brandon laughed. “I wish. But seriously, looking was worth it. Totally shaved bare. I love that look.”

I thought of my first experience seeing my wife like that and how stunned I had been. Now I *knew* I wasn’t alone in seeing it.

“Anyway, she’s working Wednesday night, so maybe you can see exactly what I’m talking about. Best \$200 I’ve dropped in a long time.”

“Sounds good.”

Sounded horrible.

I FELT like I’d had too much coffee on an empty stomach—jittery, restless, a brick sitting at the bottom of my stomach. Only the feeling didn’t go away after food. Or sleep. Or anything. If anything, as Wednesday closed in, it got worse.

I took comfort in knowing that Amanda wasn’t turning tricks in the back room, but how seriously did I really believe that she was doing that in the first place? There was nothing to be gained from compromising herself like that. Amanda was pretending to be Raven—she wasn’t actually Raven.

I was wracked with doubt and guilt and apprehension. If Amanda was just doing her job without actually compromising herself, how would this look to her? That I didn’t trust her? That I needed to check up on her because she couldn’t take care of herself?

I couldn’t go. I wouldn’t. I didn’t want to! Walking in to work on Wednesday, I had every intention not to.

Then I got summoned into the boss’s office and learned that I had no choice.

“We need to make this guy happy, understand, David?” Gary, my boss, said. “I know you’re not a big fan of Brandon’s...methods, but trust his instincts on this one. ‘Kay?”

Well, fuck me. “Got it, sir. But in that case, maybe it's best just to let Brandon take him around.”

Gary was already shaking his bald head before I finished. I hadn't known him long, but felt like I already had a bead on him. Gary was a worrier. Always acting like everything—his partnership in the firm, his trophy wife, that 7-series BMW he drove, the big house up in the Palisades, all of it—might be taken away from him in the wink of an eye. At his most upbeat and relaxed, he usually looked like someone who had just sucked an entire lemon.

“No” he said. “This needs to look official. We need the *both* of you there.” He pinched the bridge of his nose. “Look, you're new, and I know this isn't how you guys do things on the East Coast. I promise, it's not always how it's done here, either, but despite Brandon's... ways, he's actually a brilliant negotiator. Watch him. Maybe you'll learn something from him.”

And that was that. There was something freeing now that the choice had been made for me. I thought about some way to warn Amanda ahead of time, but I had no way of getting in touch with her. This was going to happen, and I needed to be flexible.

Deep down—way, way deep down—a part of me was excited for this return. Horrible, I know, but how often does a guy get an opportunity like this? To see his wife at the center of all that attention. I never thought I'd like the idea, but there was definitely something flattering about having a wife who could command so much undivided attention. Even thinking about the things that Brandon had said about her got my blood pumping once I was able to get beyond the discomfort of it happening at all.

WE PICKED up Javier Garcia at LAX, dropped his things off at the Regency, and then immediately went out to dinner. Javier was a quiet guy, not at all the brash Spaniard I'd mostly expected. He was about my age—late 20s, maybe or early 30s—but already had gray in his week-old scruff. He struck me as an artist more than the representative of a foreign defense contractor looking for legal guidance.

Dinner flew by. Brandon did most of the talking. The boss was right, Brandon really was good at negotiating, and I may have learned a thing or two had I not spent most of the time looking for an excuse to get out of this shitty scenario. I ran out of time.

“So what do you have planned for my birthday?” Javier asked in accented English.

“We have a treat for you, my friend. We’re going to take you to one of the finest gentlemen's establishments in greater LA.”

Javier smirked, the first real emotion he’d shown since we’d picked him up. “But what if I don’t feel like being a gentleman on my birthday?”

Brandon grinned. “Then we can accommodate that as well.” He looked at me and I caught a moment of hesitation from my brash coworker. It seemed out of character. Then, he pushed on, returning his full attention to Javier. “Ever tried jasmine?”

“Like the herb?” Javier asked.

“No, man. It’s this new designer pill. Has the same euphoric high as Ecstasy, with that empowering feeling of coke.”

Since Ty had mentioned it, I looked into it. The LA Times had an exposé on it a couple months ago, and apparently it was making the rounds in the clubs. Suddenly, I felt the rising dread about what Brandon was about to suggest.

“Sounds fun,” Javier said.

Brandon paused dramatically. “Want to try it?”

He pulled out a little ring box and set it in front of our new client. I looked at it like a bomb. Javier's smile widened. “Happy birthday to me.”

He cracked it open, and inside was a little purple pill.

“You’re not going to make me take this alone, are you?”

Brandon was ahead of him. From his inside coat pocket, he retrieved a couple more pills. My stomach was tight and swarming—and for the first time in days, the feeling had nothing to do with Amanda's assignment. I felt like I was back in high school, being pressured into taking a joint.

Brandon handed me the pill and I took it from him without thinking. He winked at me, popped his into his mouth, and washed it down with the last of his wine. I briefly considered turning it down, but as Javier followed Brandon's lead, he met my eyes and nodded. We were in this together, just three guys ready to begin a night of debauchery. Partnerships lived and died on this kind of thing.

I palmed the pill and pretended to take it. I'd never done a drug in my life—including the pot that my so-called friends had tried pressing on me back in high school. No way was I going to start for some contract—not to mention being married to a federal agent who fights this stuff. But I could fake it with the best of them.

Javier got up to use the bathroom. Brandon leaned over to me and held out his hand. “If you’re not going to take that, then I’d like it back. This shit’s fifty bucks a pop.”

So maybe I couldn't fake it as well as I'd thought. I handed it back. “Think Javier knows?”

“Nah. But I didn't expect a boy scout like you to take it anyway, so I was watching closely.” Brandon settled the check. “You know, though, you really should try it. It's fucking amazing.”

I wondered what he'd do if he knew that my wife worked for the FBI, or that she'd worked counter-narcotics a few years back. “I'm good.”

“Your loss. Ready to see some pussy?”

I HADN'T KNOWN what to expect the first time I'd walked into this club. We'd all been drunk from the night of schmoozing. I'd never been to a strip club before. And I certainly hadn't known that my wife would be there dancing. I walked in without any baggage.

The second time, I had all the baggage. The complete set.

With the jasmine crisis behind us, all I had in front of me was spending the night watching my wife take her clothes off for strangers.

“Fuck, you feel that, Javi my man?” Brandon said, slapping the Spaniard on the back. His smile was particularly wide—both men, in fact. I put on one of my own.

“It's good,” Javier said with a nod. Then said it again, like the feeling deserved twice the praise. “It's good.”

“I want you to remember this, Javi,” Brandon said. “When you start thinking about who you'd rather work with each time you come over here, I want you to think about tonight.”

Why did I need to be here? Brandon had this one wrapped up in a neat little bow. I'd barely said a thing all night. I hadn't needed to.

We walked up to the entrance of the Gold Club. Gold stanchions held up yellow velvet ropes, marking off a small line of perverts waiting to get inside and ogle my wife. I looked each one of them over, judging them.

Brandon bypassed the line and walked right up to the bouncer. Dressed in a black suit, the bouncer was a bruiser of a man, his shaved head made him look like an overgrown baby. At first, I was almost embarrassed for my colleague for presuming he could even talk with the strip club security—clearly the jasmine shit was impairing his judgment. When the bouncer greeted Brandon with a bro's handshake—more highfive than shake—I second guessed myself.

“Yo, Brandon, what up, bro?”

“Nice crowd for hump day,” Brandon said.

The bouncer shrugged. “You know how it is.”

“So these are the guys I told you about. Javi here just got off the plane from Spain. And that there's my man, David. This, guys, is Griff.”

“Nice to meet you,” Griff said. Then, to me: “Now spread 'em open.”

I'd gone through this drill the first time. Nevertheless, Griff explained it anyway. “Need to search you. Club policy.”

Even the first time, I remember thinking how humiliating it felt to be frisked. There was the invasion of personal space, the subtle acquiescence of control, not to mention another man's hands patting up my thigh. This time, though, I thought about what Amanda had to put up with on a nightly basis and felt even worse that I was here, about to witness that.

Griff patted down Javier, then moved on to Brandon. “Sorry man, rules are rules.”

“No worries.” Brandon said Griff patted the insides of his pockets. “There's a present in there if you're interested in *jazzing* up the night.”

Griff paused, reached into Brandon's pocket, and removed the small baggie with my lone and rejected pill. His face hardened. The friendly façade was gone just like that—apparently it *was* just a façade. He quickly sized Brandon up, then the two of us. For an uncomfortable moment, I wondered if he was about to call the cops and Javier Garcia would be trading his room at the Regency for a jail cell.

Griff seemed to find what he was looking for—or he didn't—and tucked the pill away. “Can't, I'm afraid. Club forbids it. And I'm sorry, but I can't let you take it in, either.”

Brandon played it cool, although for the first time since I'd known him, I could tell he was freaked out. "It's cool. Keep it for later then."

Griff neither nodded nor shook his head, but I got the feeling that that pill would be flushed before long. The bouncer lifted the radio to his mouth and signaled for a table for three.

"Well, that wasn't awkward," I muttered to Brandon as the thumping music of the club washed over us. "You know the bouncer?"

"Met him Sunday. It was pretty dead in there, so we got to chatting. It always pays to play nice with security."

"Well, that friendship may have been short lived."

Brandon grinned toothily. "We'll see."

The strict club policy actually took a weight off my shoulders that I hadn't realized was there. It meant that the management was interested in running a clean shop. That could only make things easier for Amanda. Thinking about Brandon's complaint about no sex in the back room, that fit, too. It was very possible that "Raven" wasn't sleeping with anyone after all.

All of this washed over me as blissful and euphoric as I'm sure that Brandon and Javier were feeling from the drugs. I decided that it was okay to have some fun tonight. Hell, this was cause for celebration.

The club opened up as before—the twin stages, the low couches, the sexy ambiance that permeated the joint. Since it was a Wednesday, I'd expected it to be less crowded than the last time I'd been here. Maybe it was, but I couldn't tell. Most of the seats and tables were filled. Girls mingled through the crowd, barely clothed, flirting from one group to the next. I searched for Amanda but couldn't find her.

A hostess met us at the entrance, just inside the thick velvet curtains. She was a petite thing with a sharp, dark bob and tits that burst from her tight black top. "Right this way," she said, leading us into the club. My gaze drifted to her ass, encased in a black mini-skirt, and I wondered if she danced, too.

Brandon caught my eye, nodding with a grin. I forced myself to stop ogling the woman, instead doing another sweep of the room.

That's when I saw her. Amanda—or Raven, I supposed—standing at the bar, chatting with the bartender as he mixed up some drinks. All the anxiety I had coming here melted away in the moment, replaced by an ache to go to my wife and hold her. To kiss her. Hell, just to say, *Hi* again. She was dressed in a pair of silver hot pants that looked painted on, coupled with a

metallic halter top not much larger than a bikini. The tattoo was there, about the size of a coaster, black, tribal swirls that formed a stylized raven, one wing up, one wing down, like it was soaring. Her dark hair was pulled back in a high ponytail and her face was so made-up that I understood why I hadn't recognized her instantly the last time we were here.

She laughed at something the bartender said, reaching across the bar to touch his arm. My gut tightened. He said something back, she picked up a couple of drinks, and headed toward the roped off VIP area. Her silver shorts couldn't contain her ass, the bottoms of her cheeks actually peeking out. As she sashayed away from us, I couldn't stop staring.

Brandon stepped up beside me. "Yeah, she's amazing," he said. To our hostess: "Raven going to be free tonight?"

The girl shrugged, and I couldn't help picking up a little attitude in the gesture. "Don't know. She's working the VIP section now, anyway."

That was a double edged sword. It was comforting to know that our interactions with her were at a minimum tonight, but I couldn't shake the thought that the VIP patrons had bigger expectations of their dancers.

"What'll it take to get in there?" Brandon asked.

The hostess looked us up and down, no doubt appraising the quality of our clothing, our shoes, the way we carried ourselves. Whatever she saw didn't impress her. "Don't worry about that, honey. There's plenty of fun to be had right out here. And if you want to see Ray dance, she'll be on stage like the rest of us at some point."

Again, I heard the edge of bitterness in her voice, but couldn't figure out a way to probe before she left us.

Brandon looked forlornly at the exclusive section. I looked, too, finding my wife sitting in the lap of a well-dressed guy with a nice beard and nicer hair. I recognized him from our last visit, and grimaced. She already had regulars. Tonight wasn't going to be easy at all.

"So what's your specialty," I asked Javier, trying to make conversation.

"Excuse me?" he asked, turning his ear in my direction. It was hard to hear over the music.

"Defense contracting, I mean," I shouted. "Do you specialize in anything?"

At first he didn't seem to get it and I almost gave up. Then it must have clicked. "Oh, for job? Yes, I..." But between his accent and the music from the clubs, I couldn't quite make out what he was saying, although he was

very enthusiastic about it. Something about some kind of proprietary digital something something that may have to do with forensics or maybe micro sticks?

It didn't matter. Brandon saw me struggling, pulled in a pair of strippers, and they were suddenly enjoying a couple floor dances as the girls tried talking them into something more private in the back. Javier had attracted a brunette with a cornfed All-American look to her. Brandon had a tawny Asian grinding in his lap.

A third had tried to entice me into a \$20 lap dance, but I wasn't feeling it. Brandon gave me a queer look, but didn't call me out—mostly because Javier was right there next to us. What I did instead was start drinking, ordering a double IPA which couldn't be watered down. If I was going to spend \$15 on a drink, I was determined that it was going to do the trick.

I'll be honest, I spent most of my time watching Amanda work the VIP section. She spent a long time with the guy with the beard and the nice, salt-and-pepper hair, although she wasn't grinding in his lap like the two strippers beside me. They just seemed to talk. And laugh. And flirt. It was a total nightmare—worse than if she'd just been dancing. My head swam with the crushing jealousy. I wanted to vomit. Twice, I thought about heading for the bathroom to try.

But I was actually hard—head-spinningly, nauseatingly hard.

A pair of strippers took to the stage closer to us—a blonde dressed as a slutty angel, complete with feathery wings and a halo, and a redhead adorned in red lingerie and horns. I hadn't seen two women dance together at the Gold Club, and I sure as hell had never seen two girls kiss each other outside of porn. But when the devil drew the angel into a steamy kiss right up there on stage, I was riveted. Finally something to take my mind off of whatever the hell my wife was doing.

The angel and devil pulled away from each other and began their act. They played coy at first, spinning opposite one another on the pole, one chasing the other. The redhead swiveled first, meeting the angel for another embrace. Her fingers traced down the blonde's back and unfastened the clasp of her bra. The white lingerie fell away, taking her angel wings with it. I didn't care. My eyes were on her tits and the way the she-devil dipped her head and took a hard nipple into her mouth.

"Fuck, that's hot," I heard Brandon say behind me.

The angel threw her head back, eyes closed, mouth open in a moan. Whether it was an act or not, I didn't really care. I let myself believe that this was why I was hard—even though I'd been fighting back an erection since Amanda had settled into that man's lap.

The devil spun away but the angel caught her, pulling her close and pulling the red top off. The redhead had small tits, pale and mesmerizing. She turned her head to kiss the fallen angel over her shoulder as she grinded back into the other woman's hips.

Their shorts went next, revealing g-strings that left so little to the imagination. Neither girl could have much hair down there, and when the devil slid her hand into the angel's panties, I caught a quick glimpse of her bare pussy.

It reminded me of Amanda. I glanced back at the VIP section. She wasn't there. I looked around the club, but she wasn't anywhere. My heart jumped. The man with the beard was also missing.

"I thought the rule was no touching," Brandon said. I turned, thinking he was talking to me. He still had the Asian stripper in his lap, although the two of them were watching the girl-on-girl show.

She said, "No touching with the customers. The girls can do whatever they want."

"You and Misty willing to give us a little show?" he asked, looking at the brunette still in Javier's lap.

The stripper considered it. If she was embarrassed at the prospect of a lesbian act, it didn't show. "\$500 for the two of us for a half-hour. Your friend can come watch, too." The Asian stripper looked right at me with a smile. I'd all but planned on declining the offer, but that look was so inviting.

"What do you say, Javi? Want to watch a couple chicks dyke it out?"

I laughed inside. In any other setting, that question—right in front of the girls about to "dyke it out"—would have been met with a slap. Here, he earned a pair of giggles.

"Let's go."

"David?" Brandon asked.

I looked at the stripper, who met my eyes with practiced ease. *You know you want to*, she seemed to say. She'd been trained to do that, to seduce with eye contact alone. To make the man she was with think he was the only one that mattered. Realizing that was enough to snap me out of my spell.

"I'm good. You guys have fun."

"You sure?"

"I'm sure."

Brandon grinned. "Your loss. Lead the way, ladies."

The women rose, threading their fingers together as they led the men toward the back room. I'll admit that I watched them go wistfully, part of me regretting my decision. I looked toward the stage, where the angel and demon were still in the midst of their show. On their knees, they were making out as they fingered one another. The crowd of men around them was thick.

I sighed. The long, booze-filled night—along with poor sleep the previous several days—was finally catching up to me. I yawned, wondering if it was time to get out of here.

"They not do it for you?" The husky voice was tinged with a hint of Eastern European.

I turned to look at one of the most beautiful women I'd ever met—my wife excepted. She was who I pictured when I thought "Russian beauty"—I just didn't realize it until now. With her high cheekbones, round face, fair skin, and the softness of her beauty, I couldn't stop staring.

"Maybe *I* do?" she said, arching a dark eyebrow. It contrasted with her crisp white-blond hair in a sexy way. "Can I join you?"

"Uh, um... sure?" I hated the sound of uncertainty in my voice.

"I am Irina." She slipped into my lap, filling my nose with her clean scent. "You are...?"

For a moment, I forgot my own name. "David."

She had clear blue eyes that never wavered from mine. I was just aware of being subtly manipulated as I had been with Brandon's dancer, but with Irina, it was easier to pretend that I wasn't.

"So girl-girl is not something you like." Her Russian accent made me feel like I was in a James Bond movie. This stripper certainly could have been a Bond girl.

"No, it is," I said too quickly, then realized what I'd just admitted to. "I mean, it's nice, I guess. I'm just tired."

The hint of a smile tugged at the corners of Irina's lips. "Why don't you order an espresso? Mikhail makes them very strong."

I followed her glance to the bar, where the bartender—presumably Mikhail—was pouring a row of shots. It reminded me of how Amanda had

flirted with the guy, which in turn reminded me of Amanda. I looked around again, but couldn't find her.

"Maybe you're not into me, either." Irina had a good pout. "Looking for someone in particular?"

Part of me almost asked her about "Raven," but I wasn't that stupid. Irina could have been working for the very people that Amanda was trying to take down; blundering in here asking about their newest dancer could only lead to trouble.

"Just wondering where my friends went."

Irina seemed to buy it. She smiled wickedly. "Oh, they're in good hands."

The way she said it made my cock—which had been stuck in a state of arousal since we'd walked in—flex. "Oh yeah? What goes on back there?"

Irina ran her hand along my chest. "Depends."

"Depends?"

"Buy me a drink and maybe I'll tell you."

At that very moment a server stepped up behind them, as if summoned. "Hello, Aimee. An espresso for David here, and an appletini for me."

"Coming right up," the girl said. I realized that the server was as scantily clad as a stripper. It was scary how quickly I could get desensitized to that. Was that what happened to Amanda? Did the criminal world which she was infiltrating start to permeate her life? I thought about what Ty had said about slipping into personas—of owning the role.

"You're a contemplative one, aren't you?" Irina said. "I bet you're an artist, yes? Or maybe a writer?"

I wonder what she'd think if I told her that I was a lawyer—and a non-litigating one at that—before I realized that it didn't matter. She'd be "impressed" no matter what; it's what she did for a living.

"Art school drop-out," I said. Which wasn't really a lie.

"So tell me, David, do I inspire you?" Irina turned in my lap, wrapping her arms around my neck. Her white halter top was no larger than a bra, designed for one reason alone: to showcase her creamy, overflowing cleavage.

"Yes." My lungs were so tight I could barely get my one-word answer out.

"Then how 'bout a dance?"

Again, I thought about what Ty had said about owning the role. Only this time, I didn't think about it in the context of Amanda's assignment, but my own. I wasn't here to check up on her, I had to remind myself. I was just like any other patron of a strip club, and I needed to start acting like one.

"One dance. \$20?"

Irina lit up. I reached into my back pocket for my wallet and withdrew a crisp bill. She took it, set it on the cocktail table beside us, and turned her thousand watt smile on me. She said, "You know, you're going to think I say this to all the guys, but I'm going to enjoy this one."

I was pretty sure that she said that to most of the guys, but at that moment, I didn't care. As she slipped out of my lap and began undulating in the close space between my legs, I became hypnotized. She knew how to move her body, sinuously weaving it to the drone of whatever stripper song was on at the time. Her outfit, I realized now that I was finally looking, was the most outrageously slutty version of a "Catholic schoolgirl" uniform that I'd ever seen. The plaid skirt didn't quite cover her ass, and I recognized that the white halter top I'd thought was a bra was actually some attempt at being a shirt.

Irina swiveled, her back to me, I looked her up and down, taking in the lower curves of her ass cheeks peeking out under the skirt, before she reached behind her and unclasped her top. "Relax, David. You've seen a naked woman before, haven't you?"

I realized how tense I was. I was clutching the arms of the chair like that was the only thing holding me into it. I loosened my hands, but since I couldn't actually touch her, I left them there. That would have to do for *relaxing* for now.

She turned, her bare tits swinging into view. They looked great—too perfect and round to be natural, I figured, but they looked better than many of the strippers I'd seen in here. She bent forward, arching her back to bring her tits within inches of my face. I suppressed the instinct to lean into them and suck on her nipples. She pivoted before my oversexed brain could revolt and do it anyway, although her half-smile suggested she knew exactly what I was thinking.

She grinded into my lap, pushing her fingers through her blond locks and piling them atop her head. "Excited, big boy?" she said with a smirk.

Shame cut through my foggy arousal. Shame and guilt. This wasn't me. I wasn't this guy. I looked away, across the room, focusing on anything but

the rippling blonde in my lap. The timing couldn't have been more perfect. Raven emerged from the back room, once again dressed in her silver stripper outfit—the bikini halter top, the tiny booty shorts.

She scanned the club at the same time that I did, and our eyes met at just the right moment. She lingered on me for just a beat longer than she would any other man before moving on. She wasn't supposed to know me, and she was good at her job. Still, that pregnant pause felt like a missile strike. I was too far from her and the light was too dim to see her reaction, but I imagined all kinds of things that she must have felt: shock, disappointment, maybe a little anger.

Done with her scan, she sashayed into the room, drawing looks from the men in her immediate vicinity. She swung by the bar, whispering something to the bartender—Mikhail. He nodded, and she moved on, approaching the nearest gathering of guys. Bending at the waist so that her breasts toppled from her top, she asked them something. One of the guys nodded enthusiastically.

She settled into his lap, much like Irina did to me earlier, the flirtation stage of the stripper game just beginning. I felt my chest tighten as I watched her smile at this guy, laugh at what he said, touch his face when making a point. Every one of those mannerisms were Amanda's—they may have been faked, but they were ones I'd seen Amanda do daily. In this context, they became painful rather than familiar.

But I couldn't keep looking at Amanda. I knew what kind of danger that would put her in—I knew I shouldn't even *be* here. So I forced myself to ignore her, to focus on Irina in my lap and pretend to be some guy that I wasn't.

"So in the back room? You said you'd tell me more about that if I bought you a drink." I looked at the side table and was surprised to find that our drinks had shown up at some point while I wasn't paying attention.

Irina sat up off me enough to hook her thumbs in the band of her schoolgirl skirt and slide it over her hips. Beneath, she wore a thong that barely covered her sex. I could trace the outline of her plump pussy lips.

"I could just take you back there if you'd like," Irina said in her exotic accent.

"First I'd like to know what I'd be agreeing to."

Irina gyrated against my erection. "Well, first, you'd be getting a half hour instead of just one song, and I can promise you that I'll make sure

every minute counts.”

“Sounds good. Keep going.”

“It’s *very* private back there. Just you and me. Out here, there’s a rule—no contact. In there...” She finished with a shrug.

My heart jumped. “I thought the rules were still pretty strict.”

Irina had an amazing smile that brought out her cheekbones. “Depends on what you consider strict. Right now, I’m pretty sure that your friends back there are watching Cherry and Misty have sex right now—and those two don’t fake anything.”

In a moment of weakness, I truly regretted turning that down. “But the guys can’t touch.”

“Not the girls,” Irina said with a laugh. “But if the guys are nice enough, maybe *they’ll* be touched.”

I squirmed at the implication. “How about you? What happens if I’m nice to you?”

Irina smiled. “How nice are we talking?”

I was out of my comfort zone on this one. I barely knew what I was talking about. “It’s \$200 to the club for the dances, right? What if your tip matched it.”

“Then things could get very friendly between us,” she said.

“And what if I offered five times that?”

Irina’s eyes flared at that. I practically saw dollar bills in her blue irises. It was a lot of money, I realized. More than she typically saw. “Then I’d say you keep your money and wait for my shift to end. Then I can show you a really private time.”

So that was the game. The prostitution happened off premise, but the deals were brokered here. How much of a cut did the club get, I wondered. And how many of the girls were in on it? Was Amanda?

Heat bloomed through me. It became hard to breathe. I looked across at Amanda. She was now straddling the stranger she’d been chatting up earlier, her long hair flipped back. She was topless, her naked breasts inches from the man’s face.

“So what do you say?” Irina asked. “Tempted?”

For the briefest of moments, I considered it. It wasn’t hard to imagine Irina’s body naked and undulating on my cock, since that’s largely what was happening now, but as sexy as that thought was, it was more a reason to not do it. The way I could justify it was that I’d be getting more information on

this crime ring that Amanda was investigating, coming at it from a different angle. Maybe if I worked it, she'd bust these guys faster, which would bring her home faster.

In the end, though, I chickened out. "Maybe next time," I said, adding a lame: "when I come back alone."

Like any good salesperson, Irina knew what that meant; I was a browser, not a buyer. She didn't seem upset about it—she'd already made an easy \$20 out of me. She just shrugged and slipped out of my lap. "Have a good night, David." She slipped back into her top with an elegance that I don't think many women could pull off, pausing before she left. "If you change your mind, I get off at two."

Salesperson to the end.

As I watched Irina strut away, I felt pride well up within me. How was that for undercover work for a total novice? I'd played the role of naive strip club patron perfectly—mostly because that's who I was. I'd uncovered a secret prostitution ring, even opened up a further lead with Irina, should I go down that route. And it wasn't even 11.

Across the room, Amanda was pulling the guy she'd just danced for toward the back. She hadn't bothered putting her top back on, leaving her in nothing but a silver thong and her platform heels. Despite that, she carried herself with elegance—her head tipped forward, her hair falling around her face, her fingers laced in those of her latest customer. She took slow, swaying steps, one foot crossing before the other. Right there was a woman who was hot and knew it. Hard to believe she was my wife.

She could do that knowing that I was there. She could compartmentalize. My stomach fluttered. She was more than capable of taking care of herself. The guy she was leading couldn't take his eyes off her ass, or the tattoo on her back, and all I could think was, *Look, friend, but when the smoke clears, she'll be coming home to me.*

It didn't put me at ease. Still, I was in a better place than where I'd been when I walked in. I knew what was going on. I knew her role in it. And maybe, just maybe, I was going to lend my help where I could.

Irina swung by one last time a minute later, tracing her fingers across my shoulders. She leaned down, her lips resting against my ear. Even her heady perfume was filled with suggestion. I thought she was going to make her offer again. I was already prepared to tell her no again. But that's not what she said.

“Oh, one other thing. That brunette you’ve been eyeing up all night long? Don’t even bother. You won’t get far. She’s the boss’s flavor of the month right now.”

The floor might as well have opened up under me, because the next moment, I was in free fall.

OceanofPDF.com

HELPING

F *avor of the month... she's the boss's flavor... she's the boss's...*

I can't remember the exact sequence of events that happened after hearing those words. I'd texted Brandon, telling him something had come up and I needed to go. I'd chugged the entire double IPA *and* the espresso before leaving. I remember standing in the bathroom, looking at myself in the mirror as I seriously contemplated vomiting.

And then I was staggering out onto the street like someone had knifed me. I think I was trying to hail a cab. Blink, blink, blink, the night went by like that.

Before an actual taxi could pull up and whisk me back to my empty life, a black BMW SUV pulled up to the curb. The window lowered smoothly and a familiar face peered out at me through the darkness. "Get in," she said.

"Julia?" My wife's FBI rival and handler? The one who'd wanted this assignment over Amanda, but was five years too old for it? What the hell was going on?

"Get the fuck in."

"Excuse me?"

"You heard me. Unless you want me to slap the cuffs on right out in front of the club."

I considered it for a moment. I couldn't help it. I'd taken a lot of "have to" commands lately from my wife, from my boss, and now from Julia, and I was nearly at the end of my tether.

I don't know where the words came from, but come they did. Maybe it was the booze talking. "Julia, you keep threatening me with a good time like that, and you might just make my wife jealous."

Julia's eyes widened and her mouth made an "o." For some reason the whole thing just struck me all at once as funny. I looked back at the club where my beloved spouse was even now likely rendering unto some old rich fuck the things that were mine.

"Or, then again, you know...maybe not." I snorted a laugh.

Julia recovered herself enough to say, "I have a taser—"

I waved the rest of her statement away as I crossed in front of the Beamer, and then I got in.

Julia didn't speak at first, and for the longest moment, I wondered if I was dreaming—if this whole night was a dream—or a nightmare—or just something that I could wake up from and have a normal life right there, waiting for me.

I looked over at my driver, illuminated every few seconds by a passing street lamp. She wore black—black jeans, black shirt, black leather jacket. Her dirty blonde hair was pulled back in a severe ponytail, emphasizing her prominent forehead and her Barbie Doll beauty. Her eyebrows were darker than her hair, and right now, they were gathered together tightly. Julia was *pissed off*.

We accelerated onto the 101, the powerful engine of the BMW pushing me back into the bucket seat. That sensation was exactly how I'd been feeling from the moment I realized that my wife was playing the part of a stripper. Things were moving too fast to do anything but hang on.

Still reeling from what I'd just seen with my own two eyes, I once again fell back on humor. "So what are we in? An X3? What are they paying FBI agents these days?"

My joke was completely ignored. "What the hell do you think you're doing?"

I flinched. "I don't know. You're the one driving."

"No, asshole. You were obstructing a federal investigation, not to mention putting your wife's pretty ass in danger."

Something in me snapped. “Oh fuck *you*,” I crowed as dismissively as I could manage in my current state. “Didn’t you read my background check? I *interned* at DOJ. I probably understand the federal obstruction statute better than *you* do, Agent Barbie.” It was out before I could stop it.

I’d been through too much. My wife was fucking the boss of a fucking strip club. “No,” I shook my head. “Nope. It’s not me who put her in danger.” My body shook as adrenaline pumped through my veins. I drew a ragged breath. “That’s all on *you* guys.”

And also on Amanda.

I was falling again, lost, the anger flowing out of me like a slowly leaking tire. I sank into the seat and stared out the window as LA glided by, waiting for Julia to dispense with the formalities and *really* start bawling me out. Let her. I didn’t care anymore.

But she didn’t say a word. Not at first. I barely knew the woman, my impressions mostly formed from the stories that Amanda brought back when they were preparing for this assignment. I was pretty sure she wasn’t the quiet type, but then again, I didn’t know what to trust from my wife anymore. Maybe Julia was feeling guilty. Good. Let her.

I went on. “It wasn’t my idea. I was there with a coworker and a client. We were trying to win him over. And I *tried* to get out of it, but my boss *insisted* I go.” I glanced at Julia, daring her to judge me. She still didn’t speak. “Anyway, I didn’t speak to Amanda. Not even a word. She didn’t even come over to my side of the room.”

Julia started to speak, but I cut her off, rushing on.

“And I learned some things that could help with your investigation. One of the dancers, Irina, solicited me, but said that *that* stuff only happens outside of the club. Inside, they’re totally legit.” I knew I was sounding defensive, but I just couldn’t stop talking. “I could even go back, to, you know, meet up with her. Help with the investigation.”

“You’d do that for us?” Julia asked. There was too much sweetness in her voice for it to be genuine. “You’d have sex with a hot, Russian stripper in the name of justice? How noble.”

If you’re okay with my wife fucking for this case, maybe I’m entitled to it, too. But that’s not what I said. “No, not to have sex. I mean, we’d set it up, right? You guys could bug me, and I could get her talking, and—”

“You haven’t really thought this one through, have you?” Julia said.

“It could work.”

“Are you done?”

I felt incredibly low. I sank deeper into my seat. “Yeah.”

She said, “So you set up a possible contact with this stripper. What alias did you go by?”

“Huh?”

I could hear the roll of her eyes in her tone. “What name did you use?”

I cringed. “David.”

“Good cover. And the guys that you came in with, did they use aliases as airtight as yours?”

When I didn't answer, she just clucked. Her point was made.

“David, I know that you're concerned for your wife. That's natural.” This time, I didn't detect sarcasm. “You're afraid for her. She's in a bad place. But you need to understand, you're going to get her *killed* if you do that again. Do you understand?”

“Sure, but I don't see how—”

“That's exactly the problem. You *don't* see. Do you even realize how much you looked at her while you were in there? How you couldn't keep your eyes off her? Our man inside knew to look out for it, but who knows? Maybe someone else noticed, too.”

I thought of Irina and her last statement. My blood ran cold. “The stripper...”

“Yeah, she probably noticed. Strippers are observant like that. A pretty catty bunch.”

“Fuck.” I put my face in my hands. “Fuck!”

“I know, right?” The car slowed down. We pulled off the highway. “But we don't know how badly we got fucked. You did go in there on completely legit business. If you'd gone alone, that would have been a huge red flag, but you were there with your womanizing friends—”

“Colleagues.”

“—and if we're lucky, no one important saw you stalking your wife.”

“I was just trying to help,” I said.

“You were trying to pry,” she growled. “You wanted to see how bad your wife was behaving.”

That made me feel ill. She wasn't wrong.

“If you want to help,” she continued, “then stay away. Let us do what we do best. That's what we were trained to do. That's what we do for a living.”

She pulled into my sleepy neighborhood—the modest homes and little shops and garden apartments looking strange this late at night. No one was watering their lawns or walking their dogs. No kids were playing in the front yards. For one quiet moment, Julia's BMW was the only car on the street.

“David, did you say anything to the stripper about your wife? I want you to think hard. Anything we should be prepared for?”

I thought hard, taking the question seriously. “No, I didn't say anything about her.” I remembered the last thing that Irina had said before I left, though, the memory arriving with queasy fanfare. “Irina said something about Amanda being the 'boss's flavor of the month.' What does that mean?”

“I'm not going to spell it out for you, but let's just say she surprised me. I didn't think she had what it takes. Guess I was wrong.”

“Is she sleeping with him?”

She pulled up before our three story apartment building, engaged the parking brake, but didn't turn off the engine. “That's classified, but come on, David, why are you even asking that? In my experience, it's much better not knowing.”

“But—”

“I worked a UC case a few years ago. We went after an LA madam, Donna Marie. I went in as one of her girls.”

I felt my eyes widen, even as I tried to play it cool. I imagined Julia stepping into a richly appointed hotel room wearing a tiny dress and tall heels, taking money from overprivileged men.

“Some of the guys I went out with were other UC operatives. We could fake it.”

“Of course.”

“We could fake it *some* of the time.”

“I...see.”

“Finally,” Julia said. “It's the job, David. One your wife is good at.” I heard the envy. “Let her do her thing, and don't think too much about it.”

Maybe Julia had meant it in the way of: *Amanda is capable, don't worry about it*. I knew Amanda was the type to put everything she had into a task, no matter how difficult, when she set her mind to it. In this case, what did *everything she had* mean?

“Pretty hard thing to do.”

Julia shrugged. “Then think about it. The Gold Club is very selective, and two months in she’s working the VIP rotation. Guys have already offered her thousands to spend the night with her. When this is all over, you get her for free. Think about *that*.”

If she’d meant for that to be comforting, she’d missed her mark by a mile. But I didn’t think she’d meant to comfort at all, especially when she added, “And who knows, maybe she’ll learn a few new tricks.”

I thought of the blowjob she’d given me, and all of the passionate sex.

My throat felt raw. “You’re a terrible person, you know.”

She pressed the button that released the BMW’s electronic door locks. “At least I’m not trying to kill your wife.”

OceanofPDF.com

REVELATION

If I hadn't been totally fucked up before the night of the Gold Club visit, I was completely unhinged after. It's funny thinking back on the time before I knew what I knew, back when I could only speculate about what Amanda's assignment was.

I was always worried then, but the worry was an abstract thing, the way I worried about the weather before going on a vacation. The way I fretted about being the new guy at work and not fitting in.

As I learned more details, the worry only hardened, but new emotions started to worm their way in. Fear, for one, and nausea for what Amanda had to do. Then came the sense of betrayal. I was upset both *for* her because of what she had to do, and upset *with* her for doing it so readily.

Julia had assumed that it was paranoia and helplessness that was riding me. Maybe she was right—at least partly. Maybe it was some ingrained sense of maleness that compelled me to do something, to protect my wife, a compulsion that ironically had put her in even more danger.

More revelations piled on.

She's the boss's flavor of the month.

I'm not going to spell it out for you, but let's just say she surprised me.

Amanda is doing her job.

I longed for a time when I could reduce my state of mind to those broad, reductive strokes, but everything was all jumbled up now. I was sad, I was

angry, I was shocked, I was turned on.

And I wasn't sure that I'd ever sleep again.

By the time the sun rose, I still didn't know what I was going to do, or even how I truly felt about all of this, so I did the thing that was routine to me. I showered. I shaved. I put on a tie, and I went into work.

Brandon had called in sick—no surprise—so I had to give an account of last night to my boss alone. I gave him a vague, high level one, figuring that he didn't want to hear the incriminating details—and especially not the fact that Brandon had offered a highly illegal narcotic to our most valuable, prospective client.

The rest of the day passed in a blur. I didn't have a clue what I did, but one moment, it was lunchtime, the next, it was dinner. I worked late, despite my exhaustion, and when I got home, I crashed. That was the ideal. No time to worry by myself. No time to wallow. I was there, then home, then asleep.

The next day, Friday, the numbness finally wore away. I woke up. The warm, California sun poured in through the windows. Birds chirped. A sprinkler was going off somewhere outside. And my wife was still not there.

And that realization triggered a full-on panic attack. Panic that she'd never come back. Panic that my stupid actions had...had...had killed her. My first irrational thought was to drive over to the Gold Club and see if she was there. Fleeting visions of interrogating the bouncer flashed through my head before I calmed down. I checked the website. Raven was still scheduled to work tonight. And tomorrow. But when had this been updated? Maybe it was old. Maybe they just hadn't had the chance to remove her name from the rotation.

Not knowing what else to do, I took a shower. Amanda was in with people who murdered agents rather than run from them. That was bad company, and I'd walked into it like some kind of idiot. I could tell myself that it was all Brandon's idea and that my boss had forced me to go, but if I'd really wanted to, I could have excused myself from the trip.

No, I wanted to know, and now wished that I didn't.

Brandon was at work when I got in. He walked into my office looking fresh and cock-sure of himself. "We landed it, Davie. We fucking landed it."

It was a testament to how wrapped up I was in my own anxiety that I didn't know that he was talking about. Then it came to me. Javier Garcia. Right.

I said, "So he had a good time?"

“You kidding me? Javi loved it. You should have stuck around, man. The night only got crazier. We ended up hooking up with those two strippers after hours.” He leaned in. “I actually did blow off a stripper's ass. It was fucking boss, man.”

“So they were hookers?”

“Yeah. Total pros. And they were into each other, too. No faking that lesbo shit. It was unreal.”

While that sounded hot, I was glad that I'd gotten out of there when I did. “Good job closing the deal.”

“Javi comes in later this afternoon to sign some papers. We're going out partying again. You should come with.”

“No, I don't think so. I've already got plans,” I lied. Then, because I couldn't help it, I asked, “Gold Club again?”

Brandon grinned. “That's the plan. Nice place to celebrate.”

My scalp started to burn even before I asked my next question, but this was the best way to find out whether she was okay—so I told myself. “Going to get Javi a dance with that brunette?”

“Now that's a good idea. Hope she's working tonight.”

She is, I didn't say.

“Now are you tempted? Pretty sure I can get us into the VIP tonight. Just need to drop enough cash, and Javier's splitting it tonight. Oh, and now that I know how this works, maybe I'll be snorting coke off *her* killer ass.”

It should have bothered me, should have rubbed me the absolute wrong way to listen to this pig of a man objectify my wife. It did. It also stirred up other things—anger that she was even there, letting men objectify her. Anger at myself for being angry. Something else, too, linked to pride and arousal and jealousy—that heart-pumping thrill that came when someone would check Amanda out.

Guys have already offered her thousands to spend the night with her. When this is all over, you get her for free. Julia's words. *Who knows, maybe she'll learn a few new tricks.*

It was all very confusing.

Brandon read my hesitation the wrong way. “You so want to come along. I knew it. Come on, man, live a little.”

Julia again, helping me settle my mind. *You're going to get her killed if you do that again.*

“Sorry man. I'm sure you'll have fun. But definitely text me later with an update.”

“Suit yourself.” Brandon left with a shrug.

That night, a Friday night, was a mixed bag of emotions. My worry for Amanda's well being was still there, an undercurrent that would never go away until she was back home and safe in our bed.

But at some point, I'd convinced myself that she must be alright. That my actions hadn't led to real consequences, and what was left was a swirling mixture of jealousy, anger, and, yes, excitement. Brandon and Javier Garcia were at the Gold Club, flirting with Amanda. He was a resourceful guy, so probably figured out how to get into the VIP section to get closer to her. I thought about Irina and her offer to meet me after her shift. The two strippers had probably made the same offer to Brandon. That was the game, right? That's what Amanda was there to bust. Would she make the same offer just to keep up appearances.

I didn't think she would. I couldn't see the upside of compromising like that. Or maybe I was just telling myself that because it made it easier to deal with Brandon flirting with her.

Whatever the reason, I hung onto my phone, waiting for something—*anything*—from Brandon about the night. I wasn't about to go “undercover” again, so this was the best I could do.

Around 11:30, I got my first text.

[Brandon]: IN THE VIP!!

The photo that accompanied it startled me. It was an image of Javier Garcia, with his quiet smile, and a stripper, whose back was to the camera as she straddled Javier's lap. Her raven tattoo gave her identity away as surely as the image of her face would have—Amanda.

She wore a black thong bikini bottom with loops at her hips, and a matching string bikini top. One hand was reaching behind her, already tugging on the tie between her shoulder blades, and her dark hair teased and wavy over her pale back.

Javier looked thrilled, giving the camera a thumb's up and a goofy smile.

My heart palpitated at the sight of it. I zoomed in on every detail, checking the tattoo as if I'd discover that this was an entirely different woman. But it was the same bold, black curves and swirls that formed the raven. This was my wife, and she was there with my fucking coworker.

That was painful to see, and jealousy racked me until a new paranoia flitted into my brain. Did she know that Brandon was my coworker? Did she remember that I'd come into the club with these same guys just two days ago? And if she did, and had still agreed to dance for them, what did that mean? Was she pissed at me? Was she punishing me?

I didn't text back. I didn't dare to. What if she saw whatever I'd said? Did she know that Brandon was sending this photo to me now?

Again, I didn't sleep well that night. I held onto my phone, waiting for another text. Waiting and thinking about all the things that Brandon wanted to do with her. It came at 2:30 in the morning, rousing me from my half-sleep.

[Brandon]: im so fucked up lololol

I didn't know how to read that, so of course it went to the worst place: Brandon in a hotel room, high off his ass as he watched our newest client drill Amanda on the bed. I shut my eyes, imagining how her hair clung to her face as she moaned, as she got off on her undercover assignment. Her body glistened with sweat. Her eyes squeezed shut as a powerful orgasm tore through her.

I hated myself, but the image got me hard. I hated myself enough that I got out of bed and actually took a cold shower to stop myself from thinking that way. My wife was being used for her body—if not by guys like Brandon or the criminal scum she was going after, then by the Feds.

But just as I hadn't been forced to go to the Gold Club, Amanda wasn't forced to go back to Javier's hotel room, right?

The anger helped me deal with my more confusing emotions—that shameful, undeniable sensation of arousal.

The shower worked a little to clear my head, but I was still haunted by these strange emotions. I checked my phone one last time to see if there were any more texts. Seeing none, I actually managed to get some sleep.

I did dream, though. Snippets from real life, snippets from fantasy. Julia and I watching Amanda enter a hotel wearing a tiny dress, flanked by Javier and Brandon. Julia turning to me and saying, *It's the job, David*. I blinked, and we were suddenly standing in the hotel room itself, Amanda stripped and on all fours, sucking Brandon's cock as Javier held her hips and fucked her from behind.

Brandon looked at me, his pupils dilated, his hair a wreck. *I'm so fucked up!*

Amanda pulled off his dick and turned, not to look at me, but back at Javier. Her brow was heavy and lined, her beautiful face tense with her building climax. *Fuck me*, she said to the man behind her. *Fuck, you feel so fucking good.*

My chest caught. Julia said, *You know Amanda better than anyone. Let her do her thing...*

Fuck. Meee!

I launched out of sleep like I'd been doused with a bucket of ice cold water. I was sweating enough that I looked around for the offending bucket. I sighed, crawled out of bed, and took another shower.

I oscillated between despair and fatalism, from jealousy to arousal to disgust with myself for being aroused at all.

This wasn't the first time that I'd felt this way when thinking about Amanda, but I had to think all the way back to a time before we'd started dating. I still remember the day I'd first met her in our Torts class. Talk about love at first sight—or the lusty college-version of it. Ty had been with me at the time, and of course, Ty laid claim to her before I'd even pointed her out.

"Dibs," he'd said with that goofy smile of his—the kind of smile that you just wanted to join in with. I acquiesced to Ty, being the man about campus that he was. I didn't begrudge the guy, it would be like getting angry at a cloud for raining on me. Still, once I realized what an amazing person Amanda was, I felt a heaping of envy.

Unlike Ty's other potential conquests, Amanda played hard to get, which made me fall for her harder—and kept Ty interested in her more despite being put off. At the time, I think that those three months had been the longest he'd gone without hooking up with another female. In my head, it was only a matter of time, and I *hated* that, and yet it also made her even more exciting. Of course, she never did go out with him. Ty grew bored, gave up, and moved on to the next flashy blonde, but those months were formative for me.

That's how I felt now—torn between hating the thing that I thought was inevitable, and turned on by it.

I wasn't an idiot. She was working in a club with strippers who moonlighted as prostitutes. She was the boss's flavor of the month. Part of her cover involved her fucking other men.

Men like Brandon. He was an asshole, the kind of guy who'd say something mean-spirited and claim it was a joke. The kind of guy who solicited strippers for sex. Yet even still, the thought that Amanda had slept with him arrived with a jolt of adrenaline.

[Me]: so how was she last night?

I'd never texted Brandon on a weekend. I was the new guy, and we weren't friends. This occasion called for it. I wasn't going to get any rest until I knew, even if it was something I didn't want to know.

It took Brandon two torturous hours to respond.

[Brandon]: awesome. she was into it, too, man. can't fake that kind of excitement, if you know what i mean

Then, a couple seconds after, he went ahead and explained what he meant.

[Brandon]: she was so fucking wet

[Brandon]: liked talking dirty, too, man. she fucking begged for it

I imagined Amanda—my Amanda—on her back as Brandon fucked her, her big breasts bouncing, her long legs wrapped around his back. I could hear her screams, her cries for him to fuck her harder, deeper. I imagined her raking her fingers through her sweat-damp hair as she arched her back and came.

She was into it. The cover made her do it, but she liked it.

I...liked it too. My gut burned, but so did my groin. I... I had to tell myself I liked it, too.

Or a part of me did.

I put the phone away and tried to keep my mind on other things. Like what was I going to eat tonight. Or what could I possibly do in the empty hours between now and Monday morning when I could distract myself with work.

I needed to talk to someone before I did something stupid again, like show up at the Gold Club. By the time Saturday evening came around, I knew that I wasn't going to make it. I was already back to scouring the Gold Club's website, looking for the names of managers or owners or anyone who'd be considered "the boss"—as in "the boss's flavor of the month."

I even went so far as driving over there again, assuring myself that I wasn't going to go in. I almost did, instead forcing myself to be satisfied with a slow drive by, like a sad window shopper.

If I drove by again, I'd go in. I knew I would. So I called the first name to come to mind, and possibly the only man I could have talked about this to anyway.

“Hey, David. Twice in one month. To what do I owe the honor?” Ty's jovial voice was infectious, even over the phone. I almost made something up and bailed on this plan. I probably should have.

“Um...”

“Spit it out, man. You're giving me a woody.”

OceanofPDF.com

PERSPECTIVE

“Spit it out, man. You're giving me a woody.”

I laughed, more to clear the nervousness from my voice than out of humor. “So you once said that we could talk...about stuff?”

“Ah, I follow. I follow. Meet me at Leo's out in Hollywood? It's discrete, and away from anyone we'd regularly see.”

A half-hour later, I was sitting at Leo's, a martini bar that was one of the last places I'd figure a guy like Ty Lawrence, Sergeant in the LAPD would haunt. Guess that was kind of the point. Ty hadn't arrived yet, giving me a few precious moments to consider why I'd actually called him. I couldn't very well give him details on the case, of course, but my emotional state was open. Of course, I wasn't sure how much of my emotional state I wanted to share, either.

Ty arrived halfway through my first martini, wearing a graphic t-shirt and a pair of jeans that would have looked completely out of place at Leo's were we not at a Hollywood bar. As far as strange sightings here, Ty would have barely registered had he shown up dressed as Santa Claus.

“Hey, man!” He was loud across the room, raising a large hand and making his way to the bar. “Let's get a booth, yeah?”

I settled my tab without even seeing the price of my drink. My mind was on the conversation ahead. How would I even start it?

Ty didn't really help my state of mind, but he did introduce the subject with bold insensitivity.

"So I was thinking about this. You have a stripper for a wife!" Judging by his intonation, he didn't think this was a negative thing.

I looked at him, wondering once again what the hell was I doing. "Maybe this was a mistake."

Ty reached out and put a hand on my elbow, stopping me. "I'm sorry, man, don't take it like that. Didn't mean to offend."

"I called you because I'm going crazy for that very reason." There was more heat in my words than I'd intended, but I rolled with it. "And here you come in, treating it like I'd just learned that Amanda could speak Chinese."

Ty's brows went up. "Can she?"

"Definitely a mistake," I muttered.

With his sandy blond hair was blown back and the beginnings of a beard coming in, Ty reminded me of a grazing lion—a lazy, unhelpful one.

"I'm sorry, man." He leaned in, setting his thick arms on the table, and released a deep breath. "She is what you want to talk about, right? So what did you learn?"

Before I knew it, I told him almost everything that I knew, short of the name of the club. I told him about my second visit to the strip club, leaving out the part that involved my colleagues doing jasmine before entering, and how Irina had solicited me. I told him about the flavor of the month comment, how I'd been picked up by Julia afterwards.

"You deserved that," Ty said.

"I know," I said. And then I repeated it out of frustration. "I know!"

He didn't say more, letting me go on. I went on, covering Javier Garcia and the contract and last night's celebratory visit to the Gold Club. This was the crux. This was the hardest part.

"I didn't go, I'm not totally stupid. I stayed home, but... I got text updates. They made it into the VIP section, apparently. I've got a pic of Javier with Amanda."

"With *Raven*," Ty corrected.

I shrugged. "Same thing."

Ty was shaking his head before I'd finished. "Not the same. Raven is not your wife. Raven is who she needs to be to do the job. Raven is not who will come home to you when this is all over."

“*Raven* spent the night in Javier and Brandon’s hotel room.” My voice shook with emotion.

Ty grimaced. “I’m sorry, man. Really. But...just remember that it’s not her—”

I lumbered on, compelled by alcohol and too much introspection. The words stumbled to get out. “But does she need to be *Raven* all of the time? It’s one thing to... do things to maintain cover. But why go back to a hotel room with two random guys? Unless they’re wrapped up in this—which I highly doubt—it’s just... sex for sex.”

Ty didn’t have a great answer to this, but I appreciated the empathy that he gave me.

“Amanda...” he began slowly, “is a warrior. Not just a fighter or a soldier.”

“Those are synonyms of the same thing.”

Ty shook his head. “No. A fighter is just someone who fights. A soldier is just a job. But a warrior is a way of life. It’s a state of mind, one who puts everything they have on the line for the greater good. You and I have known her since law school. What drives her is something beyond just herself—”

“Or our marriage,” I muttered.

“But you knew what you were signing up for, David. Please don’t tell me that you thought putting a ring on her meant life in the suburbs with dog walks and book clubs and fuckin’ barbecues with the neighbors or something. She’s not the romantic type. She’s not sentimental. I have never known someone more driven to be a badass than your wife.”

“So why is she...” I swallowed that thought. It was all speculation, all conjecture. I knew he was right. If Amanda was fucking guys out of the club, she was doing it for a reason. And if Amanda was here, she’d tell me to stop speculating about things that I had no answers for.

“Look, I’m really sorry that you’re going through this,” Ty said. “Sucks that you have so little insight into what’s going on. But she did come home the one time—”

“After being away for months—”

“After,” he interjected, “she saw you at the club. I don’t know why she did that, but I have to believe that it had something to do with needing to know that you were still there. That she still had something to come home to, which means that one day, she’ll be home.”

“And in the meantime, she’s fucking my coworker and the boss and everyone in the club.” Speculation again. I needed to get off of that, and I needed to get something else off my chest. Before Ty could go back into consoling mode, I pressed on. “And the thing is...” I took a deep breath. “The thing is, a part of me is, like, turned on by it.” I laughed, hearing the hysteria in it. “I am so fucked up.”

It was Brandon’s text from last night, verbatim, only the circumstances were completely different. That made me laugh even more.

My friend looked at me as if I were a puzzle he couldn’t quite solve. He sat back in his seat and crossed his arms. Heat gathered beneath my collar and filled my face with red. I tried to maintain eye contact with my friend, but couldn’t. Ashamed, I looked away, into my now empty martini glass.

Ty called our server over and ordered us a round of whiskey. “We’re switching to something better,” he explained when she was gone. “No more of this ginny bullshit.”

I nodded, feeling numb.

“So...” He began, then seemed to realize that he didn’t know what to follow it up with.

So I asked a question of my own, one that I’d carried around for years but never had the guts to ask it. “You and Amanda never...” My heart skipped. I raised my brows, unable to even say it aloud. “You know. Did you?”

Ty processed the change of subject quickly. “If I had, how would that make you feel?”

I licked my lips, wishing our drinks were here. “I don’t know. Like I said—”

“You’re so fucked up.” Ty scratched his scruffy beard. “It’s not as crazy as you may think, you know. The way you’re feeling. It’s actually pretty natural.”

I looked at him, wondering if he was fucking with me again. “What’s natural?”

“Well, not natural, but not that uncommon.”

“What are you talking about, Ty?”

“Fantasy of a naughty wife. Takes a lot of forms, but at its core is a wife who sleeps with other men, and a husband who gets off on it.”

“I don’t enjoy it—” I broke off when our server returned with our drinks. I waited until she was gone, then whispered, “I don’t enjoy it.”

Ty eyed me like I was a skittish dog. “You just admitted that it turns you on.”

“That’s different from enjoying it.” I knew how silly that sounded, but it didn’t make it any less true. “Look, here’s how it is. The rational side of me—and I like to think that that’s most of who I am—knows that what she has to do is wrong. Like, really wrong. Disgusting even. And that’s just looking at this from a guy who isn’t married to her. As her husband, the thought of her using her body is...” My stomach fluttered. Jealousy rose up through me, but also something else.

“Is what you’re struggling with,” Ty said. “You hate it, but you also get turned on by it. That’s what I’m trying to say. Stop beating yourself up about it. It’s natural.”

“It’s wrong.”

“That’s your Catholic guilt,” Ty said.

“Doesn’t take being raised Catholic for me to feel guilty about this, man.”

Ty stared at me for a moment before responding, letting the air cool between us. “Look, I won’t tell you how you should feel. Only one who can do that is you. But I want you to confront the facts of the matter. She’s got a job to do, and that job entails some...actions that she normally would never do. And some of those actions turn you on. It may actually be healthier here for you to embrace that, rather than let it eat away at you.”

“And when she comes home?”

“Then she’ll be home. And she’ll be Amanda.”

“And if I want her to still be Raven?” This was the crux of my fear, I realized. This was the source of all my guilt.

Ty recognized that, too, nodding. “Then you talk to her. You work it out together. That’s what people in healthy relationships do, right?”

“In a healthy relationship,” I said, “we would have talked about this before she went off and opened her legs. She can’t hide behind the fact that she’s doing this for the job.”

Ty, surprisingly, didn’t jump right to Amanda’s defense this time. “And I’m not saying that you’re wrong, man. The whole situation is fucked up, and Amanda has always put too much weight on doing what she thought she needed to do, or what she thought was right. I’m not dismissing your concerns. When this is over, take some time. Go away somewhere. Hawaii

or something. Tell her everything. Work through it. Who knows, maybe a part of her enjoyed it, too, and wants to continue..."

Can't fake that kind of excitement... She was so wet... My pants tightened, even as I fought it down.

"That's kind of what I'm concerned about," I said.

"But not just concerned." Ty wasn't being an asshole. He wasn't fucking with me.

"No, not just concerned."

Ty cleared his throat, looking uncomfortable. It was a funny expression for the man. "We did, you know," he said at last.

My breathing went shallow. I felt light-headed. The most frightening thing was that Ty Lawrence, this lion of a man, wasn't looking me in the eyes. "Did...what?"

"It."

He might as well have punched me in the head. I was surprised that I didn't see stars float across my vision.

He looked at me at last. "How does that make you feel, David? And be honest."

"When?"

"Back in our first year in school. And only once. It was before you two were a thing."

I wanted to vomit, but also...also it was exactly what I was hoping to hear. How insane was that? "You two had sex."

"We were drunk. She'd been pining for you for so long, but you were too blind to see it. And then you went out with that chick from our forensics class, remember? And Amanda...didn't take it well."

"I remember the date, but I can't even remember her name." I brushed my hand through my hair. "She really liked me that much?"

"I think you asked her out the next week, and she immediately said yes." Ty chuckled. "Sometimes I forget how dense you can be. Yes, she really did like you that much, and after she and I... after that, she really beat herself up for losing control like that. She made me promise never to tell you about our...thing."

I said, "And now you're telling me."

"I know something new now." He shook the ice in his glass. "So tell me, how does knowing make you feel?"

My hands shook. My teeth practically chattered with adrenaline. It was the past. It was during a time before we were together. It was a secret side of my wife that I'd never known before, and now that I did, it felt like electricity.

Ty nodded as though I'd answered him. Maybe my actions had. The jovial Ty was back with his grin and his lazy lion demeanor. He leaned back into the booth, throwing an arm over the back. "So..." He paused, nodding. I knew what came next, and was already smiling along with him. "You have a stripper for a wife!"

THE CONVERSATION HELPED me cope through the weekend, but only just. Doubt had a way of working its way back, no matter how much I tried to reassure myself. It was hardest at night, when I was alone and curled in my cold, empty bed. Easier when I was at work.

Although of course, with work, there was Brandon. I dreaded that meeting, even though he didn't know that 'Raven' was my wife. How was I going to work with this guy? I'd already begun thinking about revising my resume—once again—when he walked into my office Monday morning.

He looked like he'd just finished a very satisfying meal.

"Good weekend?" I asked.

"Still recovering." He drummed his fingers on his stomach. "But fuck yeah. Javi's flying back to Spain, one happy mother fucker."

My gut squirmed. "So the stripper...?"

"Javi hired her for the whole weekend. I left them to it Saturday morning. Think maybe she sees a sugar daddy there or something. Or saw, anyway. Like I said, he's gone now."

The whole weekend. Amanda had spent the whole weekend with that guy? "No, she wouldn't—" I blurted before I could stop myself.

"What?" Brandon asked. "That shit happens you know. And she was really into the sex. Like, really into it, man."

My gut tightened, even as my pants swelled. I wanted to tell him to shut up. Instead, I asked, "What did you guys do?"

Brandon slapped my desk and laughed. "You know, you play the straight man, but you've got a darker side. I knew it."

I almost told him to forget about it as shame warmed my face. “What can I say? You know I’ve got a thing for the brunette.”

He shook his head. “Unfortunately, not the brunette. We tried getting her to come out with us, but she declined. We ended up with this redhead. Amazing fake tits, man.”

I blinked. This felt like this was some kind of psychological whiplash.

“But no, not the brunette. We tried man. Raven got a lot of our money, and I swear she was interested. But in the end, she turned us down.”

“They’re supposed to make you think they’re interested,” I said. Lamely. Because while it was probably true that she was faking it, a part of me wondered if she wasn’t.

“No, she was, man. Definitely. She liked being naughty. Dancing still turned her on. She wasn’t doing it for money, to support a kid or a habit or anything. She was stripping for some other reason.”

To bust the bad guys, I thought. “How can you tell? She say that?”

Brandon shook his head. “Nah, but I really *can* tell. I’ve been around enough *dancers* to know the ones who treated it as a job and the ones who were into it. And Raven was into it. Trust me. Too bad she doesn’t hook. Such a fucking loss.”

It felt like someone had finally taken a knee off my chest, only to find the pressure was still there. Amanda hadn’t slept with Brandon and Javier, but that didn’t make her innocent. Too many other factors played into my doubt and insecurity. Julia had hinted at it with her story about her undercover prostitution job. Ty had backed it up. And now Brandon told me that my wife was into the job.

“Dude, you okay?” Brandon asked.

I snapped back to my office. Back to Brandon. Back to our conversation. “Sorry, just have my mind on some stuff.”

“Fucking Monday mornings,” Brandon agreed. “They’re the fucking worst.”

An hour later, I got an email with the cryptic subject line: ‘*Watch this when you are alone.*’ I didn’t recognize the sender, and the body of the email only contained a link. Now, I knew I shouldn’t click it. A thing like this was either spam or some way of infecting my computer with something insidious.

Thing was, I’d already been infected. I wasn’t thinking straight about anything.

So I clicked it, and what I saw next blew up my whole world.

OceanofPDF.com

THE VIDEO

“So you want to be a dancer at the Gold Club?”

“Yeah.”

Her voice was sweeter, more deferential than I was used to. But it was the way she was dressed in this video that held my attention—a pair of cut-off jean-shorts so short the pockets hung out, and a white tank top so small it didn't completely cover the lacy edge of her black bra. Her dark hair was pulled back into a high, flirty ponytail and her blue eyes were ringed with dark, thick eyeliner.

“What’s your name?”

“Raven.”

“Hello, Raven. Nice to meet you.”

The voice came from behind the camera, which shook just enough to give me the impression that the man was holding it.

“Hello there.”

Amanda took a step forward, closer to the camera. Her bra was so padded that her cleavage jiggled over the top of it.

“You’ve got the body for this place. And the face. But this ain’t a modeling agency we’re running here. At the Gold Club, you need to be able to strip.”

“Didn’t you call my references?” She batted her lashes, touching her collarbone in a not so subtle gesture to bring attention to her cleavage.

The man behind the camera snorted. *“Why call when you can demonstrate yourself... Raven. Let’s see you strip.”*

The camera panned back just enough that I finally noticed the surroundings. She wasn’t in the club itself, but what looked like one of its offices. The walls were dark maroon, covered in flourishes that made me think of the insides of a Russian manor. The furniture was similarly antique. Old-school.

And beneath it all, like the undercurrent of sex that ran through this recording, was the throbbing beat of the strip club, a steady drive that I’ll forever associate with the place. It ran through the walls like the lifeblood of temptation and lust and sin.

It was to that beat that Amanda began to sway, lifting her hands to her forehead and swinging her hips side-to-side. In all that tight clothing, it put her hourglass body on full display. I’ve watched her dance before—at weddings, at house parties, even in a club or two. I’ve never seen her dance like this before. Never seen her hips move with such erotic hypnosis.

And I’ve definitely never seen her dance with that look in her eyes. They weren’t sleepy, bedroom eyes. She looked at the man behind the camera with eyes wide open, eyes that promised dirty, naughty things. Eyes that wanted it just as much.

I thought about Brandon and what he’d said about her. *She liked being naughty. Dancing turned her on.* Either Amanda was a good faker, or a part of her really was into this. I knew it was probably the former, but that fucked up part of me wished for the latter.

This was Raven, I reminded myself. This was her cover, a character my wife was playing.

That became harder to hold onto when she crossed her arms, grabbed the bottom of her tank top, and peeled it over her head—all in perfect, sinuous time with the music around her. Where had she learned to do that? How much training had gone into this assignment?

“Very nice tits, Raven.”

With her legs planted wide, she reached up, and grasped her breasts through her lacy bra. “You like them?”

“You know I do.”

“They’re real, you know. All natural D cups.”

“Now those are the kind of references I like.”

Now I was having a really hard time believing this was my wife. The Amanda I knew seemed to do everything she could to downplay the size of her breasts. She wanted to be recognized for her abilities, not her physical assets. Raven, on the other hand, relished showing them off.

With her hips still following the beat, she reached down and unsnapped the button of her jean shorts. She lowered them, leaning forward until the entire screen seemed to fill with her deep décolletage.

"You like my body?" she asked the camera directly. I jumped a little, like she could actually see me there. No, she knew that she was playing for an audience as much as for the man speaking. *"You like how I take off my clothes?"*

She rolled her whole body back, left in nothing but her bra, a matching black thong, and a pair of platform heels. Toying with the front clasp of that bra, she asked, *"Should I take off more?"*

"Do it, honey."

"Will I get the job?"

"You don't have it yet. Show me those tits."

She...giggled. It was a husky giggle, laced with sexual promise, but still a giggle. From Amanda. Twisting until her back was to us, she shook her ass, showing off that raven tattoo on her lower back.

I watched as the tension in the bra went slack. She opened it like peeling off a shirt, treating us to the side swells of her unfettered tits. Flipping the bra off, she turned, covering her nipples with her hands. She squeezed them together, kneading them, offering them up.

"You're one fucking tease," the guy said.

"Isn't that what this job's all about?" She winked. *"The tease? The promise?"*

She swiveled around again, lowering herself into his lap.

"Mmm. Excited, big boy?" She undulated along him, grinding her ass into his lap. *"How am I doing?"*

"Pretty fucking good."

Amanda reached up, shaking her dark hair from its ponytail. It rippled around her shoulders before she pushed her hands into it and held it up. She looked at him over her shoulder, laughing breathily. *"You feel pretty fucking good, too."*

She rolled back again, draping her body over him so much that he had to pull the camera up and away. It shifted, showing her breasts. Her nipples

were hard.

“Go ahead. Feel them. See if they’re real,” she said. *“We’re not actually in the club. There are no rules back here.”*

“Oh, baby. They’re so soft.”

“Mmm, that feels good. Pinch my nipples. I love that.”

Did she? I never knew. She never told me. Was it an act? Or a secret? When the man pinched her dark nipples, she gasped with delight.

“Shit, babe, you’re turned on.”

“I’m wet, too. Dancing always makes me wet.” She turned, looking again right into the camera. *“Want to see that?”*

“Hell yeah.”

“Hmm,” she giggled, lifting herself out of his lap. Looking over her shoulder with her ass thrust back, she hooked her thumbs into her thong and pushed it down. *“I can feel your eyes all over me.”*

“Baby, you’re going to do real well here. Real, real well.”

Her panties pulled away from her pussy lips, damp enough that her thong stuck to them. She’d already shaved by this time, and her lips were plump and excited. This may have been a cover, she may have been forced to use her body like this, but at some animal level, something was getting her excited.

She turned, rocked her hip to one side, and set her hand on it, presenting herself in all her full-frontal glory. There was her pussy, smooth and bare and so different from the dark bush I was used to. But so was this attitude. So was this comfort with nudity. Raven wasn’t a woman auditioning for her first gig as a stripper. She was a woman projecting experience.

“So when do I start?”

“I said that you’d do real well, honey. Not that you have the job. Yet.”

My stomach sank as I watched Raven’s face come alive. If any of this made her nervous, she was doing a fine job hiding it. This, what I knew came next, though, she seemed to expect.

“Well, then, let me see if I can convince you...” she said, smiling playfully, meeting the lens of the camera as she sank to her knees between the man’s legs.

This wasn’t happening. It couldn’t be happening. I actually paused the video and looked around. In my own office, with daylight streaming in through the windows and people floating by just beyond my closed door, everything was so normal. Life went on. I barely saw any of it. Instead, I

had my wife's makeup-laden face, her hungry eyes, the way she has a hand frozen on the fly of this man's suit pants.

I could have turned it off now. I should have turned it off. I knew what came next. I didn't need to see it. I didn't need to experience it. It was in the past—probably a month or more ago. And if this was the manager or the boss or whatever, this dude might be fucking her every night.

My stomach roiled at the thought. My scalp prickled.

Yet I reached for the mouse and unpaused the video. I had never felt so drunk on excitement in my life.

"What are you doing?" The man asking the question didn't sound alarmed or surprised. He just wanted her to say it, and my wife didn't disappoint.

"I'm going to take this big cock of yours out and give you a blowjob. You like blowjobs?"

"I do. You like giving them?"

She fished his dick free. It was fat and shockingly erect. She stared at it, admiring it, before shifting her eyes up to him. *"I love sucking cock."*

With that, she grasped his cock, dipped forward, and ran her tongue up the side of the hard shaft. She never looked away from the man—those crystal clear blue eyes locked onto him, like he was all that mattered. She'd done that when she visited me last. Before that, though? I couldn't remember such bold confidence in her sexuality.

"You like that?" she asked sweetly. *"Or am I still too much of a tease?"*

To punctuate her question, she rolled his cockhead between her lips, swirling her tongue before drawing off with a pop.

"That's good, babe," the man groaned. He reached down, brushing her hair to one side so that the camera got a clear shot of this sex act.

"Good? I was hoping you'd think I was bad." I barely recognized her voice. It was softer than my Amanda's, cute in that fucked up, sexy way things could be. She stroked him, licked him, teased his cockhead. *"Let me be bad for you."*

She spit on the tip, a dollop of foamy saliva that drooled along the shaft before she worked it into his skin with her hands. This time, when she licked along him, she went lower, pressing his shaft against his stomach to suck on his balls.

"Your balls are so full," she whispered, swallowing them whole as she jerked his shaft. *"Is all that come for me?"*

The man could only groan a pained, *"Oh..."*

"You want to shoot all that come over my face, don't you?" She spit on his shaft again, only this time, she followed up with her mouth, swallowing half of his thick dick in one smooth motion. Again, she drew back, popping off of him. His cock glittered.

"Or maybe you want to come all over my titties. Is that what you really want?" Even as she asked, she slid up, rubbing the sensitive underside of his cock along her breasts. She teased him with her nipples, dragging his crown across it. *"You want to fuck my tits?"*

She spit another glob of saliva onto his cock. This time, the spit ran down across her breast, and Amanda rubbed it in, using his cock to spread it around.

I sat there stunned. The woman on screen ceased being Amanda, my wife. This was a treat that she had never offered to me, and I never dared to ask. Hell, until that moment, I didn't think Amanda knew what tit-fucking was, despite having tits big enough. Raven, on the other hand, knew exactly what she had, and how to use them.

She rubbed those tits along his cock, sliding it into her cleavage until his balls nestled nicely between them. Then, she spit right between them, the frothy lubricant making me think of come.

"I'll be a good dancer," she said as she wrapped her tits around his cock. *"I'll make you guys a lot of money."* She pressed her palms over her nipples, enclosing his cock into a soft, tunnel of flesh. *"I need this job, baby. Give it to me."*

She tucked her chin down and ran her tongue across his cockhead as it emerged from her cleavage.

"Oh, fuck, babe..."

"You like that, don't you? My big, soft titties wrapped around that cock."

"That's so good."

"I like it, too." She squeezed her tits around him harder, bouncing them along his shaft. It was so hot. I took a screenshot of it, even though this was my work computer. If this video disappeared, I needed to see this to believe it. *"I love the feeling of a nice, big, hard cock between my tits."*

She licked the head again.

"But you know what I like better?"

The man just groaned in response. She took that as a 'what?'

“If it’s big enough, I fucking love choking on a cock.” She drew back, fisting the top half of his cock. *“You’re definitely big enough.”*

She sucked on his balls again, her slurps loud enough to register in the recording over the low thump of techno.

“Want to shove your big cock down my throat?”

I blinked and blinked and blinked, but the video didn’t disappear. It didn’t end. I didn’t wake from a fever-induced dream. No, instead, I watched as the man’s hairy arm swung into view again, grabbed the back of my wife’s head, and dragged her lips up to his cock. She opened them, her eyes alight, and swallowed him all the way to the root.

I watched her gag on it. Watched her eyes flare and water up. The sounds she made were wet and raunchy glugs. Sounds I’ve only heard in porn, and certainly never thought I’d hear from Amanda. But what got to me, what hit me right in the gut, was her face and the excitement laced in her look. She wanted this. She welcomed this. Raven really did love choking on a cock.

I hadn’t realized that I was rubbing myself under my desk until I came right in my pants. Right at work. I looked up, reality hitting me. I half-expected the office to be standing at my door, gawking at the pervert that I was. The door, mercifully, remained closed. My perverted secret was safe.

On screen, Amanda continued to deep throat this stranger, her eyes now begging for his come. She rubbed his balls as more saliva drooled out around her lips, and her free hand, her left, was out of sight.

“Oh, fuck, baby. I’m close.”

She edged him closer with her throat and the disgusting sounds that burbled around his cock.

Then, with a flourish, she pulled back, tightening her fist around the base. *“Tell me I have the job.”*

“You’ve got it.”

“You promise?” She glanced at the camera, addressing whoever this guy’s boss was. *“Because I promise you won’t fucking regret it.”*

“Yes, baby. It’s all yours. I fucking swear.”

“Great!”

She went to work finishing him off, using both hands and her mouth, bobbing with swift, workman-like efficiency. When he was there, rocking his hips up, she pulled back, pointed his cock at her face, and took a blast of come right across the cheek.

The video ended there.
So did the last vestiges of my innocence.

OceanofPDF.com

BOOK 2

OCEANOFFPDF.COM

SETTING EXPECTATIONS

Amanda and I started dating towards the end of our first year in law school, although I had a crush on her long before that. It wasn't just that she was this smart, confident hot chick. Even in law school, most of us were still figuring out how to be adults. Not Amanda. She always seemed to already have everything figured out.

As far as I could tell, she didn't date. After she shut Ty down and he moved on, the three of us fell into a comfortable friendship. She was just one of the boys. Ty speculated that she was a lesbian, but I didn't think so. She was just driven. School came first.

I didn't want to mess up the friendship we had. It also took the pressure off, thinking that we would forever remain friends. I dated exactly one girl in that time, this girl in forensics whose name I don't even remember anymore. It went well for about a week, then it all fell apart. Honestly, I just kept comparing each of them to Amanda.

I was out at a bar with Amanda, commiserating about what a disaster my last date had been. Ty wasn't around, off banging someone new, no doubt. We were drinking. I remember telling her how I wasn't sure what I was looking for in a relationship, but I hadn't found it yet.

Amanda listened and commiserated, but seemed reserved. Later, I'd learn that she was jealous, hated that she was jealous, and was doing her best to keep those emotions in check.

“You’re a great guy, David,” she said. “Have patience. You’ll find her.”

“How about you?” I’d meant it to mean, *Who are you looking for?* or *Who are you seeing?* Amanda interpreted it differently.

She studied me with those amazing blue eyes, cocked her head to the side, and said, “Are you asking me out?”

I immediately understood the confusion, and if I was a little more sober, I would have set the record straight. Instead, I said, “If I was, would you say yes?”

I still think of that smile to this day. For one moment, her always-in-control demeanor fell away, giving me a glimpse of the girl beneath. “I’d give you a chance, sure.”

We dated through the next year, then moved to DC, where we rented a small one-bedroom up in Adams Morgan. It was a short commute to the Department of Justice, where we interned together. It was during this time that I realized that law enforcement wasn’t for me.

Amanda never wavered, though. She knew exactly what she wanted to do. After the internship, she got accepted into the FBI while I went to work for a private firm doing governmental contract law. It was convenient. Quantico wasn’t far away. We found a new place across the river, in Virginia, halfway between Quantico and my office. It was larger, in the suburbs. We had a balcony that looked out over trees, and it felt like we were making a home.

To celebrate, and still living out of boxes, we went out to dinner at an upscale restaurant near our new apartment. The waiting list was 45 minutes, but we weren’t in a rush and went to the bar to wait.

We ordered expensive cocktails that went quickly to our heads. I got up and went to the bathroom, and when I returned, some guy was hitting on Amanda.

Amanda was gorgeous, even when she tried to downplay it. Lean and tall, with dark hair, light eyes, and pale, smooth skin, she didn’t need makeup or tight dresses to be noticed. Her confidence more than made up for it, and I was used to seeing her draw the attention of men everywhere she went. This wasn’t the first time I’d watched someone hit on her. Hell, there was a time, back before we’d started dating, where I’d had to watch Ty flirt with her all the time. I’d learned to cope.

Only that night felt different. Amanda wasn’t downplaying anything. We were celebrating, so she’d put on a short sundress and makeup and

looked breathtaking.

The jealousy that rose through me was like an ache, tightening deep in my gut. The man was good looking in a way that suited her—older than us, but fit and confident. Where I still felt like a boy, even at 26 and working as a lawyer, this guy was an adult, and as he stood there beside Amanda in her dress, they just looked right.

She was shaking her head at whatever he was saying, her posture far from receptive. She wasn't one of those naive women who didn't notice when a man hit on her.

Despair descended on me. How could I compete with this? If she wasn't with me, she'd be here, in that dress, flirting with that man. They'd banter, as they were doing now, but they both knew where it was headed. They'd discuss whose place was closer—hers, since it was just around the block. They'd settle the tab, leave together, making out in doorways, his hands all over her body, and she wouldn't stop him. In the apartment, her dress would come off, his shirt would open. Their kisses would be more passionate, their groping hands more direct. He'd slide a hand into her panties, finding her so wet. He'd kiss her neck, just the way she likes it, as he fingered her and she moaned and—

“David?”

And Amanda was there before me. The man was gone. She didn't look guilty, although I wanted her to. She didn't stammer to explain who the guy was, and when I looked, I found him chatting with his friends, I assumed. They didn't pay Amanda any mind.

“Hey. Sorry, zoned out there.”

“Our table's ready,” she said, a crease forming between her brows. “You okay?”

Yes, now that you're here. No, because one day you'll leave me. I don't know! “I'm good,” I said. “Hungry though.”

Amanda smiled, putting her hands around my arm. “Me too. Come on, let's eat.”

We did just that. We talked about her basic field training schedule and what she'd have to do. She was nervous, despite her time in Afghanistan and how her whole life had been building to this moment, and her nervousness reminded me that she was still a girl, just like I was a boy. She could be vulnerable, but would only show that side to the people she was closest with.

We talked about my job, although I was less excited by it. We talked about the new neighborhood, and how there was so much to explore, and how we'd explore it together.

As we talked, I saw a future with her. More than that, I couldn't imagine one without her. That's why, somewhere between the main course and our dessert menus arriving, I did something incredibly impulsive.

Overcome with emotion, I took her hands in mine, admiring her long, slender fingers, already slightly callused from all the hours she spent in the gym and at the shooting range. She wasn't wearing any nail polish, but then she never did. My pulse thudded between my ears. My heart was going crazy. I had to force myself to look up from her hands to meet her eyes—those large, expressive blue eyes. Her dark hair was loose that night, and shorter back then than it was now, curling in around her pointed chin.

"Will you marry me?" I said before I lost my nerve. No question in my life had felt so right. I still wasn't sure what I wanted to do, career-wise. I didn't know where I wanted to live. I didn't know if I wanted a family or not. But I knew one thing: I wanted to marry Amanda.

Her eyes shimmered. There were very few times in our lives when I'd seen Amanda overcome with emotion—when we'd graduated from Columbia, seeing her father break down when we'd all gone to leave flowers at her mother's grave, getting offered a job with the FBI.

"Oh, David..." She turned her hands in mine, squeezing them right back.

I wasn't expecting anything sappy. Amanda wasn't romantic, and I never thought that she'd start crying and shouting, *'Yes, yes, a thousand times yes!'*

But I also wasn't expecting what she did say. I wasn't expecting the frown that tugged at the edges of her mouth, or the deepening crease between those knitted brows. My heart sank.

"Can I think about it?" she eventually asked. She knew it was the wrong way to answer a marriage proposal, but it seemed to be the only one that she could give.

I tried to play it off, of course. "Sure, of course," I said, even as I felt my insides crumbling. Had I read the situation all wrong? We'd been together for two years. We were living together. We were happy.

I wanted to crawl into a hole and die. Instead, the dessert menus arrived and I ordered the key lime pie.

Some would say, in hindsight, that this was a sign of a future to come. That when she did eventually go undercover as a stripper, I should have looked back on this lack of commitment and not been surprised when she didn't put me first.

But like so many things in life, it wasn't that straightforward.

"UH! UH! UHHH!" I grunted with each thrust, fucking her like I had something to prove. I had one leg up over my shoulder, opening her up wide as I thrust deep. My abs and butt burned. My balls swung full and ready to burst.

"Oh, David!" Amanda gasped beneath me. "David!"

She said my name, but her eyes were closed. Was she thinking of the guy earlier in the bar? Behind those tightly shut eyes, was she fantasizing about a handsome stranger taking her to new and exciting heights? It only made me fuck her harder, faster.

"Ah! Ah!" she moaned.

My imagination took over, twisting my earlier daydream. This time, we were at the bar, only Amanda wasn't single. I'd asked her to marry me, and instead, this guy came over, put a hand on her shoulder, and smirked at me. They didn't say anything. They just got up and left together. The rest played out much the same as before—kissing in doorways, fingering her just inside the apartment. They'd tumble into bed and he'd go down on her, burying his face in her trimmed bush.

"Ngh! Uhn!" Amanda's gasps rose higher and higher. I fucked still harder, more muscles burning, my breathing ragged and desperate.

The nightmarish fantasy continued. The man would climb over Amanda, naked now, his cock substantial. 'Yes,' she'd hiss. '*Do it.*' Nothing more was said. He'd ram home, and she'd cry out—

"Oh! Ohhh!"

And she'd come hard as she felt a real man fill her.

"Come!" she cried.

I gasped. Suddenly I was back in the moment. The man was gone, and it was me fucking into Amanda, my left hand laced in Amanda's right, her body slick and alive beneath me.

“David,” she moaned. Her voice was husky. “David, come... please...”

I didn’t wilt. I didn’t soften. If anything, thinking of that other man, that imagined rival, set me ablaze. I rutted, pounding into her as I barreled towards my own climax. It was like this was the last time I’d fuck her. It was like, now that she’d rejected my proposal, we were on borrowed time. Tomorrow, we’d go our separate ways, but I wanted her to remember tonight.

“I’m... I’m...” I couldn’t even form the words. “Uhhh!” I groaned, my balls swelling, my cock starting to pulse as I blasted deep into her. She seemed to come again, rocking her body up against me, head back, chest forward. She cried out, throaty and raw, only sound, no meaning.

I collapsed onto her. She disentangled from me, reclaiming the leg that was over her shoulder. I rolled onto my side, and she shifted until she was facing me. Suddenly, I wished that I’d rolled the other way, so I didn’t have to face the shame of her rejection.

“That was vigorous,” she said with a contented smile.

I didn’t smile back. I was already disengaging, thinking about what came next—all those messy logistics. Who would keep the apartment? How would we split up the silverware?

“David, we need to talk.”

The dreaded words. I wanted to die. “I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have put you on the spot like that. I just kind of got caught up in the night. In everything.”

Amanda touched my face, her hand soft and loving. “That’s what I love about you, honey. I love your impulsiveness. I wish I could be more like that sometimes. I’m trying to be better, but it’s hard.”

I nodded. She was as Type A as it got. Everything was planned. Everything was carefully considered before it was done.

She went on. “When you asked me to marry you, you know what my first thought was?”

I had no idea, and I wasn’t sure that I wanted to know.

“I thought: *how would having a husband get in the way of my career?* And then I hated myself for thinking that. You don’t deserve someone who thinks that.”

“You’re ambitious. I get that—”

“It’s not just that. It’s not just ambition. I never told you why I’ve wanted to be FBI. I never told you about my mom, and how she died.”

That was true. Amanda kept a lot of her past guarded. I knew that she was an only child, and that she'd lost her mom when she was just fourteen. She was raised by her dad, a cop, and he never remarried. I always figured that she got into law enforcement because of her dad.

She took a deep breath. "When I was fourteen, my mom was murdered. She was a journalist, and was working on this story about a local crime spree when she was killed. The police believed it was a robbery gone wrong, but my dad never believed it. Everyone else just wanted the case closed. It... broke Dad. He was never the same after that. I vowed that I'd never let something like that happen on my watch. That I'd go into law enforcement and make things right."

A lot of things fell into place as I listened. I caught a glimpse of what drove her, but also, for the first time, saw that this woman, who I was so deeply in love with and who always seemed right about everything, could be wrong.

"You don't need to choose," I said. "You know that you can have both things. You're an amazing person. Don't shut yourself off to being happy."

"Oh, David..." The emotion was back in her eyes. Her lower lip quivered. "I love you so much. I'm sorry... about earlier—"

"Don't apologize. I get it. I do. It was too early—"

"No, it's not. I can't imagine a better man than you. I can't imagine a future that doesn't have you in it. I'm just scared. I'm scared of hurting you. I'm scared of wrecking what we have. I'm scared of losing myself in the job and cutting you off from the happiness that *you* deserve, and—"

"And you don't have to worry about that," I said. "I'm going into this with my eyes open."

For the first time in our dating life, they *were* open. I saw all the anxiety that she carried around with her. I could see her insecurity.

"I love you, Amanda. I *accept* you. I don't want you to change. I'm not asking you to choose me over your career."

"But one day, you may regret that," she said.

"Maybe. But I'm willing to take that risk. *Let* me take that risk. I just want to share my life with you, bumps and all. And we'll figure it out together."

Amanda took a long, deep breath. She reached for me, pulling me in for a tight embrace. She was crying, sniffing into my shoulder. I'd never seen her actually cry, yet here she was, the tears streaming down her cheeks, her

lip quivering—crying because I'd asked her to marry me. Not how I'd anticipated that night to go.

"We don't have to talk about it anymore—" I began, but Amanda pulled back and stopped me.

She was smiling. Her tears weren't ones of sadness or regret. "Yes," she said.

"What?"

"Yes, I'll marry you."

It was like hearing a choir of angels. I went from the depths of despair to being lifted up to the heavens. Tears sprang to my own eyes. "Really?"

Amanda had gotten herself under control. She wiped her tears away and fixed her eyes on me. "Really, if you're *really* sure."

"I will always support you, Amanda. I will always be there for you."

"You know what?" She sniffled and laughed all at once. "I believe you. That's what scares me."

"Don't be scared." I smiled, kissing her lips. "Like I said, you can be happy..."

THREE YEARS LATER, I sat before my computer, having just watched my wife give a POV blowjob to some stranger on video, and I thought back to our history. Amanda had warned me, and I'd gone into our future knowing that one day, she might choose her career over us. At the time, I'd told her that she could have both. I'd told her that I'd be there for her, that I'd support her. Did I still believe that now?

I wasn't so sure anymore. I wasn't sure about *anything* anymore.

OUR ROLES

‘**D**id you send this, Julia?’ I responded to the email, pounding at the keyboard like I wanted to punish it. Frustratingly, after sending it, I got no immediate response despite obsessively refreshing my email. After a half hour of that—and with my come cold and uncomfortable in my pants—I told Gary that I was feeling sick and went home.

Unfortunately, home didn’t set my nerves at ease. Free from any distraction at all, I was left alone with all the drama and insecurity. I picked a six-pack up and polished it off well before dinner time. I should have deleted that email and the link that came with it. Instead, I loaded up the video and watched it again and again, jerking off to the sight of Amanda dancing for the guy, stripping for him, fucking him with her tits and mouth. Was she fucking him now, in real life?

It was so shameful. If Amanda knew that I’d started thinking of her as anything less than the ass-kicking, name-taking Federal agent that she was, she’d have been so disappointed in me. I could almost see her downturned mouth and the slight shake of her head.

And what right did she have, judging me? She was the one doing it. She was the one who’d crossed that line without me.

A line that she’d warned me she could one day cross, the other voice in my head reminded me. Maybe not specifically sex, but the sex was part of this particular job—just another aspect. Ty had told me that it was *Raven*

doing this. It was her persona. It was her alias. She would come back to me when this was over, he said, and she would still be Amanda. Did I really believe it?

I wasn't going to the Gold Club. Not again. Not for the third time. I had all kinds of problems, but I wasn't going to do anything to put the woman that I loved in any more danger.

'Just tell me that she's safe. Please.' I wrote back to the mysterious sender, whoever it was. I just wanted to know. I half-expected it to bounce, and definitely not expecting a reply. One came. Almost immediately.

'Do you want to see more?'

Ka-thunk. It was a very good question, one that I mulled over for a long time before answering. Did I want to see more? Yes, no, maybe? I didn't know, other than that I *shouldn't* want to see more.

"Yes," I wrote back, and clicked send before I could come to my senses and delete the email. Of course I wanted to see more, yet after I replied, I was filled with regret. I swooned in my chair, dizzy and sick to my stomach. I wanted to take it back, but it was too late for that. Instead, I sat there, refreshing my browser and waiting for a response. None came.

It was probably a trap. Could it have been Julia sending this? Of course, but this kind of footage just as easily could have been from the bad guys, the organization behind the Gold Club. My heart seized up at the thought of that. If they'd sent it, then I'd just given them the partial name of one of the agents investigating them. Hell, I'd just tipped them off that they were being investigated at all!

I laid my head on the table and ran my fingers through my hair. "How much more can you fuck this up, David?" I asked myself. I was too drunk and confused and tired to answer that, or make any sense out of the rest of it. The nights of terrible sleep caught up to me, and I fell asleep, my dreams were troubled and sexual, filled with snippets and flashes of Raven in her element, doing her thing, enjoying it.

I woke before my alarm, reaching for my phone before the blur of sleep had cleared my eyes. I checked my emails again. Other than some junk mail, the inbox was empty, which made me feel empty, too.

My cock, erect with morning wood, hurt from all the jerking off I'd done yesterday, and a hangover reverberated through my skull.

"You're a fucking moron," I groaned. I wished that I could skip work, but the prospect of another day at home, alone with my thoughts and that

video, was enough motivation to get me into the shower.

Work sucked, but it was quiet enough. There was a lot of paperwork to clean up with the new account Brandon Cruise had landed us. The man was good at reeling them in, but he was piss poor when it came to the details. I liked the details. It's why I was drawn to law, rather than law enforcement. I was the kid who enjoyed board games just to read the rules—hell, I was still that kid.

I did keep checking my email, though, waiting for some response. I was tempted to email again, but I was already in too deep here. I needed to stop, and a part of me half-hoped that maybe I'd never get a response—that maybe my shameful reply had been lost in delivery.

I went home. I watched the blowjob video yet again. I couldn't help myself. It's not every day that you get a video of your wife in her own, personal porn film. I looked for some sign of unease or reluctance and didn't find any.

That made me uneasy for an entirely different set of reasons. Maybe I had her all wrong. She'd told Ty not to tell me about their tryst. Were there others? It kept me up late. It ate at me. Did Amanda ever cheat on me?

I had to call Ty.

"What?" He sounded groggy, and it was only then that I realized how late it was.

"Ty, you said she fucked you before me. Did you do it while we were together?"

"Man, hello to you, too, David. And no. Fuck no. Amanda?"

"I won't hold it against you. Just... I need to know the truth."

"And I'm telling you, we only did it the one time. We were drunk. She was upset. I took advantage and I'm an asshole for it."

"Did she... how was she?" Something stirred inside of me at the question.

"Are you asking me how good the sex was with your wife?"

"I'm asking you how into it she was."

"Fuck, man, it was a while ago. She liked it, I guess."

"You guess."

He groaned. "Fine. She was into it. A total animal, really. For so long, I was so fucking jealous of you, but when I asked for a repeat, she practically dislocated my jaw."

"I thought you touched her ass."

“Well, I did that, too.” He chuckled. “Now what’s this all about?”

“Just trying to make sense of some things.”

“Everything okay? Did something happen?”

I thought about just telling him everything, right then and there. I needed some help. I was adrift, and Ty seemed like a good enough Island as any.

“Everything’s just peachy. Beer soon?”

“I never turn down beer.”

WHEN I STEPPED OUTSIDE of our house the following morning, it was sitting there idling on the street—a BMW X3. Julia was here. Of course she was behind this. Of *course* she sent the video.

A Lyft light was on in the back. I chuckled at that as I climbed in. “Never been in a BMW Lyft. This must be the super premium tier.”

Julia was behind the wheel, wearing dark sunglasses, her hair tucked up under a black baseball hat. “Hey, stranger.”

“Thought you never wanted to see me again,” I said.

“The situation is fluid.” She shrugged. “I’m sure you get it.”

I pulled the door shut. “You sent the video.”

“You liked it, didn’t you?” she shot back. There was a knowing smile beneath her sunglasses.

My face went hot. “No, don’t be—”

“I know how many times you watched it, David. Don’t worry, I don’t judge.”

I had no words. My shame was crushing. Even the tease of the hot blonde masturbating didn’t snap me out of it.

Julia moved on. “You’ve caused quite a snag, you know.” The car drove. I didn’t pay attention to where. I didn’t know *what* to pay attention to. Never in my life had I felt like such a passenger. “Let me tell ya, when your wife joined our team, I had my doubts. We all did. To me, Amanda always seemed pretty uptight. She’s a smart gal, don’t get me wrong, and on paper, she seems perfect, what with the degree and the military history and her stint in narco. But going undercover takes a toll, and not just anyone can handle it. You need to be able to bend, you know? Requires a certain moral

flexibility. Amanda..." Julia shook her head. "...she didn't strike me as the type."

She didn't strike *me* as the type, either. Now that I knew what a UC stint could entail! Well....

"Plus, there was the issue of you," Julia continued. "You were baggage. You tied her back to that version of herself that always played by the rules. Would she be able to do what needed to be done?"

What needed to be done? I wanted to ask, but my tongue was tied.

"But she surprised the hell out of me. It was a little rickety there at first, but she got in and got close. We got so fucking close. And then you showed up that first time at the club and the wheels began to come off."

"What do you mean?"

"The baggage was back, David. All of a sudden, 'Raven' started to have an identity crisis. You know how hard it is to seduce a man when you've got guilt riding you?"

"Seduce...?"

Julia ignored me. "Hirsch started to get worried." Hirsch, the agent in charge of the whole investigation. "He ordered her to go home to see you. I thought that was a terrible idea, but I was overruled. Her cover was already compromised. She needed to check on you, to get her head straight. It sort of worked until you fucking went *back*. This time, she actually saw you, and it became harder for her to maintain her cover. Wasn't good, man."

The car had slowed down. We were pulling into the garage of a high rise luxury apartment complex. "Where are we?"

Again, Julia blew past me like I hadn't spoken. "But don't worry, I think I've got a solution, in no small part thanks to you."

She pulled into a parking space. Now I knew Julia was FBI. She wasn't a threat to me. Even still, as she parked the car, the lizard part of my brain started to panic. What if she was, like, some kind of double agent? What if I was being kidnapped to be held as collateral?

Julia turned to me. "Your task is simple, yet your wife's life may depend on it."

"Way to lay out the stakes."

"The people your wife is mixed up with don't mess around, David. We can't afford to, either."

I nodded. "What can I do?"

"You know what a hotwife is?" Julia asked.

“Like, an attractive married woman?”

“That’s a no,” she said. “A ‘hotwife’ is a married woman who has sex with other men with her husband’s approval. Her husband gets off on it.” She looked at me significantly. “Remind you of anyone?”

I was already shaking my head. “No, that’s not me.”

“Remember, I know how many times you watched that video.”

Shame washed through me, hot and sticky. “I never gave her approval,” I said lamely.

“Hmm, yes, that’s a good point,” Julia acknowledged, although she seemed ready for it. “Makes you more of a cuckold, then.”

That stung but before I could defend myself, Julia had moved on.

“Point remains, though, that her actions turn you on.”

“No! They don’t. I... hate... it makes me...”

“Angry? Upset? Angry? It’s all part of the fetish. Sure, you’re pissed off at her. Maybe you hate her? But you also jerked off watching her blow that guy, right? Tell me I’m wrong.”

My face was bright red. “She betrayed me.”

“And a part of you is *into* it, David. And right now, I need you to embrace that. It’s important. Set aside the anger and any impulses you may have to lash out and burn her up, or whatever. At least until this case is over. What’s important, right now, is that she believes you not only support her, but are turned on by what she’s doing.”

“I don’t think I can do that.”

“But you can, David. You already are doing it. Do what she does best. Compartmentalize all those angry feelings and let everything else loose. She needs you to do that for her, right now. That is your role. You’re the hotwife husband.”

As far as Julia was concerned, the discussion was over. She got out of the car and indicated for me to follow.

I didn’t bother asking where we were going again. No point. I followed her towards the elevators, which we took to the thirtieth floor. I wasn’t a ‘hotwife husband’, right? I may have been a cuckold, but not a willing one.

The door-lined hall had the sterile feel of a hotel, like every room promised some identical form of corporate housing.

Made it all the more surprising when Julia unlocked the door to room 3024 to... a normal apartment. It was clean, but everywhere were signs of life—candid shots of people having fun lined the table at the entrance; a

woman's pair of boots were kicked off by the door; an empty glass sat on the coffee table amidst open mail and thumbed through fashion magazines.

It was the familiar scent that filled the apartment that gave her away. I'd recognize Amanda anywhere—not a perfume or a shampoo, but just... her. This was where Amanda lived. This was where she'd been staying these past few months. This was Raven's home.

I looked at Julia as soon as I realized. "Is she here?"

"Yes." It wasn't Julia speaking. My breath caught in my chest. I turned as Amanda said, "I'm here."

OceanofPDF.com

THE HOTWIFE HUSBAND

“Yes, I’m here.”

And there she was. Amanda as *Amanda*. She wore black leggings and a loose, striped blouse that hung off one shoulder, revealing the slender strap of a black bra. She looked sheepish and shy, fidgeting with her fingers as she stood in the doorway of what must have been the bedroom.

Seeing her standing there before me, every part of me ached. It was like exhaling a breath I’d been holding for weeks. All my anger was gone in that sublime moment. I went to her, pulling her close. She felt warm and real in my arms. She smelled fresh. Before I kissed her, though, I suddenly felt shy about it, this illogical fear of rejection, despite our marriage and our history and our former life.

“You’re here,” I parroted back at her, barely a whisper.

Her smile was warmth on my face. Her smile was relief. We kissed, softly, lovingly, taking our time to reconnect. The last time had been sudden, there and gone in a flash. The last time had been overwhelming, and so much had happened since.

“Hey, you,” she said when we finally broke the kiss.

Julia cleared her throat, reminding us that she was still there. “I’ll let you two... talk. You’ve got two hours, and then you need to get back to the club.”

“Right.” Amanda nodded, and I felt her draw a fortifying breath. She didn’t release me from our embrace. “I’ll be ready.”

“You stay here,” Julia said to me. “I’ll come get you later on. Do *not* leave this apartment.”

Amanda seemed to finally lose her tentativeness. “Is this really necessary, Julia?”

“You know it is.” The blonde’s smile was cruel. “Have fun, you two.”

Things felt awkward between me and Amanda the minute the door closed behind Julia. Suddenly, I didn’t know what to say to her. She looked at me, chewing on her lip, seeming to go through her own struggle as well. She said, “I’m so sorry.”

I wasn’t expecting that, and it threw me off. She nuzzled her forehead to mine, shutting her eyes, trying to find peace but unable to.

“I’m so sorry,” she repeated. When she opened her eyes again, she looked more resolved. “I’ve been awful to you. You don’t deserve that. You guessed right. When they sent me home, it was to check on you. To see if you recognized me.”

“You knew I was there?”

“I did. I didn’t see you, but they told me about it after.” She took me by the hands and guided me to the couch. “They were worried that you’d blow everything.”

“So you came home,” I said. “But you know that I actually *wasn’t* sure until I saw the tattoo, right?”

She nodded. “I told them. I told them that it was a bad idea, but I also... I also, selfishly, wanted to see you again. So I didn’t protest too much. They wanted to make sure that you didn’t come back, just to confirm or something.”

“I wouldn’t have. You know I wouldn’t have—”

“I know. They didn’t.”

“When I told you, you went so... cold,” I said.

She nodded. She didn’t deny it. “I was scared. I know, I know, it’s not an excuse, but I was so scared. I’ve done things... and I was worried that you’d find out and would leave.”

“But Amanda,” I said. Now that I’d had enough time to think this through, I couldn’t just sit there. I stood, starting to pace as she watched me from the couch. “That doesn’t make sense. You said you’d put it back into a

little box when this was over, but you know that's not true. You have to know that."

She nodded. "I do. I told you what I wanted to believe, but you're right. Undercover work changes people," she said. "Especially deep cover work. You have to embody the role. Like method acting. It's sink or swim, and I was determined to swim, damnit." There was the familiar fire in her eyes again. I winced, ready for her to revert back to the invulnerable persona from before. This time, she didn't. This time, her eyes refocused and she saw me. "It all kind of snowballed. Each time I crossed a line, I told myself that this would be it, that I *needed* to do this one thing, and then that was it. Yet I did it over and over. To get in. To infiltrate. To make them all think that I was one of them."

She took a loud, steadying breath in through her nose.

"And in the process, I forgot about you. About us."

"You *forgot* about us? But Amanda, what happened to me being your *whole world*?" Standing there before her, running my hands through my hair, I felt lost. Amanda saw it, too. She reached out to me and took my hand, guiding me back to the sofa beside her.

"I'm sorry, that's not quite right. Maybe..." She squeezed my hand. "Maybe more like I lost *myself*. I got caught up in it. Got wound up in being Raven." She shut her eyes and shook her head. "And when I came home and saw you—that same, sweet man that I'd fallen in love with back in school—I realized who I'd become."

"I..." I still wasn't sure what I wanted to say. I was conflicted. "I knew what I was signing up for, when we got married." I snorted. "Well, I thought I did, anyway. I knew that I'd always share the space in your life with your career. I just never thought it would lead *here*."

"And here's where it ends," she said. "I'm going to get out. Enough is enough."

I knew how hard this was for her. It wasn't a decision that she came to lightly, nor did she come to it just now. Amanda wasn't impulsive like that. Or, at least, she hadn't been before.

"If I'm honest with myself," she said, adding, "which isn't very much these days, then I knew this was what I had to do since I came home for those few days. I was hoping to wrap the case up, but it just seems to slip further and further from me." She clenched her fists, like she could hold on through sheer physicality. "But I can't do it anymore."

Julia had said much the same thing, although she'd tried to pin it all on me. I was the baggage. I'd always *been* the baggage, right from the beginning, no matter what Amanda said about forgetting about us or losing herself.

"I wish you'd told me," I said. "We could have done this together."

"I probably should have, but..."

"But you hid behind protocol," I said.

"I hid behind my own pride." She shook her head, eyes closed, head hung low. "I thought that I could do it all on my own."

And that, right there, was Amanda's critical flaw. Fiercely independent, she took everything on herself. "But you're never alone. You have the other agents. You have Julia and Bradley Hirsch, the rest of the bureau."

She nodded, but didn't seem to agree.

I pressed on. "And now, you've got me again. Open up to me. Let me help you."

She seemed to collapse, her face falling into her hands. "I can't."

I put an arm around her as she began to cry—like I said before, Amanda *never* cried. She shifted, turning in toward me to wrap her arms around my body. I smoothed my hand through her hair, holding her close. "I'm here for you, baby. But you need to meet me halfway."

"You will *hate* me," she blubbered. "And I don't know that I can take that right now. You mean so much to me, David, and I feel like you're slipping away." My stomach squirmed at that. What had she done that she was so frightened to tell me?

"Give me more credit than that," I said, gently, firmly. I kissed the top of her head, then drew back. "I saw the video, you know. The... the blowjob."

"I... know. Julia made sure to text me every time you started it up again."

My face went bright with shame. "She did?"

"She's a real piece of work, that one," Amanda said.

I finally got Julia, though. At least sort of. "In a twisted way, I think she was trying to help. You know why she brought me here?"

"Because I asked her to?" Amanda said.

She did? That was actually comforting, but also not what I was getting at. "She wants me to convince you that I'm the kind of guy who's okay with... with Raven."

“Ah, yes. Makes sense. That one’s always got schemes within schemes.” There was no love lost between the two women.

I pressed on. “But you know something?” I took a deep breath. “She’s not completely wrong.”

“What are you saying?”

“What you did hurt. I didn’t ask for any of this, but despite that...” I took a breath. “...it turned me on.” It really wasn’t a lie. I wasn’t whatever Julia accused me of—a hotwife husband or a cuckold, or whatever—but there was no denying that some aspect of this turned me on. Maybe it was as Ty said, I had a stripper for a wife. “I watched that video, and it killed me a little inside each time—”

“I’m so sorry about that—”

“But I kept watching,” I finished. “I, you know...”

“Jerked off?” Amanda’s question was so casual, another uncomfortable reminder of the woman she’d become.

“Yeah. And I’m so sorry. You’re being exploited. You’re having to sell yourself for this case. I should be disgusted.”

“It’s okay,” she said quietly. She wasn’t looking at me, but instead, was wringing her hands. I knew that face, her expression. She was processing it all, weighing all the angles. “It’s okay, because it... it turns me on, too.”

Boom. The hammer landed.

Yet the blow didn’t knock me down as much as I’d thought. Like I knew that she had this inside of her all along. It was my greatest fear manifest. It was also a fantasy come to life.

Amanda stood, gesturing back at me. “You want a drink?” she asked.

It was 9:30 in the morning. “Please.” And 5 o’clock somewhere else.

I watched her move about the apartment, opening cabinets and pulling out a half-empty bottle of bourbon, marveling at how intimately familiar she was with the place. Because it was *her* place.

“I was raised a Tom Boy, you know?” She poured out a couple glasses of liquor and set them on the island counter between us. “I wanted people to notice me for my abilities, rather than my appearance.” She pushed the glass around as she worked out her confession. “Raven is the opposite. She wants people to notice her looks and ignore the rest of her. It gave me an excuse to be someone I’ve repressed most of my life. Like I said, it happened in little increments. I could tell myself that I was just getting into the role. That I needed to behave a certain way for them to believe me.”

“And then you started to become her,” I helped out, but Amanda shook her head.

“She’s always been there. This just gave me an excuse to let her out.” She picked up the glass and tossed it back, gulping down the booze without even a wince.

She’d said this before, when she visited—that there were things she’d need to do undercover that she’d never do otherwise. I just didn’t have the full context.

I followed her into the kitchen area of the apartment, but kept the island counter between us as she refilled her glass. “Come on, you’re not going to let a girl day-drink alone, are you?”

She held my glass out, and I took it, twisting it around in my hands. Had I been holding her back? Had I kept her from letting loose, the way Raven could let loose? It was too scary a question to ask aloud. Instead, I asked it in a simpler way. “So you like sex?”

Amanda nodded. “I like *dirty* sex.”

My heart hammered. My blood pumped. My pants tightened.

“The things I’ve done, David...” Heat climbed up the base of my skull.

“Tell me.”

Amanda stared at me, weighing the pros and cons. To tell me was a risk. Not to tell me was worse. She finally seemed to realize it. She didn’t dither anymore. She didn’t ask if I *really* wanted to know, because she knew we were past all of that.

“When I first started dancing at the club, I got propositioned. I was with one of the other dancers in the back room, and the guy we were with wanted to fuck her while she ate me out.”

“Jesus,” I whispered.

She looked at her second glass of liquor, her expression almost wistful. Then she tipped the drink back before finishing the story. “We ended up meeting up with him after the club closed. We took turns doing him. I told myself that I had to do it to keep up appearances. That the other stripper might be working for the people we’re going after. That if I didn’t do this, then it would get back to someone that *Raven* doesn’t do extracurriculars. But I knew, even then, that I was rationalizing. I wanted to go back and have sex with a random stranger. I wanted to experience a threesome.”

My mouth was dry. My cock hard. “A threesome? So you and the stripper...?”

“Let’s just say I’m no longer bi-curious.”

“I never knew you *were* bi-curious. That’s what I’m talking about. We could have talked about it. We could have... I don’t know... explored it together.” I colored, realizing how that came off, but Amanda understood what I meant and didn’t tease.

“I know. We never talked about this stuff.” She unscrewed the bottle of bourbon and corrected herself. “*I* didn’t want to talk about it.”

“Because you worried that I’d lose respect for you.”

“Yes,” she confirmed. “And now I might lose you because I *didn’t* talk to you about it.”

“Sometimes the coverup is worse than the crime,” I said. “So it’s just sex?”

“It’s just sex,” she confirmed. “Raven is down to fuck.” I swear, she almost sounded disdainful of her own persona. I circled the counter just as she started to pour another glass for herself.

“You don’t need that,” I said. “I’m not going anywhere.”

She shot a long look from the bottle to me, but capped it anyway.

“I told you before we got married that you don’t need to choose one thing or the other, but you can’t leave me in the dark, either. I need to know where I stand, baby—where *we* stand in this whole mess.”

“You are my husband, and my partner, and my life.” She ran a hand down my arm, lacing her fingers into mine and lifting our hands up between us. “And I won’t leave you out of it anymore. I understand now. It’s just... it’s not easy. And I’m still scared of losing you.”

“Me, too,” I admitted. And then I matched her, vulnerability for vulnerability. “And honestly, I’m... I’m scared that I’ve already *been* replaced by someone—”

“No, David!”

“I’m scared that... that we’re falling apart.”

“I *love* you, David. You have to believe that,” she insisted. “I *need* you to believe it.”

I believed her, yet still I couldn’t just let her off the hook. Saying it was one thing, but she needed to back her words up with action. “These last two weeks have been torture. I can’t go back to that. *We* can’t.” I put my free hand at the small of her back, pulling her close. “You need to start talking to me. Take a risk. Tell me. I want to hear.”

“Okay,” she said quietly.

I decided to help her out, although the question was so hard. “So you like having sex with other men.”

And Amanda nodded.

It made me feel dizzy. I thought of the guy who’d hit on her back on the night of my proposal again. I thought of Ty and how jealous I’d been during his failed pursuit of her, back before we’d even gotten together. Then I thought of Ty’s confession that they’d actually slept together later on.

The angst was still there, and still strong. Even now, even remembering Amanda as Raven dancing in some guy’s lap just last week, left me weak and uneasy. All it would take was a word and she’d let it all go. In less than a week I’d gone from being powerless to having all the control.

When I took a breath, even that was unsteady. We both heard it, the quavery, shaky draw of air into my lungs. I leaned in and kissed her neck. “You like *dirty* sex with other men,” I whispered, kissing her along her jaw. “You like *fucking* other men.”

Our eyes met, and neither wavered anymore. “Yes,” she said. “I do.”

And like that, we were kissing, groping at one another. I lifted her onto the counter as she peeled her loose shirt off. Her black bra made her already full tits look enormous, and I swear she was looking more tanned than the last time I saw her.

“Tell me more,” I said, working on the buttons of my shirt. “Tell me how dirty you can get.”

“I like the submission...” She still sounded tentative, and now I understood why. Amanda was anything but submissive, and she knew it. “Raven gets off when men use her and... so do I.”

I reached up and started to tug at her leggings. She lifted her butt off the counter, helping me out. She wasn’t wearing panties beneath, and her clean shaved snatch opened before me, glistening with excitement.

I moved down between her legs, the smell of her lust heady and strong. “Like how?”

“Like... they come all over my face and tits, and I love it.”

I started eating her, lapping at her pussy, so deliciously smooth. I’d never given Amanda a facial, pretty sure she’d slap me if I did.

“I... I love anal sex.”

“Uhn,” I grunted, shuddering. I looked up at her, just as she unlatched her bra. “You do?”

“Yeah,” she said, less hesitant now. “If he knows what he’s doing.”

So crazy. So wild. She'd *never* done that before. We'd even talked about it once, and she'd said that she had no desire to try. Then again, she'd never shaved her bush or titfucked a stranger to get a stripper job.

Our eyes met. Hers were on fire. "It really does turn you on."

I nodded.

"Turns me on, too, just... thinking about it... thinking about a nice, thick cock... stretching out my tight, little asshole... ahh!"

She seemed to go wetter, groan louder, undulate her hips faster as she talked about it.

"Yes, David. Eat me. Finger me. Make me... make me come..."

I touched her asshole, pressing a finger against it. She gasped, moaning even louder. I applied pressure, and a moment later, the tip easily passed into her, and Amanda went off. She tightened her thighs around my head and raked her fingers through my hair. "Oh, fuck, yes!"

I lapped at her clit, extending her orgasm as it spun up and up. She flopped back on the counter, unable to support herself on her hands any longer, and gulped in oxygen when I finally let her go.

I stumbled back, staring at her naked body, splayed on the island counter like it was a stage. Which made me think of Raven. Which brought me back to the reality of what she had done.

"How many guys have you had sex with as Raven?" Even with the liquid courage and all the adrenaline pumping through my veins, my question felt raw and scary.

Amanda lifted her head, half-propping up on an elbow. "I..."

My jaw tightened, anticipating her claiming ignorance. The Amanda I knew would keep track of how many men, how many women, what she'd done, what she'd been told to do. She'd keep an internal ledger on all of it. She'd know how many men, and if she denied it, we'd be right back to square—

"Twelve," she said. I drew in a sharp breath. She was staring at me, now further propped up. She pushed her dark hair out of her face. "I've fucked twelve guys as Raven."

"Including me?"

"No, not including you. And you're the only one I've fucked as Amanda." She slipped off of the counter and took my hand. "You get to be my lucky thirteen."

She led me into the bedroom—*Raven's* bedroom. Like the rest of the apartment, it looked lived in rather than a set or a prop. There were photos around the mirror of people that I didn't know. On the bedside table, there was a Kindle, the cord of an iPhone charger, two empty glasses—which was very Amanda.

She turned to me, and we were kissing again, so hard that my gums hurt and our teeth clattered. She groped at my shirt, which I hadn't taken off yet, trying to work one button before growing frustrated and tearing it open. The buttons popped as Amanda broke the kiss, breathing hard, like a predator about to pounce.

"So you want to fuck Raven?"

"Yes." I pulled off my torn shirt, feeling her assessment as her gaze traveled along my upper body. It was the first time in a long time I felt judged by my wife. I used to feel that all the time, when I worried how out-of-my-league she was. I felt it now, squeezing my shoulder blades and lowering my shoulders.

"You're hot, David." She ran her fingers along my pectoral muscles. "Good thing, 'cause Raven only fucks hot guys, or rich guys, and you don't strike me as a man with money."

She sat back on the bed, opening her legs without a shred of modesty. "Take your pants off. Show me that cock."

It was like a switch had been flipped in her. She really was Raven now, a version of Amanda unleashed and unbridled. I did as I was told, lowering my pants. My erection sprang free, as full and as long as ever. "Very nice, David. Not quite as big as a thick BBC, but not bad for a white guy."

"BBC?"

"Big, black, cock," she said, enunciating slowly. Her words were devastating in all the right ways, and she knew it.

"You... you like that?"

"Raven likes it all, baby." She caressed my hips with one of her feet. Her toenails were painted red, and on her second toe she wore a small, silver toe ring. "As long as it's hard and the guy knows how to drive it."

She ran her other foot up my shaft, stroking it between her toes in a way that couldn't have been accidental. I gasped, and when I looked at her, she was staring back, eyes wild with mischief.

I leaned into my role, just the way Amanda had leaned into hers as Raven—I was the hotwife husband. I needed to convince her that was who I

was. It wasn't hard, because deep down, I wanted her to be Raven, too.

"You're so fucking hot," I groaned as she jerked me off between her toes.

I crawled over her, kissing her body as she enveloped me in her silky smooth legs. I slotted into her, easily sinking to my balls with a sigh. She was so wet.

"Oh, fuck, Amanda..."

"No, no, dear. You're fucking Raven—"

"No." I found my backbone, straight and titanium strong. "I'm fucking *you*, baby." I braced my hands on either side of her head, staring down at her. "No more games. No more aliases and covers. Whoever you were when you went in, *this* is who you are now."

Her heels dug into my back as I fucked her hard, her lush body rippling beneath me, her full tits bouncing hard.

"Say it," I said. "Let go of it."

"Yes..." Her eyes were shut, her head back and lips parted.

"It's okay, Amanda. We're going to be okay." I kissed her neck. Her blood pulsed just beneath her sweaty skin, a torrent, a river in a storm. "But you're going to need to say it."

"Yes, I'm her. I like sex."

"You've always liked sex."

"I've always liked sex."

I fucked her harder. "You've always wanted *dirty* sex."

"Yes. Fuuuck... yes..." I dipped in, licking the bottom swell of her tit.

"You got off, blowing that guy for the job."

"Mmmm..."

"And getting paid for sex."

"Ugh!"

I thought of her being the flavor of the month. "How does it feel to be some thug's plaything?"

"So... wrong." She said it like it wasn't a bad thing. "I've had to do things..."

"Tell me."

"He... he likes to watch," she said. Even the pronoun—the mere suggestion of another man—was like fire in my veins. "He likes watching me fuck other men."

"And you like to perform for him."

“Mmmm...”

“And now you get to perform for me, too.”

I felt her pussy tighten around my cock as I said it. I couldn't hold my orgasm at bay any longer. I'd edged as far as I could edge. I'd pushed it as far as things would go before toppling headlong into the abyss. I fucked her harder—the way Raven liked it. The way the new Amanda wanted it.

“Yes, baby, that's it...” She raked her fingers through my hair. “Give me your come. Make me yours again.”

Her words were like a shove, and over the edge I flew. I buried myself all the way into her, my dick deep and pulsing. She arched up, pressing her whole body against mine, her heels on my back, her tits against my chest, her mouth against mine. She clenched my hair until my scalp burned. Until I wanted to scream. The pain was like spice sprinkled onto the sweet release of our shared climax. I didn't want it to end.

But it did end, just as everything ends.

OceanofPDF.com

MOVING FORWARD

In the aftermath of the most intense sex of my life, all my insecurities and angst started to creep back in. Fucking Amanda after she'd confessed to the last two and a half months of secret, extramarital liaisons didn't immediately absolve her of her sins. She'd still... cheated. There, I'd said it. Or thought it, at least. Excuse or no excuse, cover or no cover, she'd still had sex with other men—twelve other men—behind my back.

"I know this isn't a dream, but it sure feels like one," Amanda murmured, snuggling up to me. "I keep waiting for that moment when I wake up, and you're gone."

"Yeah, I've had that feeling, too. Maybe this is a shared dream, although..."

"Although?"

I cringed. Why couldn't I have left that statement alone? Why couldn't I quiet the turmoil in my mind? "Just that, maybe, it's not a dream I ever thought I wanted."

Amanda nodded, running her hands along my body, like she was still expecting me to vanish. "Guess that's the thing about dreams—we can't control them, as much as we try. You know I never wanted to get married?"

"Ouch. What a thing to say—"

"I never wanted to get married until I met *you*. You didn't figure into my plans." She laughed at herself. "And I'm so glad that I decided to take that

detour.”

“So is that what this is? A detour?” I asked.

“Yes.” She rose over me, straddling my body. I wasn’t hard, but I wasn’t soft, either, and her smooth mound felt wonderful against my cock. “I will come back to you.” She rolled her hips, reminding me of her stripper training, rubbing me with her pussy. “And I cannot wait to tell you all the naughty things I’ve been up to with Raven.”

“I’d like that,” I said, stiffening enough to slip back into her.

Amanda moaned softly, eyes closed, enjoying my dick as I hardened inside of her. I wondered who she was thinking of now, or what crazy experience, and that speculation got me even harder.

“You’ll tell me everything?” I asked.

“Everything.”

Whatever my reservations were, I was definitely excited, and I loved what this implied—a future that involved her storytelling was a future where we were together. I could get behind that.

“Do what you need to do,” I said as Amanda started to bounce on me faster. “Fuck who you need to fuck.” Saying that outloud was like shooting adrenaline into my veins. “Just remember that I’m here, I’m your partner.”

“Yes!”

“And you don’t need to do any of this alone. Okay?”

“Mmm, David. Thank you. Thank... you...” She came quietly, shuddering and shivering, softly lowering her body onto mine as her orgasms continued to shiver through her. We kissed. I held her. I didn’t want to let go, but knew that she had somewhere to be, and that life needed to go on.

“Remember this,” Amanda said, squeezing me. “I cannot predict the future, and this whole assignment, like dreams, cannot always be controlled. But remember this moment, whenever you’re having doubts. Okay?”

I nodded, and we kissed, slow and languid. “Okay.”

We snuggled for a little longer before Amanda slipped out of bed and went to the shower, needing to start her day.

I glanced into her nightstand. There was a vibrator, a pair of leather handcuffs, and a box of condoms. The box was mostly empty. I started to feel a panic attack coming on, pulse pounding in my ears, chest tightening, my vision blurring.

I swear I could hear Amanda moaning, grunting, begging to be fucked. I looked over at the other side of the bed, and was almost surprised that she wasn't there, vigorously riding some dude. Strangely, the guy looked like the man who'd been hitting on her the night that I'd proposed—a man who'd haunted my dreams ever since. Biting his lower lip and squeezing Amanda's juicy tits, he'd look over at me and say, *'She just needed the excuse, cuck.'*

I sat up, running my fingers through my hair. I ripped the sheets off like they were smothering me, only to find that I was hard again.

Amanda liked sex. She'd always liked it. She'd always wanted dirty sex. It was an honest confession, yet now that I had it, I didn't know what to do with it. It was easy to be upset at the betrayal, but much harder to reconcile my excitement.

I mean, on the one hand, who didn't want a wife who liked to have dirty sex? On the other, I couldn't stop the insecurities that came with that realization. If this was really who she was, if this was the kind of sex that she'd always wanted, had she been just settling with me all these years? Had I been holding her back?

I wandered over to the mirror above her dresser. It was adorned with photos along the edge, all affixed in perfect alignment—that was so Amanda. Most must have been staged or doctored. They depicted trips she never took with vistas in places that she'd never been. There was the one with her and three girlfriends in bikinis so small that I could see most of their bare mounds. There was a photo of her and a young guy at a ski slope somewhere, his arm around her shoulders. That one sent queasy ripples through my insides. Was he one of the twelve?

I could almost buy this fantasy. She looked happy. It made me wonder if she would have been happier without me.

"Only one is real," Amanda said. She was standing in the door of the bathroom, a towel wrapped around her body like a tiny dress, her hair wet. "Can you spot it?"

I searched the photos as she sidled up next to me, smelling clean and fresh. She still used the same shampoo.

I saw it, mixed in amongst all the fantasy—one photo that I actually recognized. It was just a pair of hands, fingers entwined, a simple, golden chain on one wrist.

They were our hands—mine and Amanda’s. I’d finally gotten her a ring, and this was taken the moment just before I’d slipped it on. The fact that she had this here, with all her fake boyfriends and girlfriends, amidst the life of Raven, was like a glitter of hope.

“That one,” I said, pointing. *But how real was it?* I thought. The hope dimmed.

Amanda pulled it off the mirror, where it had been stuck with tape. “I think about this a lot,” she said, quietly. “It was a formality. You’d proposed already. I even told you that I didn’t need a ring. It was old fashioned. Why was it that the woman needed to wear a special piece of jewelry, when men didn’t?”

I remembered us talking about that, too, yet I still wanted to get it for her. I was the romantic, and I wanted that moment.

“But when you took my hand, when you looked into my eyes... when you reached into your pocket, I knew...” Her eyes were now far away, and a smile played across her lips. “I didn’t need a ring, but deep down, I wanted one. And I was so happy when you put it on me.”

It had been only the second time that I’d seen her cry, up until that point. She’d thrown her arms around me before I could get it on and squeezed me until I couldn’t breathe. It all came back to me. That was real. That was genuine.

“Who’s that?” I asked, pointing at the guy she was with at the ski slope.

“An AI image,” Amanda said with a laugh. “All of these are. Pretty good, right?”

“Scary, actually,” I said. “It’s already hard enough to tell what’s real and what’s not.”

This drew a sharp look from Amanda. I’d been trying so hard to hide my insecurities, but she knew me too well. “This is still real, David,” she said, holding up the photograph of our hands. She pressed it back into place, refilling the spot amidst all the fake memories. “You are my rock. You remind me of who I am when even I can sometimes forget.”

Twelve other guys.

You’re the hotwife husband.

That is your role.

“I know,” I said to Amanda, forcing myself out of my own head. “But so is this,” I said, waving at the apartment. “And I want to be a part of it now, too.”

She nodded stiffly, like she wasn't quite sure how to do that, or even if she could. "Are you sure?"

"Yes." And as I said it, I knew it to be true.

She eyed me carefully, slowly nodding. "I'm glad. I never realized how exciting it could be to tell you about all of this—and then when you reclaimed me..." She sighed in delight. I reached up and stroked her cheek. She closed her eyes and leaned into the touch. "I can't wait for that again."

Backing away, she went to her closet and dropped her wet towel to the floor, standing there naked. She was definitely more tanned now.

"I still can't give you all the details of the case," she said as she rifled through her dresses—most of them short. "I've put you too much at risk already. But I won't shut you out, and I'll do my best to include you."

I liked the sound of that—and was scared as hell by it.

Amanda pulled a couple of dresses out and turned. "Which do you think?"

She stood there, completely at ease with the nudity, and at first I couldn't even focus on the dresses—one long, the other so short I wasn't sure it was even a dress. I was too mesmerized by her naked body—my wife who wasn't quite my wife anymore. I couldn't stop staring at her large tits each time she switched dresses, too large for her slender frame. My cock twitched each time she flashed her bald gash. On her hip, there was a reverse tattoo where she must have worn a sticker in a tanning bed—a small sunburst. I wondered if that was one of the things she couldn't talk about.

She shook the dresses, saying, "The short one or the long one?"

"Uh, sorry. The short one."

"I thought you'd say that. You always wanted me to wear dresses like this."

"This sounds like a trap."

"Not a trap. Just an honest question." She pulled on a black thong before stepping into the emerald green dress that I'd chosen, forgoing a bra. The dress was ludicrously short, skin-tight, and entirely backless, fastening behind her neck in a way that teased her side-boob.

"I... I'm not going to lie. When you've got a wife who looks as hot as you, I've definitely fantasized about you wearing something like that."

"You never asked me to put one on," she said. But she also understood where I was coming from.

"You would have smacked me if I did."

There was the smile I loved so much. Her laugh was like a release valve. “Probably.”

“And now?” I asked.

“Now I may entertain the idea.” She winked before moving back into the bathroom to blow dry her hair. It was another change. I’m sure that we owned a blowdryer, but I’d never seen her use it.

I followed her in, sitting on the toilet as she finished with her hair. “Where did you learn to do that?” I asked, watching her apply her makeup with an expertise that I’d never seen from her before.

Amanda was carefully running a mascara pen along her eyelids. “YouTube,” she said, focused on herself in the mirror. “Also, Julia gave me some pointers. Does it look okay?”

She glanced at me. Her lashes looked long and sexy, and she’d put little flourishes of eyeliner at the corners of her eyes. “No, it looks really good. I’m just not used to seeing you wearing that much. And I’m... not sure how I feel.”

She picked up her lipstick, uncapping it, but didn’t apply it at first. Her look softened. “I’m glad that you’re conflicted,” she said. “That’s the man I fell for. If you weren’t, I think we’d have some real problems. I’m... I still struggle with it. With this...” She held up the lipstick. “There isn’t a day that I don’t wake up and wonder what the hell I am doing.”

“And yet you keep doing it.” I licked my lips. “Is it just to catch the bad guys?”

“Yes,” she said firmly—yet I saw the insecurity there. I lowered my head, staring at her flatly. “Yes, mostly. But I’m also discovering things about myself.”

“That you’re going to lock away in a box when this is over?” I didn’t mean to put as much bite behind the question, but it came spilling out anyway.

“I could,” she said, then added, “I think I could.”

“I don’t think you should.” I stood up and got down beside her. “I don’t think that’s healthy. For either of us.”

She nodded.

“When this is over,” I said, “we’ll talk it through. For now, do your thing.”

“Thank you,” she said, emotion threatening to undo her mascara. She took my hand in hers, our fingers entwined. Her smile was Amanda’s smile,

old and new, full of love. “David, again, I’m sorry. About before. And... and I’m sorry for whatever may happen in the future. I don’t have all the answers, and I don’t know what will happen next. Just... trust me, okay?”

I wasn’t ready to do that. Not yet. But I knew what she needed to hear. “Okay. I will.”

“And...” Seemed like there was one more thing she wanted to hold onto. “And don’t trust Julia.”

Not what I was expecting. “I know you don’t like her, but she’s your handler, right? Isn’t trust kind of the name of the game?”

“It should be, yeah.”

She left it at that, so I nodded. “Okay, sure. Don’t trust Julia.” I wasn’t sure that I trusted *anyone*.

Amanda finished applying her makeup as I wrestled with what she meant. We parted at the door. I hugged her tightly, kissing her gently enough that I didn’t mess up her makeup.

“I’ll see you soon, David. Don’t worry. It won’t be like before. I promise.”

I nodded.

“I love you, sweetheart,” she said. “Thank you again for being you.”

“I love you, too, Amanda.”

I WASN’T SUPPOSED to leave until Julia came to get me, so I hung out in Amanda’s fake apartment. My shirt was also torn open, so it wasn’t like I could leave anyway.

I took a shower of my own, clearing my head. I called in to work sick, and then wandered around her apartment, which proved surprisingly normal. There were pots and pans in the cupboard. There were bills to be paid by the door. She had a guitar propped in the corner beside a beginner’s guide to guitar on a stand.

I’m not sure what I was expecting—dildos in the shower, a sitcom set with an empty fridge and fake furniture? Instead, it was just a normal apartment that a young professional would actually live in—a little upscale for a stripper, but not conspicuously so.

I went to the mirror again, needing to remind myself that we were still there, mixed in amongst all of the mess, our hands clasped.

I wandered into her closet, where I found a man's clothing hanging—mostly suits with designer labels that I barely recognized. The shoes were Gucci, polished black and size 12s. It sent a wave of angsty arousal through me. I headed back out into the living room, only to find Julia there, waiting for me just inside the front door. “Done sniffing her panties?” she asked.

I hated this woman. Could I really trust her? Ignoring the comment, I said, “It's all very convincing.”

“Amanda's very convincing, isn't she? You get her head on straight?”

“We had a heart-to-heart. We're good.”

“Are you?” If I didn't know Julia better I would have thought that she was expressing concern.

“I told her that I wanted her to be Raven, and that I want to be a part of it,” I said, simplifying everything.

“And do you?”

The second guessing was getting irritating. “What do I need to do to prove it to you, Julia?”

“Funny you should ask.” She pulled out a folder and set it on Amanda's kitchen table. “Come sit. Let's go over your cover...”

MR. AND MRS. DOWNING

Exactly one week had passed since I'd last been here—one week since I'd been warned to stay away, that my actions were dangerous, that I was fucking their case up. Yet now, I'd been sent back in by the very same people.

Griff, the bouncer, was working the front doors, and as I got out of the Uber, I felt terrified that he'd recognize me. It was irrational—guys came back here all the time. Still, as I approached him and my stomach crawled up my throat, I felt so transparent. Like he would say, “Here to gawk at your wife, cuck?” as he patted me down.

Instead, he didn't show any recognition. Just a blank look as he ran his hands over me and then told me to head on inside.

It was surprisingly busy for a Wednesday night. Both stages were open, and more than half the chairs and tables were full. I forced myself to breathe. I needed to take my pulse down a notch. It was fine. This was all part of the plan. I settled into a chair close to the stage. A redhead was doing a routine, her athletic body twisting and turning on the poll, and I wondered if she was the one Brandon and Javier had spent the weekend with. A blonde in a tiny, black cocktail dress took my drink order, and I wondered if she blew the manager to get the job here, or if she was one who refused. I looked around, and the questions followed.

“Dance?” a woman asked. She had a slight, Southern twang in her voice, and when I looked up at her, I recognized her, but couldn’t immediately place her.

Which, in the context of what I was doing, was fucking terrifying.

Like every other dancer in this place, though, she was stunning. She had sable hair and long bangs that were brushed just out of her dark eyes, a doll-like face that was heavily made up, and a body more voluptuous than Amanda’s—accentuated even more by the gossamer babydoll that squeezed her tits into a shelf.

When I finally was able to dig my gaze out of her cleavage, I saw her smiling down at me. “You can keep looking. Happy to give you a closer look.”

I licked my lips, and she added, “And if you want an extra special look at ‘em, I’m happy to take you into the back for a private dance.”

I fought back the urge to refuse and tell her I’m good just to watch. But that was David talking, and right now, I wasn’t David.

“Let’s just start with a dance out here.” I withdrew a twenty from my wallet, but she didn’t take it from me. Instead, she slipped into my lap, put an arm around my shoulders, and pulled the side of her thong out for me to slip the bill in. She also flashed me a glimpse of her pussy, and the little tab of dark hair above it.

I was proud when my hand didn’t shake as I slipped the twenty in and she snapped her panties in place.

“I’m Misty. What’s yours, honey?”

I recognized her then. She’d danced with Javier when we were in here last week. She’d gone into the back with the Asian stripper to put on a lesbian show for them.

I was supposed to give her my alias’s name, but now I wasn’t so sure. What if she remembered me? What if I have myself up?

Before I could answer, though, someone else answered for me.

“Davey, so sorry I’m late. Got caught up in traffic.”

I looked up, and there was my most unlikely savior. She slipped into the cushioned seat beside me, put a hand on my knee, and kissed me on the lips. It was Julia.

This was damage control, Julia had explained. It was time to establish a cover identity, which was apparently ‘Davey Downing,’ husband to

‘Gillian’, an alias that she’d been developing in parallel with Amanda’s Raven.

My fake wife smiled at Misty. “Hi there. I’m Davey’s wife, Gillian, and you are gorgeous.”

Misty looked at me slyly. “You should have told me your wife was joining us. I love it when other women come in here.”

Julia had transformed. Gone was the badass femme fatale who’d scooped me up. Tonight, she was dressed to party in a short, tight, low-scooped silver sequined dress that left very little to the imagination. Her tits spilled out of the top and her legs looked endless. She could almost pass for a dancer here, especially with her hair half up, the rest coiling down around her shoulders.

She looked at me with her smoky eyes, placed a hand on my arm, and said, “Not that I’m going to hold it against you. I’d be distracted, too.”

The women’s eyes met, and suddenly a different kind of nervousness was fluttering through my veins.

“Your wife is pretty.” Misty said it looking right at Julia, and I had to agree.

“She’s very pretty.”

“This isn’t your first time at a gentlemen’s club together, is it?”

“We like spicing things up,” Julia said. “Davey here likes... watching. Don’t you, Davey.”

“Bit of a voyeur,” said Misty, stroking my arm. “I haven’t started my dance. I could dance for your wife, if you’d prefer.”

I glanced at “Gillian,” who didn’t look the least bit put off by it. “That would be great,” I said.

Misty flowed out of my lap and straddled Julia’s. She said, “I’ll start, but first, you need a drink.”

The music over the PA shifted away from the more traditional strip club rock to a spicy Latin beat. The DJ announced the next set of dancers. “Let’s give it up for two of your favorites: Selena and Raven, dancing the *forbidden* dance.”

My heart skipped. I’d *just* seen Amanda earlier that day, and yet it still felt like an eternity. I watched the stage in anticipation, and I wasn’t alone.

The curtains slid open, and out spun two dancers, arms embraced, doing some sexy approximation of the tango. My wife took on the role of the man—her dark hair was tied back into a tight bun, and she wore a dark suit

jacket, crisp white button up, and thin, black tie. Her pants, however, were tight and short and would have been very inappropriate in the clubs of Argentina.

Selena, her dance partner, was a sexy Latina who wore a flouncy, red dress that seemed designed to flip and flare as Amanda spun her across the stage, flashing the audience with her matching red thong.

“This set is good,” Misty said, watching the sexy tango choreography. “Those two are so sexy together.”

The dance up on stage progressed. I had no idea Amanda knew how to tango. Seemed like there were still a lot of things about her that I didn’t know.

Both women had painted their lips bright red, and as they moved, spun, dipped, and danced, those lips usually remained within inches—a kiss that just didn’t quite resolve.

They stripped, of course. Amanda’s jacket went first, revealing that her white shirt beneath was entirely backless. Selena’s red dress went next, fluttering to the floor, leaving her in that red thong and a tasseled bra. In a flurry, she ripped the tie from Amanda’s shirt—a clip on—as Amanda freed her dark hair from her bun.

Misty had flagged a cocktail waitress down and Julia ordered a Citron and Seven.

I was barely able to focus on them, even though I knew I needed to. Julia was my wife, after all.

“Start a tab?” the waitress asked me.

“Uh, sure.” I had my wallet out, reaching for my credit card when Julia stopped me. She said, “Let me treat, *Davey*.”

My credit card, I realized, had my real name on it. It peeked out, gold and embossed—David Hume—before I slid it back in. When she gathered her purse and retrieved her own card, I caught her alias on it—“Gillian Downing.” Made me feel like a total amateur, which, to be fair, I was.

“Keep it going,” she said. “Bring Davey an IPA, and Misty here...” She raised a brow at the stripper.

Misty said, “An appletini. And thank you, Gillian. You’re sweet.”

“You see, Davey?” Julia said to me. “Someone thinks I’m sweet.”

The stripper laughed and asked, “So how long y’all been married?”

I deferred to the spy on this one. Julia said, “Two years this October.”

“Ah, newlyweds still.”

Julia giggled. She was so good at falling into this role. She said, “Trying to keep it that way, aren’t we, Davey?”

I smiled weakly at her. “Trying.”

On stage, the music peaked and the DJ seamlessly transitioned it into another beat, going from spicy tango to funky hip hop. Amanda and Selena, too, changed their style. With a final flourish that ended with Amanda’s white button-down coming off, freeing her tits, the two moved into a bump-and-grind. Selena became the more dominant, backing Amanda up against the poll.

This time, their red painted lips didn’t just hover. Selena closed the deal, kissing Amanda. I gasped. This wasn’t just a peck on the lips. It was a full on, tongues out, French kiss. With another woman. And the whole time, their bodies kept moving to the beat, legs entwined, pussies against thighs.

This was the other reason I was here. To watch Amanda, and for Amanda to see me watching.

Misty saw me looking. “Sexy, aren’t they?”

“Davey has a thing for Raven. Talks about her all the time, back home.”

Julia had explained it to me before we came here: if I wasn’t going to hide it, own it.

On stage, breaking from the kiss, the two women shifted focus to their audience. Selena faced out as Amanda unsnapped her bra. She had nice, perky tits capped with small, dark nipples.

“Well, there’s a version of this, exclusive to the back room, where Ray wears a strap-on. VIP only.” She wiggled in Julia’s lap. “They love to ‘practice’ that, too.”

Selena reached back and behind her, pulling Amanda into an over-the-shoulder kiss as Amanda pinched Selena’s nipples.

“Watching those too is making me wet as fuck,” Misty said. “Ready for your dance? I need to rub on a hot chick.”

Julia laughed. Her drink arrived and she chugged it like she was nervous. I was pretty sure she was just playing. Misty found the bass of the current song, and in the strobe and flash of the dark interior of the club, the sight of these two women was mesmerizing. I didn’t like Julia. I didn’t know Misty. It didn’t matter. This was hypnotic.

Misty turned away from Julia, her legs on either side of my fake wife’s, her chest thrust forward. Julia couldn’t keep her hands off the stripper,

despite the club's rules. She ran her fingers up Misty's spine. Misty shuddered.

"My husband has a thing for brunettes with big tits. Don't you, baby?" Julia said. With a twist, she undid Misty's babydoll. Misty's tits, like Amanda's, were just a touch too big for her slim body. "It's okay," said Julia. "I've got a thing for them, too."

Misty gyrated in Julia's lap, flipping her long, dark hair back. I'd watched Amanda do this to another man from across the room. I'd watched her look back, a smile of promise and temptation for her customer.

"Does it turn you on?" Misty asked. "Knowing how much your wife likes other women?"

If she only knew... Behind her, Julia smirked at the unintended double entendre.

"Oh, he loves the idea of his wife exploring her bisexual side."

My chest tightened. I glanced towards the stage, unable to help myself. Amanda's booty shorts were gone. She wore only her heels and a g-string, which was stretched as the other stripper moved her fingers inside of it. The audience was eating it up.

"She's very naughty, you know." Julia's words pulled me back to the show right in front of me. Like what was going on up on stage, the secret agent had slipped a hand inside Misty's thong before she could stop it. "Turns out, she loves eating pussy as much as sucking cock."

Misty bucked once at Julia's expert touch before recovering and remembering where she was, and what the rules were. She didn't chide my fake wife, but swiveled once again to face Julia, this time pressing her knee between the blonde's thighs.

"You *are* naughty," Misty said a moment before leaning in and kissing her softly on the mouth. "Get your husband to pay for a private dance and we could do it all."

Julia looked at me. "What do you say, hubby?" she asked. "Want to watch us fool around? I'll even suck your cock while I ride her face."

I just glared at her, shaking my head as Misty finished up her lapdance. Amanda and Selena finished up their set, too, although I was proud to keep my attention—mostly—on Julia as the two had pseudo sex before my very eyes.

As Misty got up to leave, she didn't bother putting her top back on. Instead, she leaned close to me and whispered, "I get off in an hour. Stick

around and I'll fuck your wife for free. For you, I'll give you a nice discount."

I watched her leave, distracted by her swaying ass until Julia slipped into my lap. She was warm and smelled fruity. Her golden hoop earrings tickled my neck as she leaned close and whispered, "What do you think? Take her up on the offer?"

Amanda and Selena descended the stage, to great fanfare. "Give it up for Raven and Selena!" the MC announced. The crowd cheered and whistled.

The two proved very popular, getting called over by several groups before they could even make it all the way through the VIP section to the dressing room. They stopped before an older guy—a silver spoon type used to getting things that he wanted. He was there with a trophy wife, who looked slightly out of her comfort zone as she sipped at her cocktail. Amanda exchanged some quick banter with him—still wearing only her g-string, and not ashamed at all—then a few words with the other stripper before they moved on.

Another man was in the far back, leaning against the passage that headed into the dressing rooms. Arms crossed, impeccably dressed and exuding confidence, this had to be the boss. I'd seen him before, the last two times. Broad shoulders, a narrow waist, thick, wavy salt-and-pepper hair and an impressive beard, he looked like the kind of guy with confidence bred from money. This was the man currently fucking my wife. He was tall and distinguished, late forties or early fifties maybe.

Watching him interact with Amanda confirmed it. They smiled at one another as she sidled up, something unspoken passing between them in a way that didn't happen with Selena. My gut churned, angst and envy roiling my insides.

She didn't kiss him. There were no obvious personal displays of affection. But the way she touched his arm as she passed was enough.

"I think she's back," Julia whispered. "And I can feel how hard that makes you."

I didn't say anything. Just watched the stage, trying to keep myself from getting all tangled up in my own thoughts. Dancers came by, offering to give us dances. I politely declined. A few minutes later, Julia whispered, "Okay, looks like something interesting is happening over there."

I followed her eyes. Amanda was back out, as was Selena. They were once again dressed to tango. Amanda took the lead, speaking with the moneyed customer from earlier, who looked thrilled that she was back. A moment later, the couple rose. Selena linked her arm in the man's, while Amanda guided his girlfriend or wife towards the back.

"Think the strapon will be present?"

"Uhh..."

"Look at him," she said, speaking of the man with the beard. "He's as smitten as you." She nuzzled my neck. "He's got that particular room wired. He's like you, a total voyeur. Maybe that's why she gets on with him so well."

"I'm not like him."

"Well, you're not a drug lord, but let's not paint everything with a large brush."

He was a drug lord? That was a new piece of information.

Julia continued to mess with me, seemingly without realizing what she'd given up. "You at least have similar tastes in women."

"Big-titted brunettes?" I said, repeating her own observation earlier.

Julia laughed. "Was going to say intelligent, strong-willed women with a hidden slutty side, but your description also works." She put an arm around me, like we were a real couple. "You know we have access to that room's recordings, too. We can even watch tonight's performance."

I licked my lips. My heart went wild. "So many questions. Isn't that a bad idea? Also, not sure it's legal—"

"I forgot, you're a lawyer." She kissed my nose. "I also forget how naive you can be. We do it to protect her, and also, maybe, learn a few things about the case. But don't worry, none of it will end up in her file. We'll destroy it all when we wrap the case up. Can't have that sort of thing floating around."

"I see." I sort of did. I also only sort of heard her talking. I was watching the club boss slip out of the room, no doubt heading somewhere private to watch. "Can we go now?"

Julia looked at her watch. "Let me settle our tab. You wait right here, hubby."

She got up. I stayed sitting, watching the stage and the current stripper without actually seeing any of it. My mind was on what was happening in the backroom. Was it just a show? Was it so much more?

Julia came back and guided me out of the club like I was an invalid. “Some night, huh?”

I just grunted.

Out on the street, I was shocked to see Misty standing there, now wearing a tight black dress, chatting with the bouncer. Thought she was off in an hour. When she saw us, she lit up. “I’ll see you tomorrow, Griff,” she said. To Julia: “All set?”

“What...?” I licked my lips, biting back the question that I knew I couldn’t ask.

“I made a little arrangement when I settled the tab,” Julia said. “The problem with strip clubs is that they’re all tease, no action.”

Misty looked at me. “You ready for some action?”

I was acutely aware of Griff’s eyes on me, watching this whole exchange. Could I really do this? Did Amanda know about this setup?

“He’s so cute,” Misty said to Julia.

“He always gets like this when I bring home a hot chick.”

A car that I recognized as Julia’s rolled up, and the valet jumped out and handed the keys to my “wife.” “Ms. Downing,” he said. She slipped him a bill, and then eased onto the driver’s seat like a queen settling onto her throne.

“Feel free to get in the back, you two. Don’t worry, Davey dear. We’re all good.”

I gulped, feeling numb... and turned on as hell. “Okay.” Was I being abducted? I got into the car, with Misty right behind me. “Gillian, I’m not so sure about this...”

Julia pulled away from the curb. She met my eyes in the rearview mirror, then looked at Misty. “Well, at least he used my alias’s name.”

“He did really well,” Misty said. “Probably a little too obsessed with Raven, but at least that’s consistent.”

“What’s...” I was so thrown off. “What’s going on?”

“Oh, right. David, meet Agent Mia Moore. Mia, you know David.”

“Agent?”

“He’s normally a little smarter than this,” Julia said. “A little...”

“He’s just shell-shocked,” Misty/Mia said. “Unless he’s disappointed that we’re not going to have a threesome.”

“Hmm...” Julia said. “That it, David? Mia might be game, and I’m definitely horny as hell.”

“No! No, no. That’s not it. Just... what’s going on?”

“What? You didn’t think we put just one busty brunette agent inside, on the off-chance that our mark picked her, did you? We needed to stack the deck a little.”

“Your wife did what I couldn’t. She caught his eye.”

“And his dick,” Julia said.

“Julia!” Mia said. “Not very appropriate to talk about the man’s wife like that—”

“Relax. He’s into it. Aren’t you, David?”

I wasn’t answering that. “So you were in on it the whole time?”

“I was in earlier than Amanda, but couldn’t quite make an impression.” She glanced at her reflection in the car’s window. “Have to say, as assignments go, it’s been pretty fucking hot.” Our eyes met in the reflection. “But then, I don’t have a husband at home.”

“Mia, could you put the hood on his head?” Julia asked.

Mia sighed.

“Wha—?”

I started to question what they meant by that when a black sack was thrown over my face. Suddenly, I saw only darkness.

SURVEILLANCE

Everything about this night felt surreal, like the recollection of a dream I was currently experiencing. It was out of control. It was wild. But up to this point it had never been never scary. I was with two Federal agents, after all. That lent a certain amount of legitimacy.

With my vision cut off in a tinted vehicle with virtual strangers—agents or not—I was suddenly scared as fuck.

“Julia’s, what’s going on?” I asked as the panic rose.

“Sorry, David. This is necessary. I know you won’t disclose anything, but we can’t let you know where we’re going.”

My stomach squirmed, just as we accelerated out onto the highway. I tried to keep my voice calm. “And where are we going?”

“First, we’re going to drop Mia off. Then... part two of this exciting night. You get to go on surveillance with me.”

“And why do I need a bag on my head again?”

“Because Julia has a flair for the dramatic,” Agent Mia Moore said.

Julia added, “Don’t worry. It’ll be worth it.”

I STAYED QUIET AFTER THAT, stewing. We stopped somewhere, Misty said goodbye. Then we drove on in silence. The car wound and turned and climbed through streets that I couldn't see until at last we pulled to a stop and the hood was yanked away.

I had no clue where we were. I didn't recognize the palm tree-lined street or the large houses along it. I was too new to LA to even place what neighborhood that we were in, other than that it was a wealthy one.

Julia climbed into the backseat with me. I recoiled like she was a wild cat, and she laughed. "Chill, man. I just want to hide behind the tinted windows back here."

Headlights threw stripes along her face, and her attention shifted to something behind me. "Looks like they just got home."

I didn't want to look, but couldn't not. Here was the trainwreck, pulling into the driveway. Here was my worst nightmare come to life. Here was the unspoken fantasy made manifest.

The car—a black Mercedes sedan, sleek and polished under the street lamps—screeched as it barreled into the driveway, stopping abruptly. The sound of the car door opening had that rich, well-made quality to it—German engineering at its finest. A woman's laugh rang out in the otherwise silent street. My wife's laugh. I could tell, even from across the street and through the tinted windows of our SUV.

"Jesus Christ," a man with a thick Russian accent said as he stepped from the driver's side. "Are you trying to make me crash?"

This was the man with the beard and the great hair, standing tall and proud, like a man with money and power. When he reached down and zipped up his fly, I felt instantly sick.

"That's the boss, right?" I asked.

"Nikolai Kozlov. Yes, he's that, but also so much more," Julia said.

The passenger side door opened, and out emerged... Raven. First her legs swung into view, long and bare, wearing black patent leather pumps with spiked heels and bright, red soles. Her dress was short and black, a strapless number that barely covered her ass.

"What can I say? I go all weak in the knees for big cocks." She flowed around the car like mercury, and fell into his arms, pulling him in for a deep, soulful kiss. It felt like a punch to the gut, watching that go on and on, their arms entwining, their tongues dancing back and forth.

Worse than the kiss was what came next—the way they held each other, quietly talking, their heads together, eyes locked. I couldn't hear what they were saying, but it didn't matter. They were into each other. This went beyond pure physical attraction. A man didn't look at a woman like that on pure looks alone, and I couldn't remember the last time Amanda had looked at me with such intensity.

He leaned down and whispered something to her. She giggled, brushing her hair away and smiling up at him. With that, he led her towards the open door of his California mansion.

"Now we get to find out if she really is back," Julia said, handing me a pair of headphones. She put a set on herself, before pulling out her phone. I figured she was going to find that video feed from earlier that night, from the backroom. I'd been thinking of that, too, on the ride over. Told myself that I didn't want to see it, yet was disappointed when that's not what she loaded.

Instead, she hit a button, and I heard the crunch of a leather sofa and the unmistakable sounds of kissing.

"Mmm, you're still so hard," Amanda said. With the headphones on, it was almost like she was speaking directly to me. And to my horror, I realized that she was right—I *was* hard.

Over the headphones, as clear as if it were happening right beside me, I heard the clink of a belt buckle.

"Her purse is the bug," Julia explained. "Can't exactly hide a wire under her clothing, can we?"

"Right," I said shakily. This went beyond a recording, and well beyond any stories or confessions. This was happening just across the street. Every detail felt like a stroke along my balls—the wet slurp as my wife took another man into her mouth, the way he groaned, how she popped off of the tip and whispered, *"You know I'm in love with this cock."*

That couldn't be Amanda. Not being able to see her lent to the denial, yet it was her voice. It was her. I'd watched that video too many times to fully live in denial anymore.

"In backroom, did my guests get the VIP treatment?"

Over the speakers, the sounds of slurping grew louder, mixed with a gag or a choke. Sounds that I'd only ever heard from Amanda on the video I'd watched earlier. Sounds that belonged in the kind of gonzo porn that I don't watch.

I heard her slurp away, and when she spoke, her voice was husky. *"You didn't watch it?"*

"I had to take care of other business. But we will watch it later, together," he said with that thick Russian accent. *"And maybe I just like hearing you talk about it."*

"Okay," Amanda giggled. *"So by VIP treatment, do you mean did he get to watch me fuck his girlfriend with a strapon while Selena rode her face?"*

"Not quite."

"You want to know if I did this to him." More sounds of a blowjob. More gagging. *"Of course I did. There's almost nothing as exciting as a new cock."*

"She knows we're listening," Julia said. *"And she's comfortable with us listening. This is good."*

"You do that so well, solntse."

Amanda responded after a pause. *"You like? How about this?"*

"Uh!"

"You like it when I suck your balls, don't you?"

"It is...good."

I heard a wet fapping, wondering if Amanda was jerking him off, or had gone back to the blowjob. I wished I could see.

Which was the absolute wrong wish to have. What I should want was for all of this to be a bad dream. To have my wife back. To go back to Miami and be normal again.

"I sucked his balls, too," Amanda said. *"And I licked his asshole. Like this..."*

"Ohhh..." Nikolai gasped, grunted, and suddenly I knew he was coming.

"Yes, yes... come all over my face, Nicky. Mr. Clark liked doing that, too. Too bad Selena's not here to clean it off." She giggled. Her voice got quieter as she stepped away, her heels clicking on tile.

"Thank you, David," Julia said. She only sounded partially sarcastic. *"You did it."*

"He's the one you're going after." I thought about Julia's stray comment earlier. *"It's not prostitution, but drugs. And..."* And Ty had mentioned something else early on. *"Jasmine. Jazz. That's the case."*

“As we say, I can neither confirm nor deny, but well done, David.” There was definitely sarcasm there. “Kozlov had always been on our radar, but just as a small-time player. Small until about six months ago, when this new designer drug showed up. But this won’t last much longer. We’re close. There’s a source we need to find—the man who runs the lab where all this shit is created. We don’t know who he is. We don’t know where they meet. But soon, with your wife so close, we’ll get our answer.”

There was a tapping, like long fingernails on glass. I thought it was Amanda’s heels as she returned, but it was so much louder than that. When the tapping stopped and I heard a loud, sharp sniff, I got a little bit more clarity.

“It’s interesting,” Julia said, as calmly as a documentarian’s voice over. “Nikolai Kozlov will not touch jasmine—a good idea, as the pusher shouldn’t get addicted to his own wares. But he sure loves cocaine.”

There was another snort, followed by a deep, hearty exhale, like an athlete getting pumped up before the big game.

This time, the clicking was Amanda’s heels as she returned from cleaning up. I held my breath for her, wondering how she’d navigate the scene. She was a former narc. She was inside to stop more of it from spreading. I glanced at Julia, who was studying me in a way that made me very uncomfortable.

“Those lines for me?” Amanda asked.

My jaw fell open.

“I know how much you like to party,” Kozlov chuckled.

Amanda shared his laugh. Her heels struck the floor. Stopped. My gut was a writhing pit of vipers.

The sharp sniff echoed inside my skull. I shut my eyes as the image of Amanda, the love of my life and someone with one of the strongest moral compasses, snorted a line of cocaine. That model of purity shattered.

Another snort hissed across my eardrums. *“Mmm...”* Amanda sighed. *“Fuck, that’s good.”*

“Time to fuck.” Nikolai’s command was full of steel. *“Take off your clothes.”*

She had to do the drugs to maintain her cover, I rationalized. She had no choice. That was Raven in there. Not my wife. Not the woman I’d watched walk down the aisle for me.

Thing was, as I thought of the woman in that room, my blood pumped red and ready. She wasn't my wife—she was a fantasy. Nikolai's fantasy, certainly, but was she mine, too?

I rubbed my face with my hands, trying to get a handle on the situation and failing spectacularly. So I went back into my comfort zone—my rational zone. "Isn't this going to mess up your case in court?"

"What is? Julia's fixed expression never wavered. "I don't see anything, and all I'm hearing are two people talking about parties."

I didn't know what to say. They were going to look the other way? Just ignore this? Surely the truth would come out and this would damage their case against Kozlov.

Reading my mind, Julia pressed on. "Doesn't matter though. These recordings will never make it to a courtroom. This isn't a sting."

"I don't understand."

"We told you there were certain... compromises that needed to be made. *She* told you. We're gathering intel, not evidence. Part of that requires a certain... authenticity."

"Ah!" I turned back towards the house, like I could see through its walls, see the lurid act as it happened. Amanda's cry was unmistakable. I'd heard it hundreds of times when we were together. But had it always been so loud? So passionate.

"Fuck, you're big," she said.

"Just like you like it."

"You know me so well," Raven cried. "The bigger, the better."

"Such a size queen. Was Mr. Clark big enough for you?"

"Mmm, yes... he had a really... nice... uhh... cock..."

"She needed to become Nikolai Kozlov's fantasy woman—a hedonist cut from the same cloth as he is."

"Uh, yes!" Amanda moaned. "Right there. Yes!"

"Like I said before, I never thought Amanda would be able to handle it, but she's proved to be very... flexible."

A wet slap registered through the mic. Amanda cried out. That primal instinct to charge to the rescue seized me. I actually reached for the door as a second spank landed. This time, I heard something else in Amanda's reaction. She wasn't crying for help. She was into it.

"Harder," Amanda gasped. "Fuck me harder."

"You hear them? You hear your wife?"

"Oh, yes. Yes!" Amanda's voice cracked. Her scream filled the headphones, cruelly crystal clear.

"She's not faking. She hasn't faked it once since she's gone under. That girl loves sex, and now that we know you love that she does, too, all is good."

"Know what I liked most about tonight?" Amanda's voice was ragged with the sex. "I liked when Selena put on the strapon while I was... fucking... Mr. Clark..."

"I liked this part, too," Kozlov said. "You liked the anal sex, yes?"

"You know I do—OOOO!"

"So tight."

"Yes, reclaim my ass... reclaim my pussy... reclaim my body, Nicky!"

"You liked the DP?"

"I'm ready," she gasped. "I'm ready to try for real."

"I think that you are."

Julia clapped her hands. "Now we're officially back on track."

"What?"

But she was done feeding me information. She was already climbing up into the front seat, and I felt disappointment take over. I wanted to stay. At least then, I got to be a part of whatever this was with my wife.

"Want to stick around?" Julia asked, looking at me in the rear view mirror. "There are some tissues back there to jerk off into."

I said nothing. Julia had this way of making a man feel really small.

"I'm close... I'm close... fuck my ass... fuck it... fuck it into my ass!"

Nikolai Kozlov released a roar as he popped. Amanda was right there with him, screaming her head off at her own orgasm. "Oh, yes! Oh, yes, it's so hot... so hot in my ass! I love it. I love it so fucking much!"

"No, it's okay. We can go," I said.

Julia smirked.

"Put on the recording. I want to watch it."

"Of course, my little exhibitionist."

The tapping was back. "More coke?" she offered.

"You are exquisite, solntse. Simply exquisite. Ladies first..."

Last thing I heard before taking the headphones off was Amanda saying, "Such a gentleman."

The car pulled away from the curb as Amanda's long sniff rang in my ears. I flung the headphones against the front windshield, hoping to crack it,

then pulled the sack on voluntarily, although I was so shell-shocked that I couldn't have told you where we were anyway. I wasn't processing the world around me. I was lost in my imagination. They were fucking, bodies glistening, holding one another, staring at one another, kissing one another. She'd stay with him all night. She'd sleep in his arms. They would have breakfast together after the morning sex.

"... wife's a professional, and she knows what she's doing." I wasn't sure if Julia was finally having pity on me, or just explaining what came next. I barely heard her, like trying to interpret someone else's echo. "You did well, David. You did really well tonight."

"What *did* we do, anyway?"

"We fully established our cover," she said, back to treating me like a simpleton.

"For what purpose?"

"Ah, yes. Why, for the grand finale, of course."

OceanofPDF.com

MALIBU

After two of the most intense days of my life, I was expected to just go back to work like my life was totally normal. It was Wednesday. Hump Day. Just an easy coast into the weekend after this one. There were briefs to file. There were clients to meet with. There was the grind.

The link to the BJ video was dead, and the second time I logged in, even the emails had been erased. My memories lived on—stirring up a confusing cloud of anxiety and excitement. Raven was at the other extreme of Amanda, and yet they were one and the same.

So hot in my ass... I love it so fucking much...

You know I'm in love with this cock...

Yes, reclaim my ass... reclaim my pussy... reclaim my body...

It wasn't me she was asking to reclaim. It wasn't me that she shared a bed with at the end of the day.

There wasn't a moment that went by where some new detail didn't creep into the back of my head. The tango with another woman. Her confession that she'd eaten another man's ass. The sound of her snorting cocaine, or the realization that she'd done it before. Who was this woman, and had she always been there? She seemed to be the near-total opposite of the Amanda I'd married. But was she?

She snuck into our bedroom early Friday morning, her naked body warm and smelling like fruity shampoo. I thought it was just a very realistic

dream at first—the way she kissed me, the way she slowly stripped me, the way she sank beneath the sheets to suck my cock..

“Amanda?” I looked at the clock. It was 6:30 in the morning.

She pulled the sheets back and looked up at me. She was makeup free, her hair back in a loose ponytail, bangs escaping. “I’m here.”

Seeing me start to wake, she crawled up my body and guided my cock into her pussy.

“Is this a dream?”

She shook her head as she sank onto me. “I needed to see you so you could reclaim me.” She sighed as she relaxed, my cock fully buried. “I told you that it would be different than before. I wanted to come sooner, but couldn’t get away.”

“You were with him?” Just asking caused my cock to throb.

She nodded. “Since the night you watched me dance. He asked me to move in with him.”

“And you said yes.” I knew I was being petulant. At the same time, my cock was only hardening.

“It’s not real, David.” She squeezed me. “This is.”

“Right, I know. You’re just... *very* convincing.”

“I need to be. I’m his fantasy. Nick is someone who... craves adoration.” *Nick*, she called him. Not *Nikolai*. Not *Kozlov*. Not *the target*. “But he doesn’t just want someone who will lie there for him. He wants someone who enjoys it.”

“And you enjoy it.”

“Some of it, yes.”

“You like the sex,” I said. We’d gone over that. “The drugs? Did you really...?”

“You heard that,” she said, quietly to herself. “Yes, Nick has certain... fetishes. The pursuit of pleasure above all else is his greatest aphrodisiac. I don’t do it often, and only with him. I’m not addicted.”

“And I’m not saying you are.”

“You don’t have to worry,” she said. The defensiveness had drained away, replaced by something more reassuring. “I’ve done it because I have to, not because I want to.”

“But it’s another thing that you two have shared that we haven’t.”

“You want to do some rails with me?” she said with a smile.

“No, of course not,” I said. “That’s... that’s not what I meant.”

“I know what you meant. Shared intimacy, shared experiences. I understand.”

I pulled her close. “And I understand you. I’m sorry. You do what you have to do.”

She said, “When this is over—”

“It can be over,” I completed.

“I was actually going to say that when this is over, we find some new, shared and *intimate* experiences to have together.”

“I like that.”

She snuggled close and said, “Whatever we do when this is over, we get to figure it out. Together.”

HER VISIT HELPED... for a bit. Got me through Friday, at least, but when the weekend arrived and I was home alone, looking at the plants and telling myself that I needed to water them, my insecurities came roaring back. I didn’t have a cock like “Nick.” I didn’t have money or power. I didn’t have a dangerous, wild side. Maybe I was good enough for Amanda. Raven? I wasn’t so sure.

Saturday afternoon, I got a text before my worries spun too far out of control—not from Amanda, but from Julia, of course.

Mr. and Mrs. Downing have plans tonight in Malibu. I’ll be by around 8. Make sure to shower.

And that was it. No question, no ask, no, ‘*Hey, you doing okay?*’ But honestly, I was good with it. Helped give me something to do. Helped focus my mind.

I took a long shower, inevitably thinking about Amanda doing the same in Nikolas Kozlov’s fancy home. Maybe he was there with her. Maybe he forced her to her knees so she could suck the dick that she loved so much.

I wanted to get off, but I didn’t. Instead, I exited the shower, properly edged. Whatever was going to happen tonight, I needed to be at my sharpest.

Julia arrived wearing a leopard-print party dress—back to full-on Gillian Downing vamp. She handed me a garment bag. “Get ready, Davey dear. We’re about to go where only the rich and beautiful go.”

WHEN I THOUGHT OF MALIBU, I pictured expensive homes that sit between the beach and the hills—many of them in stilts. Images of vacations and relaxation, lying out in the sun or surfing or even just frolicking in the waves, the word itself called all of these and more, to mind. “Malibu” didn’t conjure thoughts of bars and a nightlife. I guess I didn’t have the best of imaginations.

Malibu’s Living Room wasn’t a typical bar. It was more like one giant, sprawling house built on the edge of the Pacific, unmarked from the outside other than a parking lot filled with fancy cars.

When we approached the doors to the Living Room, the bouncers recognized her. “Mrs. Downing,” said a mountain of a man in a thick, Russian accent. Looking at me, he simply said, “No guests. You know the rules.”

“This is my husband, Davey,” she said. “Check your list again. He’s always been on it.”

The man gave me a skeptical look, as if he were thinking, *‘No fucking way he’s with her.’* But he did consult his tablet, tapping a few times before frowning. “I didn’t think he was real.”

Julia reached out, brushing her fingers along the bouncer’s cheek. “Don’t worry, Boris. Davey here gets turned on when other men play with his wife. Don’t you, dear.”

She was really enjoying this more than she should. I nodded, putting on as confident a smile as I could as I looked at the bouncer. “Maybe if you get a break, Gilly here will suck your dick while I watch.”

“Come on, Davey,” Julia said, whisking me away before I could cause more trouble. “Bye, Boris.”

The scene inside of the Living Room was more like that of a house party than a club. Room after room was filled with sofas and loungers, conversation areas and seemingly makeshift dance floors. DJs spun electronica. The lighting was low, with a black light here and a strobe there.

Beyond, the sun made its final descent on the far horizon. Some gathered outside, along the balcony, drinking and flirting. Some were nestled into alcoves, masked in velvety drapes, getting close and talking quietly.

‘You’ll need to be discreet,’ Julia had said on our way over here. ‘This isn’t the Gold Club. It’s not associated with our targets and we don’t have the proper warrants.’

‘So what is it?’

‘It’s a playground for rich people to have fun, and your wife’s friend, Nikolai, is a frequent patron.’

I searched for them as we walked in, remembering my instructions to be discreet yet unable to carry through. “You’re looking like a fucking tourist,” Julia muttered.

We were walking by a short stretch of bar where a woman was laid out, her shirt lifted to just under her breasts, as another woman drank tequila out of her pierced navel. I tore my eyes away and looked at Julia. “I mean...”

Julia glanced towards the dance floor in the next room. The last rays of the sun turned the dancers into silhouettes, bouncing and rocking to the music, arms and legs swaying like reeds in the wind. I knew Amanda well enough to pick her out, even just as a shadow. I knew how she danced, cocking her head and tossing her long, loose hair as she felt the music. Her movements were different here than in the strip club. Here, she was more carefree.

I forgot all about the girls doing body shots behind me, and my heart, already beating fast, took off.

Julia got very close, blocking my view—close enough that I could smell her unfamiliar perfume and see the specks of makeup. Her breasts pressed against my chest as she leaned in and whispered, “There aren’t many watching here, but you can’t do this. Remember, don’t fucking stare—and definitely don’t stare at her.”

“Why did we even come then?”

“‘Cuz you want to see her work, and we need to make sure that she wants it, too.” She guided me to the bar, where the woman was just sitting up. “Aw, I was hoping you came with the drinks,” Julia said to her.

The woman was hot, her hair fading from dark gold to bubble gum pink in a trendy ombré. She glanced at Julia, taking in my fake wife’s leopard print dress and hot body, then over to me. “You want a drink, too?”

Julia answered for me. “No, my husband likes to watch.”

That seemed to please the girl. She smiled and turned to the bartender stationed opposite us. “One more for the blonde.”

The girl pulled her legs back up onto the bartop, leaned back, and lifted her shirt. Her skirt was short and pleated, like the fantasy version of a Catholic school uniform, and she had a very flat stomach. Sprinkling salt just below her navel, the bartender handed her a lime, which she set into her cleavage and looked excitedly at us.

“Hold my purse, dear,” Julia said. She climbed up onto the bar herself, almost like she was going to go down on the pink-haired girl. Instead, she lapped slowly at the salt on her lower belly, making sure to meet the girl’s eyes. The bartender poured a healthy amount of tequila into her navel, which Julia slurped up.

“Fuck, that’s hot,” someone said behind me.

Julia moved up the girl’s body, kissing along her stomach and snapping the lime out of her cleavage. Biting into it, juice dribbled down her chin. She plucked it out, tossed it to the bar, and leaned in. Before I could get a handle on how turned on I was, Julia was kissing the other girl, their tongues twisting and playing.

“Thank you for the drink,” Julia said huskily, hopping off the bar. To the bartender, who stood there with his mouth as gaping as mine, she said, “Can I get a couple more for my husband? Glasses are fine.”

“Uh... yes.”

“I thought we were supposed to be discreet?” I said after the tequila shots. We migrated outside, drinking more reasonable—yet still very strong—cocktails.

“Discreet means not sticking out.” She turned, elbows on the railing, her back to the ocean. Her eyes were on something inside as she sipped her drink. “Our girl in there gets it.”

I was proud that I didn’t immediately look. That earned an approving nod from Julia. Instead, I leaned on the railing, facing out. The sun had set. Night was here to announce the start of the party. I could feel it waking up behind me, but out there, on the dark ocean, all was calm. “This place is really something.”

“They screen everyone who comes in. Background checks, NDAs—don’t worry, ‘Davey’ got those, too—a hefty membership fee. Puts the clientele at ease.” She continued to focus on whatever was going on inside. “You can look now. In fact, you really should.”

I turned around as casually as I could. Like most bars and clubs in southern California, the Living Room was built with indoor and outdoor

spaces in mind. A series of French doors were propped open, affording us a good view onto the dance floor.

I found Amanda in the midst of it all, arms up, grinding between two muscular black men. The vision struck me like something physical, and I was glad that I was leaning. She'd transformed herself yet again. Her dark hair was now formed into cornrows that met in four braids down her back. Paired with a strapless, short, maroon bodycon dress and tall heels, I barely recognized her. Only it was definitely her. I knew the way she moved. I knew her mannerisms.

Like she sensed me, Amanda looked out from between the two guys. Our eyes met for only a second, but the connection was just as real as a caress on the cheek.

Her focus, however, wasn't on me. She didn't linger, even for a moment. Anyone looking would just see her scanning the small gathering outside before fixing on something off to our right.

"You know them?" I asked Julia. Really, though, I was looking beyond her, to whatever Amanda was looking at. I saw Nikolai Kozlov, of course, standing there, vape pen in hand, shamelessly staring back at her.

"We don't know them," Julia said, "but you also need to stop staring."

"Right." I looked at Julia. "Got it. So why isn't he in there, dancing with her?"

Julia had this way of smiling at me that made me feel small and naive. She did it all the time. She did it now. "Told you he's like you. He likes to watch."

Out of the corner of my eye, I saw Kozlov nod. Glancing back into the club, I was just in time to see Amanda reach out to the black guy in front of her and pull him down for a deep, searing kiss. Behind her, the other guy palmed her tits.

Other than me and Nikolai, no one else seemed to notice. They weren't the only ones making out on the dance floor, and just beyond, on the couches and in the alcoves, things had really started to feel like a house party.

"They come here to meet other men." Julia caressed me, keeping her voice low as we people watched. "He likes to watch her dance." Her hand dropped lower, brushing over my crotch. "Just like you."

She squeezed my erection. I gasped. "Makes sense, considering where he works."

Inside, Amanda broke the kiss with the one man only to turn her head and start making out with the guy behind her.

Julia said, "It's definitely nice when we love our jobs, don't you think?"

The DJ's set ended, and Amanda left the two guys with some kind of whispered promise before prancing outside. She ignored me completely, her playful smile reserved for another man. It cut deep. I was part of the furniture.

"Having fun?" I could just hear Kozlov ask, his Russian accent thick.

"You know it." It hurt even more when she kissed him. This kiss was somehow different than with the black guys. She had a familiarity with this man that felt like a betrayal. "I love it when you watch me."

She didn't look at me, and I felt excluded. It wasn't some double entendre, meant for the both of us. There was an intimacy between her and this other man, wholly apart from what we shared.

I couldn't hear the rest of their exchange, although I could feel their intimacy, hearing it in Amanda's laughs, seeing it in the way she clung to him when they entered the interior once again. Her braids bobbed and bounced in the small of her back, like dark asps nipping and fighting.

"Well, she definitely doesn't have a problem being Raven in front of you anymore," Julia said. "I'll be honest, I definitely thought this case was fucked. She was on a guilt-ridden downward spiral."

The two black guys had moved over to the bar—now free of anyone taking body shots—and were drinking and chatting with one another when Amanda and Kozlov approached them.

"What happens now?" I asked.

"Really?" Julia said, looking at me incredulously.

"I mean with me. I guess we leave?"

"We could." Julia toyed with the buttons on my shirt. She studied my chest before swinging her eyes hungrily up to mine. "Or we could watch..."

I had no idea how to respond. "What?"

"You didn't really think all the security and discretion going on here was just so that some rich fucks could dance, did you?"

"Still not following."

"This is the *literal* living room." She caressed my chest, looking around. "And while fun things can certainly happen on the couches..." She seemed to focus on one of those fun things happening behind me, "...the real action is in the bedroom, right?"

“Sure.” And then, because I *still* wasn’t following, “What the fuck are you talking about?”

“This is a swinger’s club for the most elite. In the back rooms are bedrooms. Some are for private get-togethers. Others are more public. Can you guess which one Nikolai, owner of a strip club, prefers to take his girls to?”

“You serious?”

Julia bit her tongue playfully. “Want to watch?”

“Lead the way.”

OceanofPDF.com

THE MASTER BEDROOM

Julia led me past a couple of bouncers into an even more exclusive part of the club. They didn't question us this time, and when Julia nodded at them, they seemed to know her.

"Been here before, my naughty wife?" I whispered, tugging her close.

I was still tipsy from the drink and the buzz of watching my real wife dance and flirt with other men. Still, it felt odd to cuddle up to a woman I didn't trust and didn't really like, and suddenly feeling affection for her. Looking around, I realized she was my only lifeline in this world, and indirectly, to Amanda.

"Scouting missions, my husband," she said. "Had to see if it was the kind of scene my cuckold husband would be into." And that's why I still really didn't like her. She added in a conspiratorial whisper, "I think you'll really enjoy the show."

We ascended a staircase to the club's second story—a long hallway, well appointed, its walls adorned with photos like it was a suburban home. Only the photos were not of families, but of people having sex. Some of the doors along the hall were open, revealing luxurious bedrooms. Many were closed, the sounds of moaning issuing through them.

And finally, we arrived at the master bedroom—a pair of double doors that were propped open, despite the room already being occupied.

My hands felt clammy as we approached, and my heart pounded like a hammer in my ears. Julia sensed it, her cruelty softening. “Don’t be nervous, Davey. You’re about to enter a world where the only rule is pleasure and hedonism. Whatever you may see has *nothing* to do with... our marriage.”

Julia surprised me by pulling me close and kissing me on the mouth. I resisted for only a moment before remembering who she was supposed to be—who we both were. I relaxed as I gave in to the kiss, into her compact body, her wet mouth, her soft lips.

“You’re hot, David,” she said in a whisper, meant just for us. “I’ll confess, as much as you can piss me off, I’ve always wanted to fuck you.” She laughed, pulling back. “Guess that really does make us married, hm?”

She linked her arm in mine and led me into the Master Bedroom.

I had no idea what to expect. Certainly not what I saw, though, which was essentially an ongoing orgy. The bed was beyond any size bed that I’d ever seen, tiered in places and spread out like a series of stacked kings. Everything was covered in red linens, from the pillows to the sheets to the drapery. Along that wall were couches and chairs where spectators could sit, watch, drink, and play.

There were already two couples on the bed, the women on their backs, the men between their legs fucking them. I barely saw them, because on the opposite side of the gigantic bed sat my wife.

She was seated on the edge with her two black suitors on either side of her. She was kissing one while the other nuzzled her neck and palmed her tits through her tight, maroon dress. Her hands were not idle, either, both resting in the guys’ laps, rubbing their prominent bulges through their slacks.

I felt thunderstruck. Watching her dance earlier didn’t prepare me for this. Hearing her confess about loving dirty sex felt abstract. Even watching her sucking another man’s dick on video paled in comparison to the storm I felt now.

Julia guided me to a loveseat close by Amanda. Discretion was gone. Subtlety had no place here. I didn’t need to stare at Amanda furtively across the room. Here, she was on display. Here, I could watch nakedly.

“This seat taken?” Julia asked. I was so out of it that I didn’t know who she was talking to at first.

“Not anymore,” came a Russian-accented reply. There was Nikolai before us, sitting alone on his own sofa. He tipped a vial of white powder onto the web of his right hand, between thumb and forefinger, raised it to his nose, and snorted it up. “Please. Enjoy.”

He turned back to Amanda, and like that we were forgotten. If I hadn’t felt underwater before then, I was all the way at the bottom of the deep end now.

The guys had pushed her strapless dress down, and her tits hung free. One of them was sucking on her nipple. The other rose to his feet and unbuckled his trousers. Amanda fished his cock out, and it looked huge in her hand.

“Fuck, you’re big,” she said, just before leaning forward and taking that dark flesh into her mouth. She sucked until her cheeks caved in, pulled back, and released him with a prominent pop. “You going to skull fuck me with this big, black cock?”

She slowed down, enunciating those last few words.

“Hell, yeah I am.” He reached forward, collecting her dark braids in his hand.

Before he could pull her forward, she turned and looked at his friend. “Why don’t you stand and get your dick out, too. Blow bang me.”

“Shit, Sammy. Can you believe this?” the sitting guy said.

“Oh, I be-lieve.” Sammy, presumably, pulled Amanda’s face back to his large cock and thrust deep into her mouth. She took it with a choking gargle, staring up at him the whole time.

Meanwhile, the other guy squeezed her tit one last time—harder than I ever would have—and started stripping. Unlike the first guy, Sammy, this dude got completely naked, and I could see why. He was jacked. If I rippled with glossy muscle like that, I’d try to show it off as much as possible, too.

Amanda’s free hand immediately went to his dick, which was even longer than Sammy’s. Sammy released her head, giving her more freedom to shift between the two black dicks. She took to the freedom with evident delight, pumping the cocks together, sucking and spitting and lapping at them until they glistened with spit and pre-cum. When she sucked on them, she went deep, gagging as each cock entered her throat. Then she held it there, taking another inch, before pulling back swiftly and switching dicks.

Like all the times seeing her at The Gold Club, it was hard to reconcile this vixen with the woman I’d married. She wasn’t a passive participant in

the blowbang. She was the choreographer, teasing her fingernails over their balls, driving their cockheads against the inside of her cheeks until they bulged out. Spit drooled down her chin, frothy and thick, dribbling over her tits to mix with the sweat she'd started to build up.

Sammy stripped out of his shirt, too. He wasn't quite as cut as his friend, but made up for it in the tattoos that covered his dark skin.

Julia squirmed at my side. "That's so hot," she whispered. She brushed her hand along the front of my pants, squeezing my erection. "Let me help you with that, baby."

My response lagged like a bad signal. Julia was already sliding to her knees between my legs before I could stop her. This was wrong. She shouldn't do this. I glanced at Amanda, who was staring up at Sammy as she fought to swallow even more of his dick. I glanced over at Nikolai, as if he would judge me.

Another man had joined him, I was surprised to see, and the two were talking quietly to one another, like they were conducting business court side at a Lakers game, rather than at an orgy. I looked away, knowing now that I shouldn't stare, but not before I saw this new man pass something to Nikolai.

Julia opened my pants and fished out my cock. My attention snapped down to her, protest on my lips, only to see her glancing at Nikolai and his companion. I couldn't watch them discreetly, but from her angle, she sure could.

"I'm ready to *fuck*," Amanda announced, her voice husky from dick-sucking. She stood, hooked her thumbs into the remains of her dress, and shimmied out of it, leaving her in nothing but heels and her thong.

"Ray." Nikolai's voice exuded command. "Come."

She slipped past the two naked men, crossing the short distance to her lover. I suddenly realized how compromising my position was, especially when Julia wrapped her mouth around my cock. I nearly pushed her off, but Amanda didn't even look my way.

I looked, though. I couldn't take my eyes off of her. She was sloppy from all the fellating, her ripe tits glossy with saliva, sweat glistening on her high brow.

Nikolai fished a purple pill out of a baggie—the one that his companion had passed him. Jasmine. Jazz. "A new batch," he said. "Enjoy, my Raven."

She knew what to do, getting on her knees, opening her mouth, and sticking out her tongue. He placed the pill on her tongue like a priest handing out an unholy Eucharist wafer. Even after hearing her do coke during surveillance, and even after her confession the other morning, it was still shocking. With the cornrows and the easy nudity and the way she stared up at Nikolai from her knees, it struck me how far we'd come.

He pulled her close and kissed her. No way for her to fake swallowing the pill. No way to fake her way out of this. "Tell me how this one is," he said, pulling back. "Oleg tells me he tweaked the recipe. Calls it JazzEx."

She glanced at the man sitting at Nikolai's side. "Oleg, I presume?" The man didn't acknowledge that he was or not, but she pressed on. "Thank you for the last batch. A couple of the girls and I dropped them out at a club and ended up fucking all night."

Oleg stared at her, not understanding what she was saying. Nikolai said something in Russian, listened to Oleg speak, then said, "These will be even better," Handing her two more pills, he added, "For your new friends," before sitting back, ready for the show.

She turned away from us, holding a pill in each hand, high over her head, and wiggled her thong-clad ass. "You're going to love this shit," she said.

I popped off before I could help myself, the first to come of the group, emptying into Julia's slurping mouth. She diligently swallowed everything, staring up at me in all her blue-eyed, blond-haired glory.

Once she'd finished, she said, "Davey, Davey, Davey..." in the most condescending of ways. Somehow, that not being my name made me feel both better and worse about my situation. At least I could sink into my role as "Davey." "Guess I'll need to find other hard dicks to play with."

Amanda was back with her black friends, making out with Sammy as the other rolled her thong down her thighs. Her hands were all over their cocks, jerking them, readying them.

Julia left me. I figured that she'd join Amanda and the two guys. Instead, she strutted over to Kozlov and his friend. "You two just voyeurs? Or does one of you want to fuck me?"

With a few easy movements, her leopard-print dress pooled around her ankles and suddenly it was Julia I couldn't take my eyes off of. She was sexy the way pornstars just past their prime are—meaning she was sexy as hell. Her tits weren't real, but it worked with both her curves and her vibe.

Her navel was pierced. Her pussy was clean shaven, and another piercing glittered on her clit.

Kozlov seemed to translate her question to his friend, speaking in rapid Russian as the guy gazed at Julia. He was already sold, even before he learned what the offer was. He was younger than Nikolai, about my age, and built like a gorilla. His closely cropped hair and his frameless glasses, though, somehow softened his otherwise thuggish look.

Julia didn't wait for more affirmation. She again went to her knees, working open the guy's belt like she was desperate to get to her next meal. I felt the sting of jealousy, watching that—watching Amanda, too. Both my “wives” were with other men, and I was alone.

That didn't stop my smaller head from beginning to swell all over again.

Action on the bed drew my attention back there. Amanda had one knee up on the bed, the other planted on the floor, as she bent forward and bobbed along Sammy's dick. Behind her, the ripped guy with the bigger cock lined his condom-sheathed dick against her pussy. My breath caught. He didn't push into her though. Not right away. He rubbed against her wet pussy lips, teasing her until she tore her mouth off of Sammy's dick, looked over her shoulder, and said, “Just do it. Stretch me all out with that big dick of yours.”

I was jerking myself. I didn't care who was watching anymore, and a quick glance around confirmed that I wasn't alone. Even Nikolai now had his dick out, watching the show. Watching Amanda take one BBC in her pussy as another was rammed down her throat.

Maybe I should have felt jealousy as I watched. Maybe I should have been sick to my stomach as my wife's pussy stretched to accommodate that huge dick. Maybe I did, but it was all drowned out by fiery, violent excitement.

“She feel good, Deion?” Sammy asked his muscled friend. “She tight?”

“Feels so fuckin' good, man.” He slapped her ass. “And this booty? Not bad for a white chick.” Deion spanked her again, made an approving grunt, then started fucking her with force. That pushed her forward, into Sammy's crotch. She gagged hard, but incredibly didn't push away from him. She kept his dick in her throat, pinned on either end as they worked her body.

“Ah!” Julia's gasp drew my attention her way. She and Oleg had moved to the bed. He was on his back with the blond agent straddling him, his cock

sinking deep. I had descended all the way down the rabbit hole, witnessing these agents of the law break it in the name of the case.

Much like in a dream, time lost all meaning. I watched. I jerked off. At some point, someone had come back and refreshed my drink. Sammy and Deion took turns fucking Amanda, laying her on her back, legs up, pounding as the other rubbed his dick over her face.

The first time I watched Amanda come on another man's cock, I nearly came myself. Sammy was inside of her, holding her ankle against his shoulder as he drilled her. Her tits juddered. Her staccato cries filled the room, drawing everyone's eyes. Her audience grew beyond the four of us, and she seemed to know it.

"Yes! Yes! Fuck, you're so fucking big!" she cried when she didn't have the other guy's dick in her mouth. "I love it. I fuckin' love big... Uhh! Black... Nghh! Cock!"

She crested, her body arching, tits high, head thrown back as she screamed through her orgasm. Deion didn't slow. He didn't show her mercy, nor did she want it. He didn't come, either. He powered through her climax as his buddy moved into place to take his turn next.

At some point, a lifetime later, she arose from the tangle of limbs, covered in so much sweat it was like she was emerging from a pool. She glanced at her audience, which had grown considerably, pausing only a moment on me before she looked at Nikolai with a sly grin.

"Be right back, fellas," she said to Deion and Sammy. She went back to Nikolai, sliding into his lap, putting an arm around his neck and her free hand on his cock. "Enjoying the show?"

"Always. You are incredible," he said. He kissed her. "How is the jazz?"

"So good. I feel so fucking high."

"Thank you for sampling."

"You know I'd do *anything* for you, Nick."

"I hoped that you'd say that." He leaned in and whispered something to her that made her giggle. It was their intimacy, more than anything, that gnawed at me. Reaching into the inside pocket of his coat, he handed her something.

"Very naughty," she said. They kissed. "You know I've wanted this..."

Amanda sauntered back to the bed with a confidence that belied her nakedness. She commanded attention, and everyone around her watched. "You two are in for a treat," she announced—not just to Sammy and Deion,

but to her audience as well. “My boyfriend wants to watch me experience my first ever double penetration.” She put a hand on her cocked hip. With her other, she held up the thing that Nikolai had given her—a bottle of lube. “You two up for it?”

The way the two guys looked at each other was priceless, from their shit-eating grins to the way each puffed his chest out, trying to look cool as they slowly jacked themselves.

“You ever had a brother up your ass?” Deion asked.

“Oh yeah,” Amanda said. “I love a black dick in my butt, although...” She reached out and stroked him. “...never had one quite this big.”

She actually did a pirouette, like some kind of raunchy ballerina, as she twirled back down to her knees and sucked him. “Think I can take it?” she asked.

“Let’s find out.”

She was already squirting the lube all over that big dick of his. “On the bed,” she said to Sammy. “Get on your back and get that big, beautiful dick ready.”

Kozlov sniffed another sprinkle of coke off the back of his hand. Julia was on her side, watching the setup as Nikolai’s acquaintance spooned behind her, slowly pumping into her. Others were in the chairs and sofas around us, on other tiers of the bed, all watching this exchange.

Amanda rose up, folding her tits around Deion’s lubed up cock, and gave him a brief titty fuck as she met his eyes. “A slippery dick always feels good between my tits,” she said. “But it’s gonna feel even better in my ass.”

At full height, she grabbed the back of Deion’s head and kissed him passionately. She was about to get fucked hard, but she was in complete control.

I had the perfect angle to watch as she climbed onto Sammy and eased his dick into her pussy. I shuddered at how good that looked—his black flesh spreading her pink, shaved slit. When she glanced over her shoulder, I perked up, expecting her to check in with me. Instead, her eyes went to Kozlov’s, seeking approval and getting it with a short nod from her gangster boyfriend.

Jealousy coiled in my gut.

“She with you?” a woman asked, pulling me out of my trance. At some point, another couple had joined me on my sofa and I hadn’t noticed. She

was a sexy redhead, still wearing a skirt but now topless, straddling a guy and facing out.

“Uh, no...” I stuttered. Right, I needed to remember who I was with—who I *was*. I was Davey. I was here with Gillian, my wife. And the woman on the bed, about to get DPed, was Amanda. “I’m with the blonde, but what’s about to happen...” I shrugged.

“Is intense,” the redhead agreed. “I don’t blame you for looking.”

The guy behind her palmed her full, freckle-dusted tits. “You remember when we did that to you?”

“I’ll never forget.”

I turned back to the bed, where Deion was just now aiming his dick at Amanda’s asshole. She was actually holding her butt cheeks apart for him, watching him over her shoulder. I could still see Sammy’s dick in her, glossy with their juices. I could see Deion put pressure against her backdoor, see her shiver as the pressure built and built until—

“Oh, fuck!” she cried. “Oh, fuck, I feel so... I’m so... so fucking full!” She cried louder. “Your dicks... your fucking dicks... fuck me with both fucking dicks!”

What started so slowly got intense very fast. Amanda wasn’t a stranger to anal sex, and neither, apparently, was Deion. He let her adjust to his size. He let her adjust to having two cocks in both holes. Then, grabbing her by the hips, he began to pound her ass as hard as his buddy was fucking her pussy.

“I’m coming!” hissed the redhead beside me. Or maybe it was Julia on the bed. Or one of so many people around me, having sex. All the moans, all the cries and gasps, all the squeals suddenly felt overwhelming to me. Amanda wasn’t the center of any of this, I realized. She was just one of many, seeking pleasure.

Kozlov’s buddy—the man who brought the new batch of drugs—had tipped Julia back up onto her hands and knees. Only now, they’d been joined by a third—the girl with the bubblegum pink ombré and the tequila shots was there, now completely naked. She was splayed out before Julia, legs open, as Julia did what she’d teased earlier: she was eating the tequila girl’s pussy.

As hot as that was, for me, it all paled against the sight of Amanda getting double fucked. She was out of her mind with it. “Oh...ohh fuuuck!” I could hear her over the soundscape of sex all around me, her familiar

voice spewing things I never dreamed she'd say. "Oh, fuck my ass, fill my holes... just like that, just like that! Ahh!"

I was jerking off without shame now. So was Kozlov. So was the man who'd been fucking the redhead beside me, who had now joined the fray on the bed.

"Do you like that, Nicky?" Amanda cried. "It's so much better with real cocks. Only need one more to really plug me up. Can I? Can I have one more cock, baby?"

I looked to the Russian. He was completely under her spell. I envied him, holding my breath as I waited for him to join her.

But he didn't. Instead, Amanda looked at me. Like directly at me. She smirked. "You. Come closer and I'll give you the most intense blowjob you'll ever have."

I actually looked behind me, then at the guy who'd been with the redhead. He chuckled. "Think she's talking to you, Bud, but I'm happy to go as your surrogate."

I was already up out of my sofa, stripping off my shirt. This was probably a dream that I was about to wake up from, but how was that different from anything else in my life? And like with all of those times, I wasn't about to second guess it.

Climbing onto the bed, I got a very clear glimpse of the DP—two thick, black cocks pistoning in and out of my wife, one in, the other out, like a literal fuck machine. Sensing my approach, she glanced my way, eyelids heavy with bliss. When she looked at me, though, the pretense fell away. Amanda, Raven or Ray or whoever she was, she was my partner, my love, and I was hers.

"Not a bad cock for a white guy," she said. It was a tease, playful the way old Amanda played. "Just big enough to choke on, eh, guys?"

"Plug her up," Deion said from behind her. He spanked her ass, now red from his palm. "Give the lady what she craves."

What she craves. That's exactly what Amanda wanted. The tough-as-nails, by-the-numbers federal agent craved this over-the-top sex, and she'd recruited me to play. I groaned as she wrapped her lips around my dick.

"She's good, ain't she?" Sammy said from the bed. "Grab her head. Use her. She likes it."

I hesitated, but only for a moment. I was Davey, not David. I was just another guy here for casual, no-strings-attached sex, and the sweat-coated

brunette beneath me wanted to be used.

I swear she smiled around my dick as I cupped her head and started directing her up and down my length. Amanda being Amanda, just as she did whenever we hit the dance floor, she subtly took the lead, forcing more of my dick down her throat. It looked like I was bouncing her on my cock, forcing her to grunt and gag, but that was all her.

Airtight. Never in my life did I think I'd ever do this—and especially not with Amanda. It was so raw. So real. So raunchy. She started to come, drawing out of my grip to suck air in through her nose as she shuddered through a powerful orgasm.

Deion was next, pulling free of her gaping asshole. He ripped his condom off and popped a load all over her back. Sammy, beneath her, couldn't escape to do the same. Instead, he grabbed her by the ass, pulling her onto him so his dick was deep, and filled his own latex sheath as he grunted.

Amanda's orgasms rolled. She went back to my dick, jerking it, looking up at me. "Do it. Come all over my face. I want it." She opened her mouth and stuck her tongue out, blinking her long lashes up at me, ready to receive.

My first blast caught her on the cheek, just below her eye. She didn't flinch. Second hit her chin. Third found its mark, right on her tongue, before my stream started to weaken. She sucked me back into her mouth to finish milking me before I could fully beg off.

"Thank you," she said, sitting back at last. I knew we weren't talking about her facial. It was all of this.

"Oh, no," I said. "Thank *you*."

"Or maybe thank *me*?" commented Julia, reinserting herself into the conversation. "After all, it *was* my husband's cock that you were sucking."

There was definitely a palpable animosity between these two. Even here, in the lion's den.

Amanda's eyes lingered on me as she said, "Why yes. Thank you. He's quite special." She turned midway through the sentence and kissed Julia on the lips. My come smeared into Julia's face. It was a power move, but not one that the blonde was going to back down from. She kissed Amanda back, just as hardcore, their tongues jousting.

"You taste like pussy," Amanda said. "Yummy."

Julia lapped the strand of come from Amanda's cheek. "And you taste like my husband." She glanced at me. "Look at that Davey. You finally got to play with the slut you've been eye-fucking all night. Too bad you didn't get her ass, but I bet that like me, she saves it for real men."

Julia slipped off the bed and picked up her dress. "Come now. Time for us to go. I love a good, hard reclaiming."

That last sentence was directed at Amanda, who let it roll off of her. Amanda just smiled and said, "Ditto. And eventually, when mine comes, it's going to be epic."

OceanofPDF.com

BACK TO NORMAL

“How are you holding up?”

Julia and I were in the car, heading along Highway 1. This time I got to sit up front, windows down, letting the wind cool my overheated body.

I glanced at Julia, her golden hair fluttering like a model at a shoot. She was pretty. She felt more real, despite the over-the-top stuff I’d watched happen that night. I saw her flaws. I saw her as a person.

“That was intense,” I said. “But...”

“Never thought you’d see Amanda do those things.” When Julia finished my thought, it wasn’t laced with the usual ridicule or mockery. She was just making a statement.

“Never in a million years.”

“She was doing it for the cover,” Julia said.

“Not just the cover.” We both knew the truth now. “She was into it.”

Julia didn’t give me an out. “Yes, she was. But also, I think you had something to do with that. I think she got off knowing that you were watching her. I’m honestly not sure that she could have done what she did without you there. I’ve never seen her so into it.”

We drove in silence for a bit as I thought about that. I remembered the way Amanda had looked at me at the end, and the way she and Julia bantered around me. I didn’t feel like an outsider anymore.

“What comes next?” I asked.

Julia glanced across at me before going back to the road. I wondered if her good will towards me had run out. I wasn’t actually part of this investigation, after all. But she surprised me. “I planted a tracker on that guy, Oleg. With any luck, he’ll guide us right back to his lab. If nothing else, though, we have a fresh lead.”

“And Amanda?”

“It’s fluid. We’ll pull her as soon as we know it’s safe. The club will probably close, so that’ll be a natural break. Raven keeps her cover, just in case...”

“Just in case?” I asked.

“One thing I’ve learned, you can never be too prepared. She won’t be a witness, she won’t need to testify, but who knows? Maybe something goes sideways. We may still have a use for Raven yet.”

So this wasn’t over. Not yet.

We drove up to my apartment building, and it felt odd, saying goodbye to her after such an intense experience. “You make a pretty good husband. Look me up if things don’t work out in your life.” She grinned. “Or even if they do. You’ve earned your right to play around.”

With that, Julia drove away, leaving me more confused than ever.

A week later, the bust was all over the news. The FBI had found an extensive lab hidden just outside of the city, from which all the jasmine was flowing. More importantly, the chief cook of the operation was apprehended, too, a man named Oleg Kuznetsov, along with all of his lieutenants.

I ate up the news, constantly refreshing CNN and the LA Times site. I never watched news on television anymore, but I did with this story, following it as it unfolded on prime time. Bradley Hirsch was at the center of it all, eating up the media spotlight, holding press conferences, taking all the credit.

They raided the Gold Club. That was covered on the news, federal agents going in and taking out boxes and papers, but no one was actually arrested there, and Nikolai Kozlov’s name was never mentioned. When Hirsch was asked about the club’s connection, he just said that it was all part of an ongoing investigation, but that they were close to wrapping things up.

I watched the footage of that particular bust and consumed every news article about it. In addition to Nikolai being a ghost, Amanda was never present. Julia and Misty also weren't ever present during any of the media outings. This was the Bradley Hirsch Show now. It was Miami all over again—same bureaucratic scene stealing, different actors.

THREE DAYS after Oleg was arrested, Amanda returned to me. She wasn't dolled up like Raven. She wasn't even some hybrid version, like Nikolai's girlfriend. She was Amanda, my wife, my partner, my whole world.

She was waiting for me in the open door of our garden apartment when I got home from work, arms crossed, leaning against the doorframe. She was barefoot, wearing capri-length jeans and a loose blouse. The cornrow braids were gone, and she had a headband holding back her flowing, dark hair.

I ascended the stairs, wondering if this was an apparition. When she detached herself from the doorframe, meeting me halfway, she felt real enough. When I started to say something, she gently folded her arms around my neck and kissed me. It was a sweet, lingering kiss, the kind we shared all the time before her assignment.

She pulled back, but didn't step away. "You didn't change the locks," she said.

"Locksmith wasn't free until next week."

Amanda laughed low and soft. "Lucky me then." She rubbed her nose to mine and whispered, "And I really am lucky."

My wife took my hand, pulling me inside. I felt as nervous as I did the first time Amanda and I got together. Which made sense. This was new. In so many ways, this was a different Amanda—an exciting one, a spicy one, an edgy one. I thought of Ty and his flippant remark from a conversation that felt like a million years ago—*you have a stripper for a wife*. A stripper and so much more.

She pulled me to the couch, sat me on the edge, and climbed into my lap. I couldn't help but think of her persona as a stripper, and yet this didn't *feel* like that. It just felt like Amanda when she had sex on the brain.

We made out like that, beyond the need for words, getting reacquainted with each other. I opened her blouse. She stripped off my shirt and tie. Her bra went next with an easy twist.

Despite the normality, I could see the differences, the changes. Amanda was leaner, stronger, definitely more tanned. She wore a thong beneath her jeans, and when she shimmied out of jeans and thong alike, that move was definitely infused with stripper confidence. And of course, she was still shaved or waxed smooth—and quite recently, I discovered, as I sank into her slippery embrace.

This was the moment that I'd been waiting for since she went undercover. This was the homecoming that I'd dreamt of, one that built and built with each new revelation. Call it a reunion or a reclamation. I called it release.

The smiles gave way to passion. I got lost in the sound of Amanda's gasps, in the rise and fall of her body on mine. She felt both fragile and strong, like a steel wire stretched taut. She didn't always fuck this way. She cradled my head to her cleavage, skin against skin, close enough to feel her heart beating. I kissed her neck. I squeezed her hips. I cupped her ass cheeks.

We were a team again. Together, we were the rider and the ridden. We still had things to work through, but we finally had the space to begin.

We climaxed together, with me pumping her hard, filling her as she cried out and clutched my head to her body. "Oh, yes, David... David..."

"Welcome home, Amanda."

She didn't get out of my lap. She stayed there, straddling me, my dick still semi-erect. "And I promise you, this is where I want to be." She nuzzled my nose with hers again. "I joked about you changing the locks, but I'm serious. I... I put you through a lot."

"You put *us* through a lot," I said.

"I know I did. They say hindsight's 20-20, but I was scared, and somehow I convinced myself that it was all done for this assignment and nothing more. I thought about my dad wasting away after Mom died, and all the young kids ODing on this shit, and... and it was still wrong. I know that."

A tear rolled down her cheek, and she brushed it away like it annoyed her.

I thought of all that she'd done—the men, the sex, the cheating, the betrayal. Then I looked at Amanda, broken yet still strong, vulnerable to me in a way that she never showed to others. She was no longer the exemplar of justice and the right thing to do—a version of this woman that I'd hoisted onto a pedestal and lived in the shadow of the entire time I'd known her. She was just another person, flawed and prone to making mistakes. Could I forgive her?

"From here on out, we need to do this together," I said. "No more secrets. No more omissions. Hopefully by now, you know that I can take it."

I thought about her getting double-teamed by those two guys last week, and started to harden inside of her. I thought of how she teased Nikolai Kozlov about her exploits, and how turned on that made me, too.

Amanda felt it, her eyes flaring.

"It turns me on hearing about what a slut Raven got to be," I admitted. "The thing that stung was that I was never a part of that. And another man was."

"I'm sorry for that. It wasn't real. Ever. I *had* to sell it."

"That was *all* an act?" I brushed her cheek. "I'm not talking about the easy stuff, the words. It's what I saw. The easy familiarity. The way you *looked* at him. The way you leaned into his touch." I winced at the memory. She saw it.

"Everything hinged on Nick—on *Kozlov* buying—it. *Everything*. And... and I was too driven to realize what it was doing to you. And I'm so fucking sorry for that. Not going to make that mistake again," she said. "But do you know the worst part? The biggest challenge? Once we talked and you made it clear we were in this together, performing *for* you without staring *at* you the entire time was so hard."

I blinked. She went on.

"Especially with the way your eyes kept boring straight into me every single time I was able to steal a glance!"

"And here I thought I was being subtle," I said. "I guess Julia was right about that."

"Forget about her," Amanda said. She leaned into me, pressing against me. "Wanna know my secret, how I managed to fake all that with him?" She murmured in my ear. "Muscle memory."

"I don't get it."

She pressed her mouth against my neck. “Remember me telling you how hard I trained to be credible as a stripper?”

I nodded. She nipped at my ear.

“Sorta the same thing. The mission was everything. Seducing Kozlov was the key to getting access. So I focused on that. Blocked everything else out. Leaned into the sex, played the role of the hedonist bad girl. Then I’d go back to that lonely apartment and drink myself stupid, obsessing about you and how I could never let you know if I harbored any hope of keeping you.”

“That’s why you tried to back out once you knew *I knew*.”

Her turn to nod. “And the only reason I was able to get back on the Raven Express was because I knew you’d approve.”

“The Raven Express”? My cock twitched. Judging from her reaction she felt it. Then she reached down without breaking eye contact, and began to deftly and expertly stroke me.

I definitely wasn’t wilting anymore. Amanda guided me into her, and I immediately felt her pussy tighten around me. I shuddered at the pressure. That was a new move for her. At one point in time, my mind would have taken that revelation down a dark path. Now, ever so tentatively, I looked forward to learning more.

Thinking about what I’d heard while on surveillance with Julia, how she’d regaled Kozlov with her exploits in the backroom, I asked, “So the next time you have enthusiastic analingus, you’ll tell me?”

“I’ll tell you both giving *and* receiving,” she said with a snort. “Remember when I said before that I was surprised at my own strong reaction to pleasing men? Turning them on? Getting them raring to go? Well, every time I did something like that—”

“Ass-licking.” I was growing harder and harder, even as we dove into this wild and once totally out-of-bounds topic.

She suppressed a grin and ducked her head. “Yes, like *ass-licking*... every time I got a big reaction from something like that, I couldn’t stop thinking about what it might be like to try it with you...and then I’d think about how afraid I was that you would get grossed out by the things I found turned me on.”

“Like ass-licking.”

She swatted my shoulder but continued as if I hadn’t said anything. “Then when you told me the thought of me getting wild in the sack got you

going, well... all I have been able to think about since you said that is how I can't *wait* to do all of these things with you."

"I can get behind that."

She wiggled her eyebrows. "Your world will be *rocked*." My cock pulsed, deep and fully erect inside of her. "And *that* response," she said, "is gonna rock *mine*!"

"What about the drugs? What about when you were on the jazz?"

She smirked at how I phrased it. "It's just 'jazz'. And even then, I was never out of it. It just made everything feel really fucking good. I get why people are ODing on it. A little bit goes a *long* way."

"And the coke?"

"A necessary evil. Nikolai Kozlov never gets high on his own supply, but he certainly indulges in the adjacent supply—and he loves watching hot girls do it, too. At first I thought it was just a power move. Probably mostly is. But it really got him going."

"And you're not addicted, are you?"

"I was able to minimize it."

"How do you mean?"

"You'd be surprised how unobservant a guy with a burgeoning coke problem can be."

I continued to look at her, waiting for her to elaborate further.

"Nick's a hedonist, but he's also a greedy fucker. He sees himself as the founder of the feast, and I guess Russians tend to ignore what Miss Manners said about avoiding gluttony at your own party. Most of the coke he 'gave' me wound up on the floor or sprinkled theatrically on the head of his dick as part of yet another blowjob."

My cock twitched again. She grinned at me, slipping out of my lap. I whined as my dick left her pussy, but only long enough for her to move to the floor between my legs and take my dick in her hand. "I'd start it off like this," she said, stroking me slowly. "Up... and down..." She wrapped her lips around me next, bobbing along my length lazily, her eyes on me the whole time. "Up... and down... really sloppy..." She licked the head of my dick. "Get him nice and juicy..."

I gasped, watching her please me, yet seeing her doing it for another man.

"Then I'd put all that coke on his cockhead. He'd go numb from it entering his bloodstream, and that blowjob became a handjob... just

working it in...”

I let out a slow exhale as I pictured her at work on another man’s cock.

“By the time I went back to blowing him, most of it was gone.” She sucked my dick again, as if to demonstrate, and I blew out another long breath.

I finally was able to find words. “Sprinkling it on his junk, that was inspired.”

She slurped up off of me. “I can’t take credit for that. Julia suggested it as both a way to keep from doing too much but also to get him feeling more positively towards me.”

“Julia...” My mind flashed back to the blowjob she gave me in the club.

“Has a lot of experience,” Amanda finished for me. “But of course, you know that.”

I heard the jealousy there. We were both thinking about the same thing. I almost apologized, but then why should I? No one was innocent here. Then Amanda surprised me.

“It was actually a real eye-opener, scorchingly hot, watching her with you,” she admitted. “Probably helped that I was riffing hard on jazz in the moment, but you know what I thought at the time?”

“I have no idea,” I admitted.

“I thought about how hot it would be to watch you fuck the shit out of her. Put her in her place.”

I laughed. “Never thought that we’d have this conversation together.”

“And I’m so happy that we can.” She squeezed my dick.

“What’s next for Amanda?”

“Mandatory, bureaucratic bullshit,” she said. “Mandatory detox. Mandatory shrinks. Mandatory R&R.”

“And is *this* mandatory?”

Amanda softened, casting aside her bitterness. She snaked her hand down to play with my balls. “Mandatory Bureau procedure? No. But mandatory for me to demo my slutty blowjob technique for my loving, patient, sex-god-of-a-husband over and over and over again until he says I’ve perfected it?” She leaned forward and swirled her tongue around my cockhead. “Absolutely.”

Her head, however, went even lower. She was on a mission. Pushing my legs open and pressing my erection against my stomach, she dove down between my ass cheeks.

“Uhh, fuck, Amanda...” I groaned as she tongued my asshole.

“We’ll do that later,” she said. “Right now, I have a promise to keep.”

I didn’t last long. The sensation of her soft tongue on my asshole was unlike anything I’d ever felt. When she got her hand into it, stroking my shaft, I realized how expert her technique was. She had experience, and I was just the latest recipient.

She even knew when I was about to come. Unlatching herself from between my cheeks, she pointed my dick right at her face. I thought of the last time we were together, in the Master Bedroom, when she told me to come all over her face as she straddled a black stud’s dick. That had been for show. This time, as I painted her pretty face with my come, and saw the pure delight in her expression, I knew this was for us.

“Well that was fun,” she said, hopping up. “I’m going to jump in the shower and wash myself off.” She started for the bathroom, saying, “Then, you know what I’m in the mood for?”

I honestly had no idea. Was this how little I knew my wife now? “What’s that?”

“Let’s get dinner at Fridays. I’m craving something really unhealthy.”

I laughed. “Sounds great.”

Amanda walked into the bedroom, and I followed close behind. “So you’re not going right into a new assignment?” I asked. “*Not working* is going to kill you.”

I heard Amanda chuckle as she rooted through her things on the bed. “I was thinking the two of us could get away. ‘Not work’ together.”

There were still so many things to talk about. The road ahead wasn’t a smooth or straight one, but I realized that I *wanted* there to be more ahead. “I like the sound of that.”

Entering the bedroom, I saw her standing with her back to me, frozen in place. My body went cold as fear licked up through me. She was holding something, staring at it as I approached.

On the bed was Amanda’s bag, unzipped and spilling the contents of her life as Raven. Everything was small, tight, lacy, or some combination thereof. There was a makeup kit. A small vibrator. A toiletries bag. In her hand, she held a phone that I didn’t recognize, the black case imprinted with a sunburst that matched her tanning bed tattoo—Raven’s burner phone.

“What?” I asked.

Amanda jumped, not realizing that I was right there. She turned to me, her eyes wide and guarded, and for a moment, I wondered if she wouldn't share. Instead, she held the phone out for me to take.

I took it from her gingerly, like it was a bomb. My hands shook as I glanced at the message on the screen.

I must see you, solntse. I can't trust anyone else.

"Is this...?" I began, but I knew. I heard those words ring in my ears, delivered in a confident, cruel, Russian accent.

Amanda nodded. When I opened my mouth to ask something else, though, she shook her head curtly, silencing me. Taking my hand, she led me into the bathroom. When I started to pull away, though, her grip tightened and she shot me an insistent look over her shoulder.

Her face was still covered in my come, and this would have been humorous in any other situation. Instead, it felt like the world was falling out from beneath my feet. I had no idea what was going on.

She turned the shower on and stepped beneath the spray, washing her face at last. I didn't follow her in, squatting down on my haunches as I tried to get my bearings. I felt dizzy. I felt confused.

Amanda looked amazing, rising above me like a nymph as water cascaded down her curvy, naked form. Her legs were so long, her heart-shaped ass so taut. Her skin that had once been pale, but now was definitely bronzed all over. Those big tits, full and almost out of proportion with the rest of her, peeked around her svelte back.

And of course, there was the tattoo, a raven perched above her tailbone, beak slightly raised as if observing something over its shoulder, all styled in black, tribal swirls. Rinsing her hair and face, she gestured for me to join her.

"What's going on?" I said as I stepped under the spray.

When she spoke, it was so soft that I almost missed it under the sound of the water around us. "Sorry, I'm probably being paranoid, but we can't be too careful."

I furrowed my brow, not following.

"Someone could be listening," she said, glancing around the room. *A bug?* I thought. *A microphone.*

"Someone bugged our apart—"

"Maybe," she said, cutting me off. "I... I don't know."

"Who?"

She shook her head. “Maybe no one. I’m not sure.”

I closed my eyes and leaned back against the shower tile, away from Amanda. “What the fuck’s going on, babe? That message—”

“Is from Kozlov. That phone’s my Raven burner. We kept the cover intact because—”

“Because you can never be too prepared,” I said. “Yes, I know. Julia told me.”

Amanda sighed at the mention of her handler’s name. “He hasn’t contacted me since things went down, David. You have to believe me.”

I wanted to—and I did. Mostly. But then I remembered the way they’d looked at one another, how willingly subservient she’d been with him, the way they’d kissed, and it became difficult.

“You’re not going to report the message, are you?” I concluded. “Why not?”

Amanda hesitated, and a drip of cold insecurity ran down my spine. Was she worried about him? Had she fallen for him?

“There’s something going on here, and I’m trying to figure it out,” she said slowly.

I raised my brows at her, growing more impatient. “What?”

I saw the guarded look, the way she wouldn’t quite meet my eyes, the way she spoke in ambiguities. This was how she got when talking about all her other cases. This is how she’d been in the months preceding this one. This was why we found ourselves in the unhealthy place we currently occupied. Before I could press, though, she opened up first.

She clutched my upper arms and pulled me close. “I think there’s more going on here than just a criminal investigation. Something just seems... off.”

“With what?”

“I’m still working through that part. I want to find out. I... I *need* to find out...”

It was almost like the old Amanda—determined, ready to take on the world. Given my new understanding of what Amanda was capable of, it scared me. Only there was a hesitancy now. Her blue eyes wavered as she gazed up at me.

She stepped closer, pressed up against me, reaching up a hand and touching my face. “But only if you’ll do this with me,” she said quietly. “If you want to walk away, I’ll call this in. I’ll tell them about Kozlov. I’m sure

Hirsch would love to bring him in and add another scalp to his belt. We can be David and Amanda again.”

“You’d do that? After everything?”

“For *you*? For *us*? *Yes*.” I knew she wasn’t lying.

I nodded, processing it all.

I might have been a bit thick sometimes, and maybe too trusting for my own good too much of the time, but if I knew anything about my wife and about myself and about our marriage, I knew that in the long run, letting this go wouldn’t work for *us* because it didn’t work for *her*.

And I wanted us to work out.

“Okay,” I said. “Let’s find out what’s going on with your investigation.”

Her eyes widened, and her smile followed shortly after.

“Together,” we said it in unison

“But first,” I said, running my thumb up her cheekbone. She turned into the touch and kissed the palm of my hand. “You’ve still got some of my jazz on your cheek.”

I felt her hand clamp on my balls—not painfully, more like she was showing ownership. “It’s ‘jizz.’ Not ‘jazz.’” She sighed theatrically as she leaned in for another kiss, all while giving my balls a firm tug. “I can already see that I’m going to have my hands full breaking you in.”